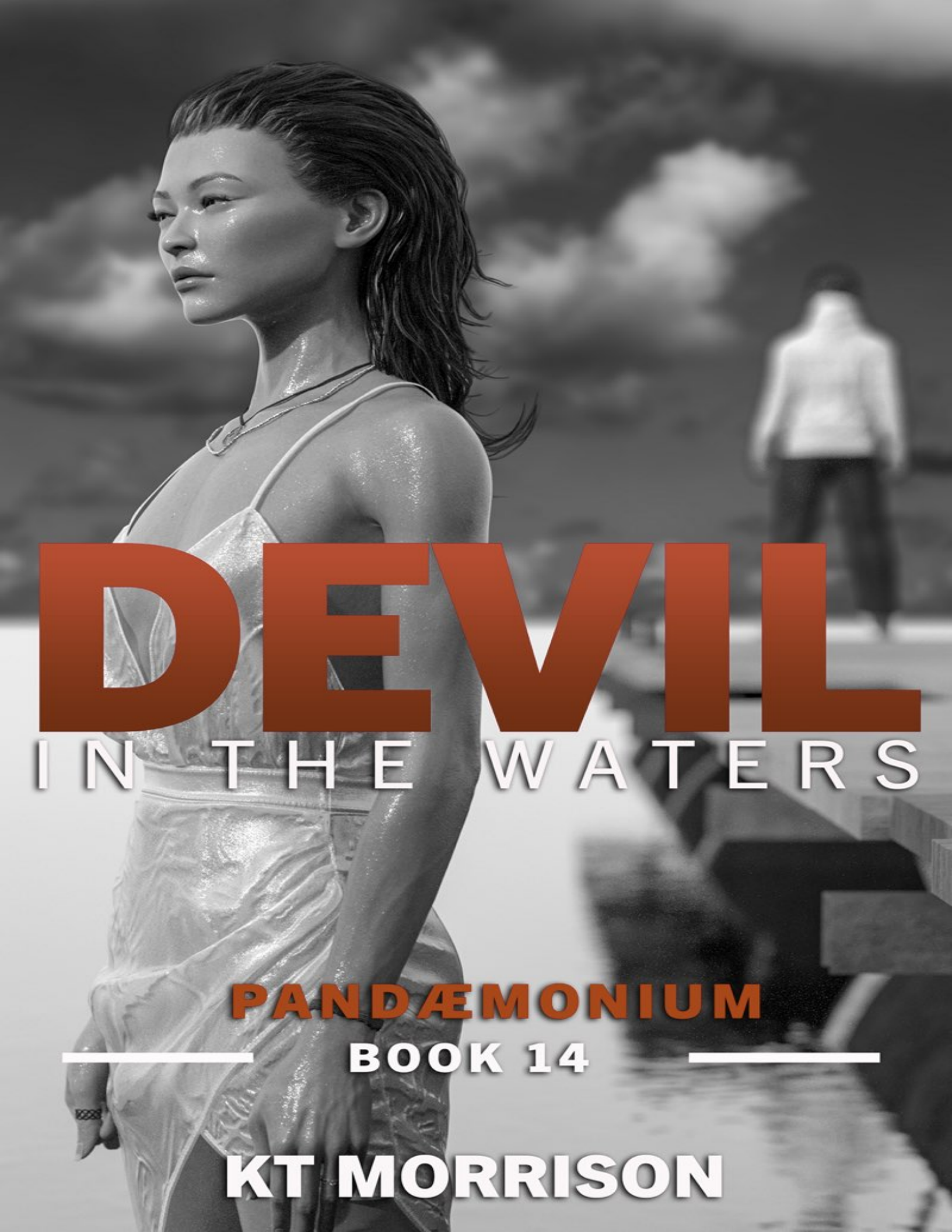




DEVIL

IN THE WATERS

PANDÆMONIUM

BOOK 14

KT MORRISON

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This is a work of fiction. Similarities to real people, places, or events are entirely coincidental.

All characters are over the age of eighteen.

PANDÆMONIUM

A DEVIL IN THE WATERS Novel

53,000 words

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Written by KT Morrison

Cover by KT Morrison

FOREWORD

Devil in the Waters is an ongoing Patreon serial. The Patrons decide how long the serial will be through their wonderful engagement. I collect episodes approximately every 30k words and publish them as ebooks in the marketplaces.

One can subscribe to my lowest Patreon tier and read every single word of Devil in the Waters. If one waited until the series is finished, they could subscribe to the lowest tier for one month and read the whole thing, beginning to end. The higher tiers even provide downloadable ebooks as well.

This has been a fantastic, epic journey with these characters, that I've loved (and hated) writing. While this isn't yet the last book, we are so close to the end, as a reader will realize when they read this 14th book.

Many thanks to my supporters on Patreon who make this kind of long form epic possible. I could never do a project this challenging without their support!

* * *

ktmorrison.com

On my [Patreon](#) and on my [Ream](#) you can have access to chapters as they are written (and all the previous ones, too), and see artwork from the KT universe of stories—even NSFW ones!

CHAPTER 1

FIT HAUNT OF GODS

TUESDAY, SEPTEMBER 29

When the video got to the end it played over again.

Kimmy lay in bed at home, the sun going down, Josh at Meyer's, twelve hours after she'd left for work this morning. Left for work and performed the most depraved act of her life. And she rewatched it, naked under the covers, toes grabbing the sheets, humping her hips against her pleasuring fingers. She held the phone playing the video on her sternum, the image going up and down with her heaving breath. Quiet coughs came as she got closer again. This would be the fourth time she came while watching what she'd done to Devlin. Right now she focussed on her hand in the video, and the way her fingers curved Devlin's thick cock, and how Devlin had pumped out an endless supply of pre-cum for her hand job. That perfect big cock shone in the light, wet steely flesh, and as her orgasm rose closer and closer to where she could feel its pressure expanding her ribcage, she closed her eyes and pictured what she knew came next. She'd watched this video eleven times since this afternoon. With her eyes closed she could still see the white rim light on those luscious cock curves, those pink and gray flesh shapes, the bulging swells of his perfect cock head, knowing what that thing felt like inside her, deep, deep inside her, knowing what the flared rim of his cock head felt like plunging in and out, buried in her guts. And she knew the feel of his ejaculation. Not the pulsing, but the flexing as his cock

spurted its joy right in the mouth of her cervix, beyond it, by Devlin's claim, and then that flooding wet and the silvery sensation of orgasm and an almost unbearable swell of lusty desire that made her squirt every time. And this time she did come that way, squirting, all by herself, all alone in her apartment, abandoned by the man who'd witnessed the basest lust she enjoyed. She cursed and hissed and curled her feet into balls, listening to the patter under the bedsheets as she spritzed out exquisite glee. She dropped the phone to her bare stomach, panting and gasping, putting a forearm over her eyes. Her body shuddered, her stomach fluttered, and the slightest movement of her long fingers inside her would send her over again. She had to ease them out before she succumbed once more to the worst thing a woman on the edge of losing her marriage could do.

The intensity of this experience was something she wanted to share with Josh. Wanted him to know about it. There was this rotten tug to send him the video, saying to him, "Look what I did." And, fuck, Josh would come just as hard as she did. She was sure of it. But Josh had wrapped himself in some newfound nobility she didn't like at all. It put a barrier between them. His moral certitude slipped Devlin between them like a big fat flesh colored chess piece with a delicious mushroom head that she wanted to suck on right now. She groaned and cursed herself again. She was so fucking horny over this. It was rotten. And where was Josh? Not here. Josh had made her confessions and her admissions into things he could wield over her, using the sin even he enjoyed as a weapon in an effort to control her. His reaction was natural and made sense to a rational mind, but their alignment in kink and pleasure had showed Josh's inner joy to her. He hated how it pleased him and he wanted to hurt her instead of submitting to the things that aroused him.

What was the way to show him it was okay? Tell him he was loved even if he was aroused by something that was the antithesis of every male

instruction passed on down through the years. That's what was holding him back. Flimsy tendons of yore.

But the solution wasn't easy. Josh was a volatile opponent when you compared him to Devlin. And not just volatile. The stakes were high with Josh. Josh mattered. She loved Josh. They were married.

She growled with the compounding frustration and the growing dread. Everything had become more complicated by a factor of ten. She'd known going into this thing there would be obstacles, but everything seemed now to tighten around her, every move she made spawning newer tentacles that lashed her back, constricted her, pulled her deeper where maybe she would drown.

With that she was off the bed, stepping into the bathroom and washing her hands. Then she stripped the bed and changed the sheets.

The lure of the phone was strong. Not to do the most sensible thing, like use it to reach out to her hurting husband, but to watch the video one more time. There was a pull from down below, a nagging tug. She wanted to masturbate again. It grew stronger, and images flashed in her mind showing her the most arousing and nefarious thing a woman could do. And Devlin's incredible dick...

She shook her hands out and exhaled, pushing back against the looming height of dirty thoughts and nasty images.

Later, on her phone on the couch, she checked Josh's location again on Find My Phone. He wasn't at Meyer's now. He was still in town. Maybe him and Meyer going out to eat or to see a movie. Sophie would be with them. It was getting late on a school night for Sophie to be away from home. Josh was on his own somewhere?

She checked her texts. Re-read the half dozen from Hyun that she hadn't responded to yet with more than a heart reaction. She could go to Hyun's. Sophie wasn't there. Maybe they could spend the night together.

And then came the infernal horniness again. Imagining herself in bed with Hyun, doing the things that Hyun liked her to do, trying to coax Hyun into doing some of the things she liked to do. Her stomach dropped and her sex throbbed with the sudden raw thought of showing Hyun the video, of making her watch the vilest thing that poor innocent thing would ever have seen. Hyun looking at the size and beauty of a massive cock, watching how much Devlin came, how it splattered and sprayed.

"Fuck," she hissed, standing up, aching between her hips, thinking she might just go to the bedroom and do it again.

Not on the fresh sheets though.

She sat back down, sighing, mind racing and twisting, trying to get away from the sexual tugging, checking Josh's location again. Same place. She looked it up. A hotel.

"Josh, don't do that," she whispered. "I don't want you to be alone."

She sighed and looked up at the ceiling, hoping he wasn't hurting too much. The horniness waned, and she smiled. Feelings of love and affection ebbed up from nowhere to replace it.

Later in the week he'd stay with Meyer. He wasn't ready to tell his cousin his marriage to Kimmy was over. Didn't even know how to word it. Didn't want to say it.

And why was that?

The answer was simple. He would miss her. He would miss being with her. It was like ending their marriage would be an act of aggression. Something done to punish Kimmy. To hurt her. Hurt her because she'd hurt

him. But then he could picture himself without Kimmy. Picture himself alone, Kimmy moving on, having success, having a baby. His baby.

His baby, right?

“Maybe,” he said, and dropped to the Best Western bed, looking up at the ceiling. The television was on but muted and he didn’t even know how to watch anything. All the channels were different from when he was home. He only had his phone, not his tablet, and he didn’t like watching things on that small of a screen.

What if it *was* his baby?

What if right now Kimmy grew their child in her belly and he was lying in a hotel room a mile away from her, wanting to end everything so she would know how mad he was? And then what? He could picture her with Devlin, the two of them together, Devlin getting all the good stuff, Kimmy making dumplings, Kimmy’s belly all big, a big beautiful baby inside. And then a baby born. He could picture a baby, and Devlin had his child, and they went to the zoo and Kimmy was happy with the man she hated.

It didn’t take long for his own mind to show him all the things he knew would make him cry, and he ended up in tears. Like a fucking idiot. An emotional idiot.

“You’re doing it to yourself,” he said, wiping his face and blowing his nose with hotel tissue. “Fucking idiot.”

His phone rang, and he searched for it, finding it pushed up under the pillow.

“Oh my God.”

The call came from one Kimmy Waters.

Esquire.

Cunt. Bitch.

He answered it. “Yeah?”

Silence for a moment. Long enough for him to regret the meanness in his answer, his arrogant tone manufactured with an artificial growl.

“I’m sorry,” she said, and it took him off guard. He didn’t know what he’d expected, but that wasn’t it. She continued. “I’m sorry I told you the way I did. I didn’t think how you would feel. I’m so happy, Josh. It’s everything I want. I want it with you.”

“Uh-huh,” he said in that same gravelly way, like an idiot, but doing it now because tears were on the threshold.

“I want you to come home. I want you to come home so we can talk. I’ll listen to anything you want to say to me. We really have to talk.”

First thing he’d ask her: Why did you turn your phone off at lunchtime? Did he fuck you good?

“What’s there to talk about?” He rolled his eyes at his own melodrama. There was so much to talk about. What a dumb thing to say. She sounded like she was trying to be honest with him.

“We don’t have to talk if you don’t want to. I just want to be near you.”

That line had him covering his eyes with a hand, holding his breath so she wouldn’t hear him sob or something.

“Just come home and watch TV with me.”

Eyes squinted shut behind his hand and tears on his cheeks, he said, “Okay.”

He was home in half an hour, coming into their apartment to the familiar sound of the television and the smell of cooking. It hit him hard. God damn it, she was cooking dumplings. Dumplings and something else. She’d read his mind. Done this on purpose. Knew to welcome him with all these familiar elements like she was conjuring a spell.

And then he thought of Devlin getting this treatment. Of Kimmy caring enough about Devlin’s happiness, of Kimmy earning Devlin’s affection if

she'd lost it. A jealous surge gripped his viscera, and he grunted and leaned on the wall in the foyer, heart racing.

Then Kimmy appeared in the archway to the kitchen, a half dozen feet away, hearing him come in.

Their eyes met and there wasn't a swelling crescendo of reunion, only an intractable clash that had them both looking away. Terrible things had transpired.

Kimmy stepped closer, his eyes turned down to her feet clad in slippers. Her hand went to his chest, then to his neck. He looked up again, looked in her eyes and this time didn't look away no matter how hard it was.

CHAPTER 2

INFERIOR ANGEL

Her pussy was too wet. Why would Kimmy be this wet?

Were these the kinds of thoughts he would always endure with her from now on? Ones of worry and suspicion? Her pussy teemed with juices; their union was slick and messy and made sounds of liquid flesh sliding and smacking and slurping.

But fuck it made him hard.

It made him so hard to be inside her right now when she wanted him so badly. When she needed him. Her nails raked his back, and she moaned and writhed as he pumped into her, her knees up at his hips. His cock was like iron thinking of her the way he'd seen her at The Hazelton. Just like she was now, but her guts being reamed by Devlin's huge cock, her slick little pussy lips clinging to life on Devlin's massive girth. And that knot in her belly; the head of Devlin's cock so deep inside of her and making her squirt.

"Oh, Josh," she moaned. "You're so hard. You feel so good."

And that ruined it. That reminded him of the lies that spilled from those other wet lips. Those words of encouragement were lies. Weren't they? *Did* he feel good? *Could* he feel good in comparison? It didn't seem likely, and that brought the dread again—all the bad that came intertwined with the dark joy in watching her with Devlin. Lies and betrayal; whispered compliments meant to manipulate.

His thrusts slowed, and in response, Kimmy squeezed him tighter, her arms around his neck, her thighs on his hips. Like she was afraid he would flee again and go into hiding. Like a witness protection program for men who'd seen the worst and couldn't face the consequences of bearing it.

"Josh, don't stop," she whispered, her hips humping against his. "I want you to come inside me. Please? I want to feel that."

He grunted, putting his forehead into the pillows at her collar, feeling his hardness retreating, his cock going flimsy inside her.

She rubbed his back. "Tell me what to do, Josh. I'll do anything."

"I don't want anything," he said, frustrated. Hating now that they were in bed together, that he was that easy a lay, that one look in his wife's seductive eyes and he was in their bed and giving her what she wanted.

"Dirty stuff, Josh. I'll say anything. Do you want that? I'll do that."

He shook his head, but her urging brought potential whispers in his ears, things he could imagine she would say. Things like how big Devlin's cock was and how he felt so good how he filled her up like Josh could never do, give her pleasure only a bad man like Devlin Stone could, and how she loved being so bad she would do anything for that pleasure, even betray the man she loved. That's how much she liked Devlin's huge cock and balls and the way his come shot a yard into the air in thick ropes of unbelievable volume.

"Oh, that's it, baby," she cooed, writhing against him as his cock thundered to full, blood-rushing steel again. He squinted against the embarrassment of it all, the sheer humiliation of the things that turned him on.

"Come inside me, okay?" She said, "Come on, I want you to come."

And now he was galloping after it, chasing down his eruption, wanting to fill her up with his seed, wanting to get it over with in a sense, wanting the clear-headedness that followed an orgasm. Through gritted teeth, he said, "Can you feel him? Feel him when he comes in you?"

Kimmy grunted, and the sound reminded him of a transmission changing gears, Kimmy knowing they were going for it now and they would be dirty instead of kind and loving. “Oh yeah,” she gasped. “Oh yes, Josh.”

“You fucking feel him? Feel the way he comes? Feel it . . . Squirting in you?”

Kimmy grabbed his ass cheeks, forcing him to fuck her harder, and he knew this was real. This was turning her on. Kimmy loved the debauchery, the wickedness, the sin. That’s what turned her on. They got the bed squeaking, Kimmy panting and gasping, saying, “He fills me up, Josh, I feel it going off inside me, and, oh, ah, he pumps me full of come until it’s, mm, it’s spilling out of my pussy and all over the sheets, and, oh, mm . . .”

Kimmy orgasmed with him, both of their bodies tightening and twisting, both of them uttering gibberish and hissing air, Kimmy’s nails digging into his ass until he thought he was scarred. He pumped her full of come. Whatever he could produce. Little bursts of his mediocre seed, jetting half the depth inside her that her horse-cock lover did. But the pleasure rolled and rumbled and bloomed in his mind and in his heart until he collapsed on her, heaving to catch his breath. Kimmy hugged him.

But the shame filled the vacuum of lust’s absence. He’d pumped all of it into her wet pussy and now he was left with the cold reality of why they were in bed like this and how it all came to be. Tears filled his eyes, and he broke from her clutch, rolling to her side, facing away from her and trying not to sob. Kimmy clung to his back, putting a long thigh over his hip, running her nails on his arm.

“I’m so sorry, Josh. I’m so sorry. I love you. I love you so much. You know that.”

He nodded, lips slim, brows bowed in glumness, eyes looking beyond their window and out into the starry night. It was terrible to be in this bed, but it was better than being alone.

“I betrayed you. I know I did. I’m lucky to have you here with me now. I know that. I know it. Are you listening?”

“I don’t want to talk right now,” he said, wanting her silenced. He was pure woman at the moment. Not a man. He was tender and overflowing with emotion, sensitive to touch and to words. He said, “Just stay with me.” Kimmy could say the right thing or the wrong thing in this moment and they would be received the same way. Silence was king. Silence would be king until he’d healed his heart.

Kimmy kissed the back of his neck and held him, saying nothing.

Later, maybe after an hour or so, Kimmy shifted behind him and brought him out of a fleeting and fitful slumber. He asked her where she was going.

“Do you want something to eat? Did you have dinner?”

“You made dumplings?”

She caressed his hip.

“You made them for me?” There was the tone of an inquisitor in his voice, and Kimmy heard it.

“You like my dumplings,” she said.

“That’s why you made them.” It was like an accusation; a revelation of how his mind fabricated her methodology, the way he calculated his own wife’s manipulations. But at the end of the sad day, Kimmy had just made him dumplings, and had made them because she knew he liked them. It was him attaching great nefarious weight to the act. Instead of explaining himself or apologizing for his harshness, he turned away again as if he would sleep, eyes open and looking out the window at the almost-black night.

She snuggled against his back, then traced the backs of her nails down his naked hip and thigh, doing it over and over again in a playful way that

he still interpreted as manipulative. But what did he have that she wanted? What was it that he had that would make her lie and betray and manipulate her way back into his good grace? Was it his seven-figure bank account? Was it his rock hard body that she loved to caress? Was it his foot long horse cock that touched a trigger point in her pussy so deep it made the clit and the g-spot underwhelming gimcrack-things of commonplace? Devlin had those things, yet it was in Josh Waters's bed Kimmy mewled and wriggled, looking for comfort. But accepting his own wife's love had become an albatross, an anchor that weighed him down to the depths with the enormity of self-realization: You're a simpleton, a rube. A victim. A perpetual victim. The nice guy that let people get their jollies off him as long as they paid him a cheap nicety.

"I would do anything," she whispered, "to be with you like we were before, be with you just to hear your excitement when I made you something good to eat."

He closed his eyes, longing for that time to return as well.

She snuggled against his back. She whispered something, and he was sure it was, "We're a team."

If only it could be so. If only he could trust her that way.

Then, more clearly, she whispered near his ear, "Do you think we can be like that again?"

His eyes squeezed tight; his jaw clenched. That's all he wanted. But there was no way to get there.

He said, "You're pregnant."

"I am," she sighed, fingertips still grazing his skin.

Then, so out of the blue he had to repeat it over twice in his own mind before it registered, she said, "I told Devlin it was his."

His vision pinched into darkness, and he covered his eyes, hunching forward. Kimmy sighed, sensing his reaction, knowing she'd hurt him

again. She hugged him tighter, afraid he would pop out of bed. He said, “*What?* You said *what?* Why?”

She said, “To hurt him.”

It made no sense, and he scoffed, shaking his head, saying, “What if it’s his?”

“It’s not, Josh. I swear it.”

“You don’t know it.”

“Do you want a DNA test?”

He grunted and pulled free from her arms, sitting up, but not leaving. Kimmy stayed with her head on the pillow next to him, watching him. Their eyes met, and he studied her, trying to comprehend how she had changed, how she had transformed into someone who scared him so much. Where had his other Kimmy gone?

“I will get you one,” she said. “I will get you one right away if it makes you feel better. I swear it’s ours, Josh.”

He stared and blinked, struggling to remain level at this unbalanced time. “I appreciate how earnest you are. But those are words of, I don’t know, hope or something. Wishes.” He looked away, out at the night. “He came inside you without a condom, didn’t he? Before you were on the pill?”

He heard the sound of her silky hair on the pillow, Kimmy shaking her head no. He looked back at her. “He didn’t?”

She said, “He didn’t come inside me.”

“But did he wear a condom?”

Her mouth opened and closed. Then she said, “No. But we didn’t have real sex.”

His stomach twisted thinking about it. “But he put it inside you?”

She nodded. He groaned and looked away.

Kimmy sat up and touched his arm. “It’s not his, Josh. I know it. I feel it.”

He hung his head, growling into his hands, heart crushed, ears ringing, wondering how he had the resolve to remain in this bed with her. The hotel room had been comfortable. He said, “You can’t feel it. Can’t feel whose it is. What do you think, you’re going to feel devil horns scraping your insides?”

“Don’t be flippant, Josh,” she said. “I know you’re mad. But I know you want this. We can make it all work. I’ll do anything.”

“Except quit your job,” he said into his hands.

She said, “That’s how I’m going to make it work.”

CHAPTER 3

THE GOOD OF EVIL

Josh pulled away again, and this time she didn't seize him or hold him back. He wasn't angry; he was exhausted, enervated. He sat up, looking away from her. "Kimmy, I . . . I don't want to live a life like this where I can have a conversation like this one. I can't believe I'm sitting in my bed with my wife and my wife is assuring me the baby that's growing inside her is mine. This conversation should never happen. It shouldn't happen to anyone. That's the whole point of getting married." He hung his head and sighed. She couldn't think yet about how to console him. How to assure him she loved him. Thoughts of sharing her video of Devlin diminished. Thoughts of the two of them snuggling up and laughing at Devlin together, of Josh getting aroused by what he saw, of them making love all night, were fading fast. And that was only the first step in revealing to Josh what she'd done. It scared her to sense that wedge between them again, that dividing force.

She said, "I know you love me—"

"Yeah, I know."

"No," she said, "I know you love me, but I know you can love me more. I know how I can show you how I love you."

"What about what's happened? You want to pretend it didn't."

“I don’t. I confessed, Josh. I told you what I did. I want you to see how I might think—”

“That what, I liked it? That I wanted it?”

“If you’re here with me now, it’s because you’re not sure if you didn’t like it.” This time she met his gaze and held it, and Josh didn’t look away. She kept the connection until Josh wavered, doubts flitting at him, getting him blinking as if he stood on the threshold of a bat cave at dusk. At last, he looked away.

She said, “And I know you tell yourself that you never wanted it, that the wanting of it is a function of manipulation. That Devlin did it, or that Amy did it. I know I did it. I did it only because I hoped if you liked it even a little, it would save me in your eyes.”

She waited, watched Josh’s eyes travel the bed space between them until finding their way to her again.

He said, “That sounds pretty honest.”

“That’s honest. I want you to like it because then I’m not the devil.”

Josh stared at her, thinking. But he didn’t absolve her of her own condemnation. Didn’t babble in effusive amelioration how she wasn’t the devil. The reflection of her badness in her husband’s reaction tightened her chest. Residual angst, abhorrence of harming another, general proclivities of moral goodness held so much of her past in place. Wickedness had liberated her from fear and from harm and shown her success and mastery over others she would have shrunk from in another life. Josh was the damper and the foil. Without Josh, would there be a limit to her wickedness? And without Josh, would there be wickedness’s thrill at all?

“You’re the reason I want to do anything, Josh. You’re the man I want in my life. You’re the man I want in my bed. You’re the man I want to be the father of my baby.”

Josh’s features quivered, and he hung his head again. She feared he would cry, but he didn’t. He stayed in the posture of mortal pain for a long

time. She said, “I hope that means even something little to you.”

He looked up, eyes wet. “It does. It means everything. . . . I don’t know what you want, Kimmy. I’m not going to throw my arms around you and everything’s fixed. I want what you’re saying. I want it with every part of my being. But it’s not easy. What I watched, how I know . . . How you *lied* to me. How you betrayed me.”

She ran a hand over her hair, slumping, her own eyes drifting. “I’m terrible,” she said.

“I don’t need you to say anything like that. That’s not why I said it.”

“I’m not going to lie anymore, Josh. I told you that. I *am* terrible. I did awful things to you. And even though I know they were awful and that they hurt you . . .”

He looked up, seeing her stalling. “What?”

She licked her lower lip. “I enjoyed those things.”

Josh’s soft features pinched tight in disbelief.

“Hear me out,” she said, touching his wrist. “I want you to like it. Okay? I’m being honest. All of it, Josh, all of it—not Devlin, that’s not what I mean. I mean all of the betrayal, the lies, the . . . Fuck. The *ascent*. It turned me on. I hate that I hurt you, but I want to be honest. I liked it. I still like it. I’ll never hurt you again, but I can’t help how it turned me on.”

Josh’s scowl loosened to something like a silent howl, and she stopped him. “Don’t,” she said, almost like a warning. “Don’t take what I just said and run with it. Don’t take it and use it against me. Don’t say anything. Think about it and don’t say anything. Not now, at least. I handed you a weapon and I know you want to hit me over the head with it as hard as you can, but please wait for a minute or two.”

Josh hid his face in his hands and turned away.

“I didn’t want to *trick* you into liking what I did. I wanted to lure it out of you because I hoped it was there. If it’s not there, Josh, it’s not there. And if it’s not there, I’m horrified at how it must hurt.”

He said, "And now you might be carrying Devlin Stone's baby."

Calm and collected, she said, "I asked you not to hit me with it."

"I'm just supposed to take it," he said, dropping his hands to his lap and looking out the apartment window.

"If you'd look in my eyes, I could tell you everything you'd ever want to hear. I would tell you that not only do I love you, I will love you forever. I will make you the happiest man. I will make you a father. I will buy us a house. I will make our dreams real. I will crush your enemies. I will destroy anyone you ask me to. I know in my heart that I am everything you ever wanted."

Josh chuckled once, still not looking at her, but hearing her claims and laughing at their face value. In time Josh would see those words weren't empty and that he would reap the benefits of her devotion.

He quarter turned, saying, "I don't want you to destroy anyone. I want you to be mine. My faithful wife. My partner. I don't need you to say frightening things."

"It's too late for me to be faithful. Can you love me the way you did before?"

Josh said, "That's up to you."

And for that, she had no comeback. There were no more vengeful claims to be made, no more promises, no more enticing whispers of lust and lechery.

Josh said, "I'm going to get up now and I want to leave, but I know you'll say I'm fleeing and that I'm a coward."

"I won't say that. But you could stay. You could stay and we could eat dumplings and we could watch TV and we could have sex again."

Josh stilled and didn't get up. She thought he might stay. Eyes looking away, he said, "You went on the pill so you could have sex with Devlin. Is that right?"

She hesitated, biting her cheek. "Yes."

“It’s not so easy, Kimmy. Not so easy to submit to the things you can do for me, the ways you can remind me of when things were better. Everything weighs on me. I don’t think we can be the same.”

She nodded once, feeling the bitter bile of anger. She said, “Can we be different?”

Josh nodded.

She said, “Maybe we can be close to the way it was, but a little different. Where I’m sorry for the things I’ve done and you’ve forgiven me and we’re *almost* the same.”

Josh nodded again. “We could do that. I would like that.”

She exhaled, surprised by the trembling of her breath. Hearing that relief conjured wet to her eyes, and she sniffled. And now she worried Josh would think her emotional relief was an act. She bit it back and gritted her teeth.

“I don’t want you to leave. I want you to stay with me.”

“I want to stay,” he said. “But it’s easy to stay.”

“It’s easier to run away,” she said. “I felt it, too, how easy it would be. I stayed and I’m fighting for you even though I ruined everything and it would be so easy to let it all sift through my fingers, let it all go away and blame everyone else. I can blame me, Josh. I can blame me and I can prove that I know I fucked up and I know I hurt you and I can humiliate myself through any ritual you want.”

“That’s not true.”

She shook her head. “No. You wouldn’t make me do it. I can say it because you’re too kind to humiliate me.”

“It’s not kindness. Your humiliation would be my own. I’m the man who failed you. I’m the man who lost you. I’m the one who couldn’t satisfy you. I’m the one you cheated on and lied to and manipulated. That’s the reason I wouldn’t do it.”

She was the one covering her face now, breathing into her hands.

He said, "What would your father say? Your sister?"

"Don't, Josh," she whispered.

"I wouldn't. I wouldn't do that to you. I wouldn't hurt you like that. I hated saying it now. But it felt good to remind you."

"You could crush me. If you did that, you could crush me."

"I wouldn't do that, Kimmy."

She smoothed back her hair, leaned to the side table and plucked up a tissue and held it to her eyes, then wiped her nose. "It's late," she said. "You're not going to a hotel and you're not going to Meyer's or wherever. Stay here. I can sleep on the couch."

"And tomorrow?"

She shrugged a shoulder. "That's up to you."

He said, "Tomorrow you go to work for Devlin."

Her lips slimmed. "I do."

"And you'll turn your phone off at lunch time again."

Her scalp prickled, and a shiver ran up her back. She said, "Don't ask me about that."

He stared at her for a long while, then said, "I guess I don't have to."

She shook her head side to side, staring away and thinking of Devlin today and his thick cock in her hand and how hard Josh would get if he could embrace the worst of himself and of her. "I'm not ready to explain it," she said. "But it was for you."

"You went to Devlin's. Correct?"

She looked into his eyes. "I told you I'm not ready to tell you, but please consider how you might not be ready to hear it, either."

"More wickedness," he lamented, voice low and admonishing.

She said. "Yes. I'm the wickedest."

Josh chuckled, taking the opportunity to retreat. She wanted to scold him, point out his cowardice and how he used her sins as his own virtue. But she bit her tongue and let him rise from the bed.

He said, “I’ll sleep on the couch. You can take the bed.”

CHAPTER 4

STRANGE CREATURES

WEDNESDAY, SEPTEMBER 30

Hyun opened the door, pleased by the unexpected visit. Right away, Hyun saw everything was not right in Kimmy's world, stepping back and ushering Kimmy into her apartment, saying, "Are you okay?"

Kimmy trudged into the foyer. "Is Sophie here?"

"No, she's with Meyer. What's going on?"

Kimmy put down her bag, closed her eyes, palming her forehead, not knowing where to begin. She'd been on her way home from work and knew Josh wouldn't be there. She texted Hyun to see if she was home and Hyun told her to come on over.

When Kimmy had no response, only standing there trying to collect her shattered world in a way she could present it, Hyun was helping her into the living room, urging her to remove her jacket and sit on the couch. "I'll make us some tea."

"You don't have to do that, Hyun," Kimmy told her, taking Hyun's wrist and guiding her to join her on the couch. "Just sit with me for a minute."

Hyun sat on the couch, ever patient, watching Kimmy, her posture comforting and supportive, and her presence welcoming. Kimmy said, "I'm glad you were home."

"Is it something bad? Is everyone okay?"

“Everyone’s fine. Sorry, I guess I’m melodramatic, not saying anything. That’s not fair.”

Hyun nodded, still patient, and now Kimmy smiled. She took Hyun’s hand. “I’m sorry I haven’t called this week.”

“I know you’re busy.”

“I need to make time for you.”

“We’re both busy, Kimmy. It’s okay, I mean it.”

Kimmy licked her lower lip, her head sagging toward Hyun, their gazes connecting. “I think I messed everything up.”

“What did you mess up?”

“Everything. Josh. Work. Marriage. Career. My life. You name it.”

Hyun frowned. “What happened?”

“I...” She looked away from Hyun, wondering what way to frame this that would make sense. The truth wouldn’t make sense. “I don’t think he loves me anymore.”

“Are you sure he loved you before?”

She rolled her gaze back to Hyun, puzzled. “Of course. What do you mean?”

“He wanted you with someone else.”

“Oh. No, it’s not like that. It’s so complicated I don’t even know which direction I’m facing anymore.”

“Did he tell you he doesn’t love you?”

She shook her head no. “I see it in his eyes. Or, I guess, *don’t* see it in his eyes.”

Hyun stroked Kimmy’s forearm. “That’s why you’re upset?”

Kimmy put her hand over Hyun’s. “Can I hang out with you tonight? Are you busy?”

“I’m not too busy for you,” Hyun said.

“Can I order us some dinner? Can we stay in?”

Hyun nodded, smiling, leaning close and laying her head on Kimmy's shoulder. Kimmy said, "Josh is staying at Meyer's again."

"Okay," Hyun said. "Are you guys going to separate?"

Kimmy screwed her mouth up, hating the thought of abandonment, of Josh losing his love for her, of leaving her behind and moving on. The thought of him happy with another woman burned in her stomach and hurt her heart. The idea of him smiling because he was in love and it wasn't with her and his back faced her broke her and she wondered why she would ever try to picture that. She'd done it to herself all day. "Don't ask me that."

Hyun went upright, apology harrowing her features. "I'm so sorry, Kimmy, I didn't mean to—"

Kimmy palmed Hyun's warm cheek. "It's okay, it's fine."

Hyun looked down. "I'm not very good at this."

Kimmy thumbed the soft plump shape of Hyun's lower lip. "You couldn't be better, Hyun. You're perfect. You're everything I need right now. Just be with me. Okay?"

Hyun kissed the pad of Kimmy's thumb, eyes still averted, submissive and stinging from her mistake still. "I want that," she whispered.

Kimmy's hand slipped behind Hyun's neck and she pulled Hyun close. Hyun drew her feet up on the couch and snuggled into Kimmy's side. Kimmy closed an arm around Hyun and held her tight. And when that felt good, she held her even tighter. Tighter until a happy feeling swelled her heart and pushed away all the dread, at least for the time being.

"Sometimes I feel," she whispered to Hyun, "like everything I want is so close, but the harder I try to claim it, the more it moves away from me."

"It's slippery," Hyun said. "If you persist, I promise good things will come to you."

"What about the bad things I've done?"

"If someone loves you, they'll forgive you. And if they don't, they never loved you at all. They were lying the whole time."

Kimmy hugged Hyun again. “I’m going to take care of you. I’m going to make you happy.”

Sophie met Josh at the apartment door like she’d been expecting him. Josh manufactured joy and pleasantness, enduring a real struggle to stick his chest out, stop slouching, raise his heavy brow. Anything to conceal from Sophie the physical manifestation of his aching heart.

Sophie was pure and innocent and excited to see her Uncle Josh. He kneeled to hug her, then she brought him into the apartment. Meyer was already on the couch playing video games, saying, “What’s up, buddy,” without turning. “Give me one sec.”

Josh took his suit jacket off and sat on the couch. Sophie asked him if he wanted a drink of water.

“That’d be great, Sophie.”

Then Sophie did the unthinkable, asking him, “Where’s Aunt Kimmy?”

He said, “She has a girls’ night or something,” wondering why Meyer hadn’t explained to his daughter better why Uncle Josh was staying over yet again.

Sophie was too polite to say it, but he could read it in her eyes. Something was wrong and Aunt Kimmy was having a lot of girls’ nights. Sophie left to get him a glass of water.

“You didn’t tell her Kimmy wasn’t coming?”

Meyer paused his game. “I just said you were coming to stay over tonight. I didn’t mention Kimmy.”

Josh let it go.

He covered his eyes with a hand. “What a day today. Every hour was like ten.”

They ate light but still indulged. Kimmy told Hyun to get *anything* she wanted and Hyun used Doordash, ordering sushi from her favorite place to eat, and a box of donuts. They ate *age gyoza* and sushi rolls; yellowtail and spicy salmon and *futo maki*. They split only a single Boston cream and then lay on the couch and watched TV together, silent but embracing, the sound turned low. Later, in bed early, Kimmy told Hyun, “I don’t know if I want to have sex right now.”

“I don’t want that,” Hyun said. “I just want you in my bed.”

They lay on their sides in t-shirts and underwear, and the strongest urge pulled Kimmy’s lips to Hyun’s. They kissed, and Kimmy closed her eyes and breathed in. Hyun tasted like toothpaste, but she smelled warm and homey, like body and faded soap. It was a wonderful smell.

Meyer said, “You can’t trust women,” and swigged from his beer bottle.

Josh said, “That’s what it comes down to, is it?”

Sophie had gone to bed an hour ago, and now it was the two cousins, Josh on the couch where he’d be sleeping tonight, already dressed for bed in T-shirt and sweatpants. The TV was muted and the Jays and Phillies were on, the Phillies ahead by two.

“You know Sophie will be a woman some day.”

Meyer winced. “Don’t remind me.”

“Don’t reduce women to characteristics you don’t like.”

“Yeah, it sounds shitty, but I’m not wrong. Pattern recognition, cuz. I was on your couch, now you’re on my couch, and it’s all for the same reason.”

“Women,” Josh said in mock misogyny, crossing his arms and harrumphing. “We should start a club.”

“You’re joking because I’m getting too close to the wound.”

Josh leaned his head to the side, bowing his eyebrows in sly chiding.

Meyer laughed, knowing he sounded brutish. But he persisted. “Who knows what they want. *If* they know what they want. They’ll say one thing to mean another, soothe you, aggravate you, all of it to get what they want, and what they want is just hormonal impulses and societal constructs and I swear, the pill is fucking them all up.”

Josh shook his head, bothered by the reminder that Kimmy was on the pill and had gone on it to have an affair. And even then she couldn’t assure him the baby belonged to him and not Devlin. No, that was wrong. She could assure him, she just couldn’t assure herself. “Manipulators,” he said and swigged his beer.

“Now you’re talking,” Meyer said, and wagged the neck of his beer bottle Josh’s way.

“Talk about pattern recognition, though—we’re the common denominator. The Waters.”

“The Waters are cursed,” Meyer said. “Cursed by our love for Asian women.” He giggled at that, eyes getting sleepy, watching Guerrero getting tagged at second to end the inning. He scoffed and rolled his eyes.

In the quiet that followed, Josh considered ways he would depict to Meyer what had happened, preserving his dignity, and even Kimmy’s. How would he explain what had happened, the sheer enormity of it, without ruining his life?—without humiliating himself to his closest friend and family member?

The circumstances of Kimmy’s sins had cast him into this thick purgatory where he was held immobile, forced not to move in any way that might alleviate his torment. He had to suffer for Kimmy’s crimes.

Meyer's head rolled Josh's way when the commercial came on. "You going to tell me what's going on this time? It's serious. I feel it."

"I don't know what it is yet. No, I do. At least I know it's serious. I'm sure of that."

"Was she having an affair for sure? What, you better not tell me she's leaving you for that guy, I swear to fucking god. That would be the fucking lowest, most evil . . . Kimmy wouldn't do that, would she?"

A bright spot in this terrible evening switched on. It calmed him to say, "No. She is not leaving me for him. She doesn't want *me* to leave her."

Meyer studied his profile for a while and Josh faced him. They looked at each other, not knowing what to say, his cousin's mouth screwing around, not sure what would be consoling and what would be aggravating.

Meyer settled on: "You want a shot of whisky?"

Josh sighed and rested his head back on the sofa. "I have to go to work tomorrow, Meyer."

Meyer nodded, regarding the ball game again. He said, "We'll do something this weekend. We'll have some fun, loosen up. I'll take your mind off it. Hyun's got Sophie. We can do whatever we want." He turned to Josh, sitting on his sofa in sweats and a T-shirt, smiling. "And you'll have a bed instead of a couch."

They kissed forever and Kimmy couldn't remember another time where she had enjoyed it so much. Hyun had a perfect mouth, small and plump, and her body was soft and warm. No hard muscle and scratchy hair, no stubble shredding her cheeks or her neck, no hard and urgent dick poking at her, wanting inside her to spit its seed. Kimmy's hands drifted from the small of Hyun's back and down her panties to cup her cool ass cheeks. She guided the underwear down while their mouths still sucked and their tongues still

slithered. Hyun's breaths deepened. She'd said to Hyun she didn't want sex, but this was something else altogether.

Hyun gasped as Kimmy stroked the folds of her sex, the membranes full and hot and sticky. She kissed Hyun's neck. Their bodies writhed and their legs wrangled in languorous glory. Hyun pushed Kimmy's underwear down, both of them with their twisted panties scoring mid-thigh, and now they tilted hips and touched mounds, the scratch of their pubic pelts brushing up the sexiest sound under the covers. Hyun stroked Kimmy's belly, her palm circling low, over the magic creation growing inside her.

CHAPTER 5

DEPARTING CRANES

FRIDAY, OCTOBER 2

The show tonight at the Royal Ontario Museum started at seven, and it was quarter to five now. It would be a rush, but they could get to Future Bistro for dinner in time to make the Opera Atelier at the ROM's Eaton Theatre for a special kids' show. Sophie would love it. Dinner at the fun bistro—a place of fond memories for her Aunt Kimmy and Uncle Josh—and then professional Romantic ballet; mazurkas and tarantellas.

Her phone dinged with an incoming text, and she pushed herself back from her desk.

Hyun: We're here now. Do you want us to come up?

Kimmy: I'm coming down

Hyun and Sophie had taken the GO Bus this afternoon, heading out of Ajax as soon as Sophie got out of school. They'd made good time.

Tami stopped her in the lobby, hanging up the phone and calling her name. Kimmy turned, and Tami said, "Mr. Stone wants to see you."

"I'm on my way out. I have people waiting. I'll call him later."

"It's Mr. Stone senior," Tami said. "He's here."

Kimmy showed no expression, but her heart thudded double time and her back went to ice. A tingle began at her fingertips and crawled up her arms. "He's here?"

“Yes, he’s waiting for you downstairs. He told me to send you down.”

“He’s not coming up?”

Tami looked helpless. “He just said for me to send you down. I think he’s in his car.”

While her pulse thundered in her ears, she considered what it might mean—then she smiled for Tami’s sake, headed to the washroom, lightheaded now. Once she was closed in the washroom, she ran cold water, wetted a paper towel and held it to her forehead. She regarded her pained eyes in the mirror, saying to herself, “This could be it.” This could be where it all came crashing down. “Friday, just before five.” The time when all good leaders dropped their hammers, a time where an unfortunate underling couldn’t make a scene and would go home to vent their frustrations to their families.

She dried her hands and face, tidied her clothes, then left the washroom and walked to the elevator.

A cold October afternoon, but sunny, and out in the daylight two things met Kimmy. On the left, standing on the interlock walkway out front of the P&G building, were Hyun and Sophie, oblivious to the second thing waiting to greet Kimmy. Hyun smiled with innocent joy and held Sophie at the shoulders, Sophie standing in front of her mother wearing comfortable dress-up clothes. They were going to have a fun night tonight.

But the second thing that greeted her was a long black car on the right, faceless, nameless, gleaming. The windows were tinted black, concealing its intent. It was Stone senior’s liveried saloon, a driver up front behind the black glass, a buttercream leather salon in the back. She’d seen it before at a meeting in Kingston. She’d never sat in it. As the rear door opened and an

unknown man in a suit stepped out, Kimmy greeted Hyun and Sophie, conjuring every ounce of inscrutable calm while the seas roiled inside.

“Look at you, Sophie,” she said, eyeing the high shine on Sophie’s patent leather lace-ups. “I love your shoes.”

Sophie smiled ear to ear, wowed seeing her Aunt Kimmy all dressed up for work, in the city, going out for a fun evening just for her to see a real ballet.

She cupped Sophie’s cheeks and kissed her hairline, rising again to meet Hyun’s gaze. Hyun was filled with warm ardor, both of them restraining the desire to kiss. Not in front of Sophie. She mouthed, “You look good, too.”

Hyun went bashful, her tawny cheek looking exquisite against the camel taupe of the long wool coat Kimmy had bought her for the season.

“Hey,” Kimmy said, smiling, “I have to take care of one more thing before we get going,” nodding her head to the side where a man stood waiting for her beside Devlin’s father’s limo.

Hyun nodded, ebullient, and unsuspecting of the dire circumstance around them. The man waiting for her would be a lawyer, or worse, an RCMP officer.

But as she got closer, she knew he wasn’t the police. He was a man shorter than her, in his fifties, and not the kind of man who’d spent time on the rougher side of law enforcement. He was pampered, soft, well-nourished, his hair a curly salt and pepper. She knew his name from the company roster before he’d even said it.

“Kim Waters? I’m Aaron Berg, Stone’s counsel.” He gestured into the cool cabin. “Mr. Stone and I would like to speak with you.”

Only Stone didn’t speak with her, not even looking her way as she sat down on the comfortable back-facing leather bench, sitting so she faced both men. Devlin’s father didn’t look her way, eyes cast out the side window, looking at nothing but parked cars, elbow on the sill, groomed hand supporting the wide point of his chin. He looked like Devlin, only

mean and cunning, and sporting none of that boyish emptiness filled with bravado. Stone senior was the real man of the show. Aaron Berg closed the car door, and the cabin was dimmer with the tint. She worried what Hyun and Sophie would be thinking now, but then realized they thought she was the real *woman* of the show. They'd be impressed. *Look at your Aunt Kimmy at work, the level of business she deals at.*

Aaron crossed his legs and held cupped hands over the point of one knee. "Something's come to our attention, and I think you know why we're here."

"I don't."

Aaron smiled. "I'm quite sure you do, Mrs. Waters. You've been avoiding us."

She said, "Tell me what it's about."

Aaron said, "It's a matter of money, isn't it?"

"You're not telling me, you're asking me."

Aaron looked at Stone's profile a moment, then returned his attention to Kimmy. "There's a leak. Money pouring out of a hole in Mr. Stone's boat. And it looks like you're holding your cupped hands below the hole. Is that clearer?"

"You're accusing me of stealing?"

Aaron smiled again. "Yes."

Her pulse galloped faster. She showed no expression, no change of demeanor, only fixed her gaze on Aaron's. She said, "Then arrest me."

Aaron seemed gleed by her resistance, trying to show her he had all the best cards and she had none. "First things first. The money?"

She turned away from Aaron Berg, sighing, looking out the same window Stone senior looked out. "This isn't about the money," she said.

Aaron said, "It isn't?" Curious and playful, like he toyed with her.

"No," she said. "And you know it's not. This is bigger than a little bit of missing money."

“It’s seventy-five K, Mrs. Waters. If we took it from you, would you say the same?”

Though her heart pounded and her back went into agonizing spasms, she spoke to Devlin’s father’s profile. “Your son isn’t the man you are. He wants to be, but he hasn’t got anything more than a handsome face and a big set. You know that’s not enough. In fact, that’s the worst combination. At least the most dangerous. But you know that, too. I’ve proved it to you. You see it. And *that’s* why I’m here.”

Aaron looked to Stone senior and finally Stone turned to regard his lawyer, face stony and unreadable, other than its natural grave menace. They said nothing, but Stone moved two fingers of his left hand sitting in his lap.

Aaron returned his attention to her. “So you don’t think it’s about the money you stole?”

She said, “\$75,000 got your attention. You would have paid a consultant \$200,000 to come in for six months and find out why things weren’t adding up. If you ever even noticed they weren’t adding up at all.”

Now for the first time Devlin’s dad really considered her, turning his face to hers. He didn’t speak, only regarded her in a way that said he wanted to smash his fist through her face. She soaked it in, adrenalin replacing the fear. Devlin’s father was everything Devlin wanted to be. Everything he pretended to be. But Devlin’s dad didn’t go to a nice high school in the suburbs, didn’t have all the corrupting perks Devlin had. He was the one who’d done the work and built the business. He had large workman’s hands at the end of his fine French cuffs and platinum cuff links. It made her wonder if he also sported an equine appendage between his legs.

But Stone senior said nothing, only attempted to wither her in his radioactive gaze. Then he regarded Aaron and nodded once before resuming his parking lot reverie.

“We’re done,” Aaron said, leaning forward, uncrossing his legs so he could put his hand on the door’s handle. “Here’s what’s going to happen next. Expect a call from the Law Society, and if I were you, I would shop for a criminal lawyer.”

There were many possible retorts. She could have name dropped the lawyer in Cayman, Quinton Rathburn, a man who should not ever touch the books of a legitimate Canadian company. And how she’d been awarded a trip to meet with the man, and what that trip really meant. She could have mentioned how Devlin Stone followed her and her husband to Cayman and insinuated himself into their marriage. She could have opened her jacket and rested her hand on her belly as a silent indication of the result of Stone Junior’s very deep insinuation. And if she felt really nasty, she could show Devlin’s father the video of his son wearing her satin panties and loving every second of it.

But those were emotional reactions, theatrical, hysterical, not the reaction of Kimmy Chang Waters. So she said nothing, showed no reaction, left them wondering as Aaron Berg, Esquire, levered open the luxury car’s door for her and she stepped back onto the interlock walkway.

Hyun and Sophie waited for her. Had stood there the whole time imagining great things for her career were happening behind those blacked-out windows. They couldn’t imagine that she’d been caught stealing a lot of money. Couldn’t imagine that her career would end here and she would be disbarred and would soon be in court and could see the inside of a prison, too, if convicted. They didn’t know any of that. They only knew what they saw and what she told them.

Her legs quivered and shook, and her heart raced. The urge to crumple before them came over her with infernal weight and it took courage and strength to remain standing. She admired them for a moment, knowing this might be one of the last moments anyone she knew would see her with any measure of respect.

What would happen next was clear. Someone from building security would emerge from the lobby with her belongings in a box, maybe the painting of cranes her father had gifted her wheeled out by a second guard, they would put them on the ground and leave her in bottomless shame for Hyun and Sophie to see.

She stood, not knowing if she should smile, if she should appear stoic, or if she should do the easiest thing and fall to her knees and lure their comfort.

But nothing happened.

Hyun's smile screwed to one side and her brow wriggled as she tried to comprehend why Kimmy stood there saying nothing and doing nothing. Behind her, Stone's limo left the curb and drove away, out onto Yonge Street and to who knew where. No one came out from the lobby with her belongings.

She worked her jaw around, trying to reduce the whooshing pulse deafening her. Then she smiled, produced her car key and said to Sophie, "Are you ready for the ballet?"

CHAPTER 6

ODYSSEY 1

He should have known something was up.

At the end of the almost three-hour drive north to Quinn's family cottage in Gunter, he finds a caravan of cars waiting for him, Meyer's headlights glinting off many parked cars.

"You're such an asshole," Josh said to Meyer, behind the wheel of Meyer's new truck.

Meyer chuckled. "Sorry, bud. Had to happen."

Josh rubbed his brow as they drove up the long drive to the cottage, the wheels crunching over a bed of rusted pine needles. There looked to be a half dozen cars or more parked by the side of the cottage, the darkness of the lake beyond. "Fuck, is *Steve* here?" It looked like Steve's car parked amongst the many.

Meyer said yes, Steve was here.

"God, who else?"

"Gabrielle from your work. Samara . . . Rafe—"

"Ah fuck, I hate Rafe."

"You do? I didn't know that."

"I don't hate him, but . . . Whatever."

"I can tell him to leave. You want me to kick him out?"

"No," he said, sulking.

“Karina’s here, too.”

“Ah shit,” he muttered, wanting to sink his head into the collar of his jacket like a turtle. “Why would you do this to me?”

“Don’t look at me, cuz. It was Quinn’s idea. If it was me, we’d be balls deep in a pizza and COD. Quinn said you need to have friends around right now.”

He rubbed his brow harder. “They don’t *know*, do they?”

“I didn’t tell them what’s going on. And Quinn didn’t either. We could only get a hold of a handful of people. She invited some of her own friends to fill out the crowd. They gotta close the cottage this weekend. That part was true. Her brothers are here.”

“How many people?”

“Like a dozen, I guess. We’re not going to act like it’s for you. Quinn’s considerate, okay?”

Josh shook his head, still disgruntled, but momentarily quieted by the task of closing the cottage and the presence of Quinn’s friends. If he were surrounded only by sympathizers right now, he might crumble before them.

Meyer added, “And do me a favor, okay? Don’t be a dick about this. Put a smile on your pasty face for me. Quinn’s nice. I like her. Don’t fuck this up for me.”

“She did this for you, not for me.”

“Yes, and no. She likes you, Josh. She’s really upset about what’s going on with you.”

Josh groaned and squeezed the bridge of his nose. “Why would you tell her any of that?”

“You barely tell me anything, so what magic secrets do you think I’m telling her? I don’t know shit, so I’m not telling her shit. You’re sleeping on my couch, and she knows what’s up. She was there last time. Appreciate it that people like you, and stop with the prima dona shit. We want you to be happy. *I* sure do. And Quinn does. So I’m asking you to do me the kindness,

if you will”—he put a hand over his heart, eyes turned to the sky—“of some grace for the kind effort a woman who’s a stranger to you is offering.”

Meyer put both hands back on the wheel, and Josh watched his cousin’s profile. “Jesus, dude. You’re really hooked on this girl.”

“I just know what kind of grump you are. Don’t embarrass me, okay?”

“I’ll be on my best behavior.”

Meyer leaned over the console, grabbed Josh’s thigh, and squeezed. “You should be around people, buddy.”

“You’re people. Why can’t I just be around you?”

“Because I’m as fucked up as you are.”

“That’s why I like you.”

Meyer nodded out the passenger window, saying, “Look, here comes Steve,” and Josh turned to the right to see Steve emerging from the dusky gloom, walking between two parked cars, skin glistening wet, wearing only swimming trunks and Crocs, holding an almost empty bottle of Sleeman. Steam rose from his shoulders. Meyer rolled down Josh’s window from the driver side as Josh was saying, “Quinn has a hot tub, I guess,” and Steve reached in and patted Josh’s chest, leaning forearms on the open window sill.

Steve said, “And it’s real fucking hot, buddy,” Then, “Nice truck, Meyer.”

Josh said, “When did you get here?”

“Almost an hour ago,” Steve said. “I ducked out early.”

“You didn’t say anything at work today.”

“About coming up here? Meyer said you wouldn’t come if you knew I’d be here.”

“I didn’t say that, I wouldn’t—”

But Meyer and Steve were laughing, putting him on.

Josh said, “Who else is here from work? Samara and Gabrielle?”

“Yeah, they rode up with me.”

“Rafe’s here?”

“Who, Rafe? No, he’s not here,” Steve said, frowning like he wondered who would ask Rafe to come.

“Oh, that’s too bad,” Josh said with sarcastic disappointment. “Anyway, you guys are the best, coming up all this way.

“Last chance to be at a cottage this year,” Steve said, tipping the neck of the beer bottle at Josh.

“How many beers are you in?”

“This is number three,” Steve said.

Meyer shut off the truck and got out. Josh got out as well, Steve stepping back to give him space, admiring Meyer’s new truck and asking Meyer questions. Campfire wood-smoke was thick in the chilly night air. Meyer handed Josh his bag, Steve saying how Quinn had the main cottage, and there were four bunkies, and how they would bunk up together right by the water. “You should see this dock, dude. It was misty when I got here and you couldn’t even see the end of it. It was like right out of Lord of the Rings.”

Quinn met them before they even passed between the parked cars, making it right toward Meyer and kissing him. “I’m so glad you’re here,” she said. Quinn wore a ball cap, a towel around her waist, a bikini top in black. She had a really great set of knockers. No wonder Meyer was amped about a potential relationship. Quinn greeted Josh now, too, kissing his cheek and one-arm hugging.

“We’re going to have a good time, Josh,” she said near his ear. “Go grab a cold beer and we’ll squeeze you into the hot tub.”

“Thanks,” he said in his most heartfelt way, without elaborating on the specifics. It *was* a kind thing for a stranger to do.

Quinn led them past the parked cars, over a rough patch of grass and around the side of the black-painted cottage, a bungalow with a new pressure-treated deck. But just before the anxious swell of introductions to

the gathered crowd of people around the hot tub, a woman called out his name from behind. He knew the voice because he knew she was here tonight. It was Karina.

“Hang on a sec,” he said to Quinn and the others, glad for the relief. “Karina’s calling me.”

Quinn pointed out the coolers with the beer, told him to grab a swimsuit from the main cabin if he forgot his (no one told him to bring one) and she and Meyer headed off together. Josh told Steve he’d catch up in a minute, and headed back the way he’d come from, moving toward where he’d heard Karina, down in the dark somewhere by the water. She met him where the grass met the dock, saying, “Hey, buddy,” and hugging him. It was damp and cold and he could tell she was shivering despite the wool jacket she wore.

“What are you doing down here by yourself?”

“I was watching the sunset. The colors are starting. Not all over, but there are a couple trees out on the other side of the lake that have gone yellow, and some red patches too. Everything’s still so green in Ajax.”

“We’re really up in the boonies here,” he said.

“It’s nice and quiet. The neighbors are far apart, and they’re not even up this weekend. We have the south half of the lake all to ourselves.” She stuck her hands in her jacket pockets, regarding him now. And there was that look of sympathy he didn’t want to see. Karina knew. Somehow, she knew he was in the shit with Kimmy. How much she knew, he didn’t know. But it could be the whole thing. She’d been there that night at Tiffany’s post high-school reunion, had been awake when he wasn’t, had been around for those igniting moments when Kimmy and Devlin had argued. He looked away, not ready for making eye contact now, not when she was obviously sending out feelers, testing his defenses, wanting to know how much he was hurting.

She chuckled, said, “So what did you think you were coming up here for?”

“I thought it was going to be me and Meyer and Quinn and like one of her brothers. She made it sound low key.”

“I make it high key?”

He could look at her now, that probing moment passed, and Karina hopefully getting the message he didn’t want to talk about Kimmy at all right now. “Yeah, you do. You make it high key.”

Karina scrunched up her face. “I guess that’s good. I think that’s good.”

He chuckled. “Good. You keep thinking that.”

“What, while you sneak out the back, Irish-goodbye us?”

“I’ll be fine.”

“Yeah, you will be,” she said, smiling, eyes narrowed. “You’re going to be just fine.”

With Sophie in bed, Hyun made them tea and served it in the family room. It had been a terrible night. Not for Sophie. Sophie had been oblivious to her aunt’s uneasiness. It had been impossible to keep a happy face for long, so Kimmy had been glad for the show. The ballet took over all the attention, and left her behind Sophie and Hyun, able to direct her fleeting thoughts without one of them asking her what was wrong. But she hadn’t got away with anything. Though she didn’t think she would. Not for long, anyway. Hyun asked her right away, handing her a steaming cup of tea, and saying at the same time. “You’re going to tell me what’s going on, okay? Please. I feel it from you. I feel it. Something is really wrong.”

She smiled wanly, cocking her head to Hyun, saying, “It’s fine. It will pass.”

Hyun studied her for a long time, unconvinced. She set down her untouched tea cup and got closer. “I know you’ve been with him.”

“Who?”

“That man. Devlin.”

“Why would you say that?”

“I’m not stupid, Kimmy. I want you to be honest with me.”

Kimmy sank into the couch and suddenly felt a claustrophobic enervation, like the couch might consume her. She passed her own untouched tea to Hyun, too weak to lean over and set it on the table herself. She said, “Everything is so complicated now. I told you. Everything’s over. I messed it all up.”

Hyun gathered her hands together, eyes turned down to look at them twist. “You didn’t look so good when you got out of that car at your building.”

Kimmy shook her head. “You can read me, huh?”

Hyun looked up, sucking on her lower lip. The lip plopped out. “I’m going to be here for you. No matter what.”

The offer somehow didn’t warm Kimmy this time. Hyun was too small, too fragile, too powerless to make a difference to a woman trapped in the autonomous gears of a massive machine of destruction she’d set in motion herself. In fact, Hyun’s words made her feel worse, made her failure grander and steeper; far more precarious. They shouldn’t even be together at all. Hyun was another twist in this complication.

She covered Hyun’s hand with her own, smiling, but not feeling it, knowing it would show in her eyes. “Did you like the ballet?”

Hyun pulled her hands away. “Come on, Kimmy. Don’t do that to me. I’m not...”

“Not what?”

“I’m not . . . Josh. You don’t have to hide anything from me. I want to know it, no matter what it is.”

The look of adorable determination brought a real smile to her face now, and her hands pursued Hyun’s again, and this time, Hyun didn’t pull away.

Kimmy said, “What if it’s really bad? What if what I’ve done is *really* bad?”

CHAPTER 7

ODYSSEY 2

The hot tub was big enough to seat a dozen people, but it was more comfortable with nine. It was also more comfortable with six wobbly-pops in his belly. The acceptance of this shindig had arrived with unnecessary reluctance, but now that it was here, there was one truth he had to admit: he needed to be around people. It was hard to dwell on his hardships when everyone around him only wanted to have a good time. Quinn's brothers were loud but funny. Big guys who liked hunting and fishing and snowmobiling and worked construction trades, and both of them ready to insult the other at any moment. Seeing such camaraderie made him feel better. Like there was hope, like there was a big friendly world beyond the confines of his marriage and the woman who'd given him the darkest pleasures he'd never dreamed he wanted. He did his best to joke it up with the group, sometimes to chase away depression, other times to make sure he didn't sport the long-lost look of some survivor at sea found by hardy sailors after three months on a life raft, parched and sunburned and half-crazed. It would be easy to fall into that trap.

There was goodness in Quinn. Meyer was a lucky guy. Maybe Quinn had been through the wringer when she divorced from whoever her son Harley's father was. Seeing her laughing and playful burned a small measure of resentment inside him. Kimmy was long and lean, owning a

newfound and striking beauty that developed post college. She was built like a supermodel. She could wither a man in a boardroom, of that he was sure. She was dangerous. He'd grown up with her, and she'd never been that way when she was young. But Quinn was something altogether different. Soft and feminine, but still a little brassy. Like a tomboy who'd grown up sexy but couldn't shake the ball cap and country music now that she was a woman. But Quinn could be a partner for Meyer, someone for Meyer to look forward to coming home to. Soft, feminine, comforting. Quinn wouldn't break away and lead a charge up a hill like some demonic force suddenly consumed with an unknown bloodlust. Leave Meyer behind, or worse, command him to follow.

As for the former reticence, the current glory couldn't be denied. Balls deep in video games and pizza were a pale comparison. Now he was in a beer commercial; sitting in a hot tub up north, a bunch of young and some quite attractive young people (*like yourself, admit it, old boy*), in hot bubbling water during cold Canadian October, patio lanterns strung above, music pumping out of a high-power JBL bluetooth, people laughing and talking, all of them having a good time.

Quinn's friends were nurses. They were cute and funny. Sure, they swore a lot and all of them had tattoos, but they were great company. And looked good in skimpy swimwear, too. It was a horrible thought, but a snapshot of his current circumstance sent to one cunning lawyer who lived in his apartment right now would send that dragon into apoplexy. If he'd let his FindMyPhone ping his location, she might follow. And now, instead of feeling sad about thoughts of his wife, he chuckled to himself, seeing some grave humor in his terrible circumstance. A harmless look at how revenge might form. Living well, as they say. Facebook pictures of him with some buxom young single mom with two kids, a soft and pretty girl, one with lots of ink on her arms and the small of her back, but maybe one who was a great cook, or an artist of some kind. Kimmy would erupt in flames.

Now he was chuckling harder, looking around the scene. Gabrielle and Samara laughing at a nearby picnic table with one of Quinn's guy friends; eight people with him in the tub; two girls dancing in place, standing beside the tub. And Meyer, looking at him now, liking what he saw. They both smiled at each other. Quinn was beside Meyer, yakking it up with one of the standing friends, the standing friend in a straw cowboy hat, smoking a cigarette and drinking a beer, leaning over Quinn. The friend offered Quinn the cigarette and Quinn took a puff before handing it back. The friend then offered Quinn's phone from the hot tub's edge, the screen lit up. Quinn took the phone, saw the screen and stood up, stepping out of the tub, splashing water in Meyer's face on purpose as she did, taking off and laughing before Meyer could get a hold of her.

Meyer bobbed over to Josh's side of the tub and squeezed in beside him. "It's not so bad, huh?"

"I guess not."

"I guess not, he says," Meyer muttered, and swigged his beer. "We can head home if you want."

Josh smiled, looking down at his hands on a beer bottle. "I think I'll stick it out."

"That's a good idea," Meyer said. He lifted his bottle a little higher. "Don't think I can drive now, anyway."

Josh shrugged a shoulder. "Looks like you got me stuck in this hellhole."

Meyer nodded, smirking, leaning forward to look at the two Chatty Cathy's next to Josh, all glistening skin and bikini tops.

Steve's leg climbed over the side of the tub, across from them, Steve claiming Meyer's vacated spot. Steve was lit up and having a blast, eating something, chewing, holding not a beer, but some fruity concoction that someone had served him, bright yellow up top, and a slushy mango bottom.

Steve drew on the straw and settled shoulder deep in the water, looking blissful. Meyer and Josh laughed.

Then Quinn waving an arm got their attention, standing near the back door of the cottage, looking like she wanted them to come to her. But it would take a lot to get them out of the tub and Quinn had to come around behind them, stick her head between theirs and explain.

Quinn said, “Irreconcilable differences, I guess, if that’s the term. Infidelity.”

Josh brightened. “Oh, yeah?”

The three of them were in the cottage’s sitting room, view toward the lake, a room with a stone fireplace, a fire burning, the gang of partiers visible out the windows. Josh stood in bare feet, dried off, the towel around his shoulders.

Quinn said, “Yeah, the guy cheated on his wife with like a nineteen-year-old.”

Meyer said, “Why do you care about *this* guy? He’s some fucking hockey bum. Guy’s a deadbeat.”

Quinn nodded. “He declared bankruptcy after the divorce.”

Josh brightened again. “He did?”

“What’s he got to do with you?”

The guy in question was Johnny Rumble. Quinn was relating back what her PI friend had told her about him, as Josh had requested.

“Nothing,” Josh said. “It was a long shot. I just thought...”

Quinn and Meyer looked at each other. “Tell us.”

“I . . . thought Devlin might have slept with his wife.”

Quinn said, “Slept with this guy’s wife? Rumble? No. It was *him* who cheated. So, you thought Devlin was messing with this guy’s wife?”

“I hoped.”

Meyer said, “Why would you hope that?”

“So Rumble would cave Devlin’s head in.”

“Ohhh. Oh, okay,” Meyer said, nodding. “Do to Devlin what you want to do.”

Josh sighed, hating this distraction from the party, wanting to be back outside and away from all of his problems. He turned to the fireplace, stepped closer and put his butt to it, letting the heat bake the back of his legs. He said, “I guess.”

Meyer said, “You’re not going to do it?”

He stood silent for a moment. “I can’t.”

Quinn said, “Hit him with a car or something.”

Josh laughed. “It’s not worth going to jail for. I was just looking for . . . Looking for...”

“You’re looking for justice.”

“Yeah. I thought if he’d fucked over Rumble, it would be justice if Rumble found out, and did what Rumble is known for. Beating a dude’s head in.”

“Universal karma failed you,” Meyer said.

“Like always.”

Quinn shook her head and Meyer said, “Don’t be such a downer.”

“I’m not. I’m just used to not getting what I want.”

“That’s bullshit.”

And it was. He’d received everything he’d asked for. He’d received all the gifts he’d requested. Or imagined he’d requested. It was just that Kimmy had given him something before even looking if it was on his wishlist. It counted as betrayal, even if she could rationalize it all away. He looked over his shoulder at the bright theater of life that he’d been a part of a moment ago, then turned back to face Quinn and Meyer. “You know, I’m going to tell you something. I did it. I did it already.”

“Did what?”

“Caved Devlin’s head in.”

Quinn stared and Meyer frowned. “What do you mean?”

“It’s why I’m on your couch. I picked up a chair, and I fucking hit him over the head with it. Almost knocked him out.”

Now Meyer stared, and Quinn cocked her head, showing the smallest smile. Meyer said, “Get the fuck out of here.”

“I’m serious. I did,” Josh said, smiling a little himself now. “I fucking wailed him with it.”

“Holy shit, Josh,” Meyer said, frown deepening, walking a step away and circling, rubbing his chin, considering it. Meyer chuckled then, decision made. “Fucking way to go, man. Where was this?”

Josh waved it away. “I don’t want to talk about it. Not tonight. But yeah, I took care of it. I didn’t need Rumble at all.”

Quinn committed to the smile, raising her eyebrows. Meyer grabbed Josh’s shoulder and squeezed it. “You need to open up to me. You should have already told me this.” Meyer’s smile was gone, Meyer now realizing what it would take for a guy like Josh Waters to pick up a chair and strike someone with it. It probably would be very bad. Quinn hadn’t pieced that part together yet, and Josh hoped Meyer would let her believe Meyer’s cousin Josh was just an everyday badass.

Josh said, “Can we just go back to the tub now, please?”

Quinn approached him, eyes slimmed, and hooked an arm under his, like she would personally escort his return to the hot tub.

He said to her, “Thank you for doing that. For having him look into it for me. It’s very kind.”

“Sounds like it was too late to help, anyway. Even if we could dig up some dirt on the guy that would pit him against your enemy.”

“I’m not proud of what I did,” he said. “But I’m glad I did it.”

Quinn walked him to the double doors leading from the sitting room to the kitchen. "I think it needed to be done."

Quinn's skin was cold, her flesh soft, and he loved the comfort she gave him. In the enduring absence of support, he'd been in free fall, and now here he was somehow landed in a stuntman's air bag. All three of them returned to the party, and Quinn let his arm go and went ahead. Meyer slapped him on the back as he passed. They climbed into the hot tub, and Josh took a moment standing under the eaves to watch everything going on around him and for once not feeling so small or alone or trapped. Everyone was having a good time. Life always moved on. Quinn's marriage had ended. So had Meyer's. And that one had been tragic to witness. But look at Meyer now. Look at *all* these people. All of them had some kind of fucked-up tale to tell. They were here today, alive enough to tell it.

He stepped down to the grass and crossed to the hot tub. Steve yelled at him for not having a drink in his hand and thrust a beer at him. He took it and popped the top. One of Quinn's brothers turned up the stereo when Eminem came on. Everyone cheered. Girls danced. Steve danced with them. Josh lifted a leg and stepped into the hot tub. Quinn's other brother hunched over the cooler, then rose with a bottle of Jim Beam dripping with ice water, and told everyone it was time for shots.

CHAPTER 8

ODYSSEY 3

With a pillow in Hyun's lap to hide what her hand did, Kimmy tried to explain to Hyun what she'd done. Hyun resisted, worried Sophie would catch them sitting too close on the couch together. Kimmy patted and squeezed Hyun's pussy over her cotton pants, and Hyun succumbed to pleasure, lashes fluttering, eyes looking lost.

"Don't . . . We can't . . ."

Kimmy's hand retreated, and a wavering image of self-reflection came over her. Sex had conjoined with badness. Sex had conjoined with supremacy. Sex was control. Wickedness was sex. She squeezed Hyun's thigh as an awful rising of guilt sickened her stomach. She withdrew the pillow from Hyun's lap and held it in her own now, easing away from Hyun, going to her corner as if an unseen referee had ordered her to do so. A time out. A time to cool off.

Hyun approached, face filled with worry that she'd disappointed her with that stark refusal. But that wasn't.

"I'm sorry, Kimmy. Not when Sophie's home. I can't . . ."

"I corrupted you."

Hyun looked puzzled, taken aback, and Kimmy couldn't look at her, instead gazing across the room, toward the hall where Sophie could have appeared and witnessed her aunt and her mother together.

“No, no, you didn’t.”

Kimmy nodded, then shook her head, capricious emotion twisting her. She said, “You make me see myself.”

Hyun slumped, silent, determined to understand, but not knowing what to say.

Kimmy looked her way. “See the parts I don’t like.”

“What parts don’t you like?”

She shrugged and bit her lower lip, considering it. “I don’t know if I don’t like it, I just . . . I...”

Hyun said, “Whatever you did, it’s okay,” and put her hand on Kimmy’s forearm.

“Devlin’s dad owns the company.”

“I know.” Hyun’s thumb stroked Kimmy’s forearm.

“The man’s only around fifty-five. He built the company himself. He’s not going anywhere. And he’s not going to retire when he’s sixty-five. He’s not the type.”

Hyun nodded, still thumb-stroking.

“Devlin knows this. Devlin wishes he was his dad. Or at least wishes he was the same kind of man. No, he thinks he *is* the same kind of man. But he’s not. He’s not like his dad at all. He’s just a spoiled, rich white man living on the laurels of the empire’s real caesar. You know what I’m saying?”

“He resents his dad?”

Kimmy shook her head. “Not smart enough to resent him. Dumb enough to think of himself as an usurper.”

“He wants to overthrow his dad?” Then Hyun considered something worse and gasped. Kimmy looked at her, and Hyun asked the mortifying question with her eyes only.

“What are you thinking? Like, you mean get rid of him? . . . No, Hyun. He’s not brave enough to try. Too afraid he’d end up in jail, I’m sure. No, he

has different dreams. He wants to make something of himself, but he doesn't want to do the hard work. He just wants to swindle his dad. I think he thinks his dad would let him get away with it if he got caught. . . . Ah, I don't know what he thinks," she said chuckling, trying to put into words Devlin's plan.

Hyun relaxed a little, but still sat poised with tension. "So, what did you do?"

"Devlin hired me so he could fuck around with Josh. He's fucking . . ." She laughed, recollecting it. "He's got a control kink or something. Who knows? He . . ." Now she looked at Hyun and realized this eroded her own elaboration on her role with Devlin Stone and Josh's involvement. But maybe that didn't matter anymore. And maybe if Hyun saw her for what she was, maybe Hyun would let her go. "He wanted me to work for him so he could mess around with me. . . . He likes that I'm married to Josh. He gets off on belittling other men." She shrugged, hoping that was enough of an explanation for Hyun, because she didn't know much more to say about it. Devlin's dick got hard as a rock knowing he was putting it inside another man's wife. And Josh was filet mignon, the finest of cuts, prepared for him over a decade, like feeding Kobe cattle excellent beer and massaging their flesh as preparation for the most decadent indulgence. Only Josh wasn't fed beer and rubbed down; no, the man she loved was beaten and humiliated and bullied into subjugation. "But Devlin didn't figure on me being a valuable asset to the company. Once he discovered that I had value to Stone Brokerage, he eased me into a scheme. And since he thought I owed him, and that we were a team, that my loyalty would be his."

"What did he ask you to do?"

She looked at Hyun, smirking. "Oh, he didn't ask me to do anything. I mean, other than work with him when he broke away from his father."

"Oh, I see. I think."

Kimmy steadied her eyes on Hyun's. "Do you want my confession?"

Hyun showed a fearful gaze, a wild-eyed look of retreat; but she stayed on the couch.

Kimmy's heart rate picked up, and she licked her lips, ready for the first time for someone to hear her most secret sin. "I stole money."

Hyun whimpered and looked away. "Kimmy . . ."

"I stole a lot of money."

Hyun stared holes in the couch seat, shaking her head, looking like she might cry. "You could go to jail for that. Are you going to go to jail?"

"Devlin has all these companies. Numbered companies. Shell companies. I think his dad knows about some of them. Maybe he got the idea from his dad, I don't know. Anyway, I find he's got these companies and they're all doing business with each other, and some of the transactions are legitimate, but I chased down some of these other more scurrilous ones. They don't go anywhere but to a Cayman company, and they just sit there. A little more digging and I see there's more than one."

"But you didn't do this? Devlin did this?"

She nodded. "Devlin's compiling money on the side. He's squaring away some Chinese investors who want some easier routes through Canada, we'll say. Like not through Stone Brokerage."

Hyun shook her head, brow furrowed in puzzlement. "There's a lot of detail you don't care about. The detail doesn't matter. I diverted funds from Cayman."

You stole the money."

"Yes. I guess."

"But why, Kimmy? Why would you do that?"

She laughed. Not because it was funny, but because it was tragic. What would she tell her? That when her mom was dying, and the world was rotten and everything she'd been promised was dissolving before her that she'd found a little thrill in shoplifting. The more trivial, the better. The more nonsensical the better. How sometimes it would have been more

exciting to be caught than to actually steal. To walk out of Shoppers Drug mart with lifted items was exciting, but wow, if anyone would have caught her? They'd find Ex-Lax or Geritol or men's shaving kits or any kind of thing that a teenage straight-A student wouldn't have. She would have cried to her dad how this was all a mistake and how she would never steal and he would know his daughter wouldn't steal those things. They had money. He was a business owner. His daughter would never do that. When you're dead inside, there's nothing more electrifying than fighting for chaos, fighting for the natural demise of everything we know, or eroding the ramparts of civility, of lying and cheating and then begging forgiveness and watching everyone around you fall into place because they can't stand disorder. Everything must be whole. Everything must make sense and be right. But nothing makes sense. Nothing is right. Everything is shit and life is unfair. She sniffed, prepared herself to phrase this for Hyun in the right way, the ameliorating way, then snuffled a small laugh. She said, "For the thrill."

"Oh, Kimmy," Hyun sighed and her forehead fell into her palm, her elbow on the back of the couch. She looked adorable; a sweet little bird broken by the reality of hard glass that looked just like bright blue sky.

She reached up and stroked Hyun's hair away from her porcelain cheek, smiling. "At first, I did."

Hyun said, "Can you give it back?"

"Not really," she said.

Hyun was astounded. "You spent it?" And then, horror of horrors: "*No*—the clothes! The clothes you bought me?"

Kimmy nodded, smiling.

Hyun was mortified, her features pinched into a silent howl of pain.

Kimmy said, "Don't worry. They were business expenses."

"What? Business expenses?"

"I want them to come after me. I want them to try to say I stole the money."

Now Hyun was blank, her eyes devoid of thought, just staring at her.

“I took the money, but I didn’t keep it. I didn’t hide it in my bank. I spent it. I spent it right from Stone. I bought things I deserve. I want them to ask me about it. I want them to try to say I stole it. I can’t wait for them to do it.”

Hyun’s head shook from side to side in a mix of horror and disbelief.

“I’m the best thing they’ve got going.” She shrugged, smirking. “I’m in complicated relationships. You can’t define love. They can’t, that’s for sure. They wouldn’t dare to try. I bought my lover the most beautiful clothes. I bought them so she looks good when I bring her to a function. I bought my husband a suit because he deserves to look as good as the boss’s son—the boss’s son who has seduced me, using his superior power as leverage. What will they say then? Nothing. Not a thing. They won’t know what to do.”

Hyun’s wide eyes roamed the room as she sought some solace in this torrent of chaos, an inexperienced rafter pitched from a kayak and looking for a safe stretch of shore before the rapids consumed her. Kimmy smiled and offered her a hand.

“I stole the money from a thief. How about that, Hyun? Yes, I did it at first for the thrill, but maybe after a while I did it for vengeance.”

Hyun’s mouth worked around, wanting to say something, maybe wanting to condemn her, maybe wanting to cast her out of the home she kept with her daughter, but she could come up with nothing. Her hand trembled in Kimmy’s.

“I bought clothes for me. But only to wear to work. I bought clothes for my unbelievable girlfriend, who makes my heart feel so good. I bought my husband a suit so he could hang out with my boss, go to the ball game with my boss and his friends. My boss who stepped over too many lines to count. If anything, it was Devlin’s poor leadership that led me astray.” Now

she showed Hyun an innocent face. Did it for as long as she could before she chuckled. She pulled Hyun's hand so Hyun came closer.

"They're not going to send me to jail, Hyun. They're not going to do anything."

Now dry and wearing a sweatshirt and shorts, Josh sat by the campfire down the slope of grass, halfway between the hot tub and the shore and the dock. The night sky was clear and stars twinkled above. Despite that beauty, the smoke chased him and even with his hood pulled over his face, he had to abandon the fire, the other fire-sitters laughing at him. One of Quinn's friends, one of the nurses, saw him coming her way and showed him the sign of the cross, one finger over another, warding him away like he was a vampire. "Keep you and your smoke away from me," she said, laughing. Someone else called him Josh the Smoke Magnet. For that particular insult, he stumbled to stand behind her despite her protestations, and sure enough, the billowing smoke column ambled their way, and she screeched with laughter and jumped away. Meyer threw a marshmallow at him and hit him right in the forehead. Steve fell off his log from laughing too hard. Someone passed him an ice cold beer can.

He thanked them, then saw it was Karina.

He said, "You out of the tub?"

"For now," she said. "You going back in?"

He nodded. "In a bit," he said.

But now, despite his lovely inebriation's dulling effect, he detected a somberness from his old friend. "You okay?"

She smiled though, saying now, "Yeah," and angling her head to the side. "Come down to the lake with me."

CHAPTER 9

ODYSSEY 4

Down near the water, Josh popped the top on the beer in the dark and took a swig. It wasn't what he was expecting. "What is this?"

"Some pumpkin ale. Perfect for the season," Karina said. "You don't like it?"

"I just wasn't expecting it," he said and took another sip, this time ready for it. "No, it's good. It's real good."

All either of them could see was the dancing silvery sheen on the lake's choppy surface. Far across the lake there was a jagged tree line, the starry night above. Karina was silent, but he figured he knew why she wanted to talk to him. He said, "Did Meyer tell you what's going on?"

Karina said, "A little. He said you were staying with him, and it wasn't the first time in the last couple weeks." She stepped ahead, going to the left of the black line of the dock extending out into the water. Steve was right. The dock was incredibly long. He could make out she was slipping her shoes off, then walking barefoot in the sand. A little off to the left, there was an outcrop of rock, a massive bulge of Canadian Shield the lake water crashed against. He followed her, watching her prance from the shore to land on the rock, take a few steps and sit down. He did the same, keeping his shoes on. It was already too cold with his shorts on.

The spot where they sat was large enough that the center point remained dry despite the rough water around them. They both sat cross-legged, facing out to the lake. Karina turned to speak, realized they weren't close enough to be heard without raising their voices over the water, and scooted closer to him until their thighs touched. She sipped her beer, stalling for time. He wasn't in a rush. She could not say a thing about Kimmy and he would be happy about it. He was going to have another beer after this one, maybe some marshmallows, if Meyer didn't eat them all. Get another burger off the grill, then another beer. Then he was going to retire to the hot tub.

At last she spoke. "I'm sorry, Josh. I . . . I should've said something."

"Something about what?"

Karina shook her head and sucked on her lower lip. "At Tiffany's party, I was there, I saw, you know, I saw Kimmy and Devlin."

His stomach turned, and he grunted, looked out over the water.

"It's not *that* I'm sorry about," she said, looking at his profile now, getting him to look her way again. "I'm not just saying platitudes. What Kimmy did wasn't right, but she's my friend and I trusted her to do the right thing and tell you and make everything whole again. And . . . And she told me she did."

He nodded, mouth squished to one side, skin crawling at this talk of the very thing he'd gone all the way north of Tweed to escape.

"Yeah, she told me," he groaned. "At least I think she did."

Karina was quiet again, and he got the sense she regretted bringing this thing up. She plucked at the beer tab, nervous. "Kimmy told me she would tell you what happened, and then I saw her at yoga, and, uh, she told me she squared it with you, and I knew she didn't, but I . . . I let it go. I'm a coward. I was too afraid to call her on it, press her, and then she started the new, uh, job, and I didn't see her anymore."

"Yeah, but you came to that party at the Dragon. You saw us there. Everything was fine."

She scrunched her mouth up. "I didn't think it was. But I thought you were man enough to figure out your own marriage."

"And now you realize I'm not and think you should have said something?"

She laughed. "No, don't be stupid. I'm trying to be real here. I feel like I failed you, and it was because I chickened out. Kimmy said it was square, and I said okay."

"Wait a second. What really happened then? She said she and Devlin got in a fight. That Devlin said something he shouldn't have and then they kind of ended up fighting for real, and then the fighting became..."

Karina said, "Yeah, that's right. That's what happened. Then there was more."

He growled in frustration and rubbed his brow. Karina said, "Forget it, Josh. It doesn't matter. I shouldn't have brought it up."

He said, "No, I know. Then they maybe started to have, like, real sex or something?"

"Let's forget the details. It's not important. She started a fight with Devlin and then they wrestled, and it got weird. Like real weird. Then they disappeared and . . . I don't think they had sex. But..."

"I know all this. It's okay," he said, waving his hand like it was nothing, even though it hurt like crazy. And Karina knew nothing of the scab which she picked. That Amy was in on it, that Devlin woke him up in the tent and taunted him with his Kimmy-wet cock. That they'd all worked him over like a chump and beat him down and humiliated him. He huffed with psychic pain and changed the subject, saying, "Kimmy said Devlin started the fight." He squeezed his nose and held his breath against an oncoming feeling of terror.

"No, Kimmy started it with him. Started the fight. She goaded him. She *wanted* to fight. We all saw it. Devlin thinks he's the master of all he

surveys and Kimmy can just talk circles around him and make him dance. It was pathetic.”

He let his nose go and took a deep breath, let it out. “It’s hard to believe. I mean, I believe you. If you’d told me a few months ago, though, I don’t think I would have. I’m sure I wouldn’t have. I can see it now. I can picture what you’re telling me.”

“Devlin’s not innocent, you know? That’s not what I’m saying.”

“I didn’t think you were.”

“It was like Kimmy wanted what happened to happen. She created it. Devlin is an easy mark.”

“You think she marked him? Think she did it all on purpose?”

Karina chuckled. “I don’t know. I don’t want to say bad things about my friend.”

“So you do think that?”

“Let’s just say she got everything out of him she wanted.”

Josh sighed and could hear the tremble in his breath. “That’s for sure.” His heart felt like a lead weight in his chest.

“Anyway, Josh, I let you down. I was a coward. I guess I let Kimmy scare me into silence or something. She *is* my friend. I do love her. I believed her when she told me that she made everything right with you. That she told you the truth. But that’s stupid. She wouldn’t tell you the things I told you now.”

“That’s not fair. Those things that are true now weren’t true then. Not yet. They hadn’t borne fruit.”

“Maybe not. But if I had told you what I saw, maybe it wouldn’t have gone this far.”

“Yeah,” he said, nodding. Then: “Wait. How far? What do you mean?”

“Well, where we’re at now. You’re staying with Meyer and Kimmy’s with Devlin.”

He groaned and set his half-finished can of beer on the cold rock between his legs, then rubbed his face and smoothed his hair back. “It’s way more complicated than that.”

“You don’t have to tell me if you don’t want to. I’m not prying. I said my piece.”

“You don’t even need to apologize. It’s . . . Kimmy’s not *with* Devlin. She’s staying with Meyer’s ex-wife right now. Staying with Meyer’s ex and their daughter. Kimmy is *not* with Devlin.”

Karina said nothing in return and he looked aside at her to see her features lit up in silver light, confused, brow knitted tight. He chuckled and said, “Kimmy’s not with Devlin, if that’s what you thought.”

“I guess I assumed.”

He shook his head and sighed, picked up his beer and swigged it again. “Kimmy hates Devlin. She wants me. She wants me back. It’s me who left.” He looked at Karina and was embarrassed by the measure of pride he couldn’t conceal. Like the failure of his marriage wasn’t on his shoulders, the dreaded weight of your wife’s infidelity crushing down your self-respect. While it was Kimmy’s infidelity that had rung demise’s bell, it was he who had the say, who had the judgment. He could choose to return to Kimmy or could choose to leave her. “Kimmy wants me back. Kimmy wants me to return.”

Karina didn’t smile or say anything, and in her silence he heard the unspoken, and just now realized it. Kimmy knew her mark. Knew how to place people where she wanted, knew how to say the things that would have them rushing to please her and fulfill her own wishes. Devlin was an easy mark for a devil like Kimmy. Did he really think he was any less easy?

The pride he’d felt washed away and now all the fun of the evening went with it. The realization of his own artless trust had been the plug pulled from a drain, and now all the good will and happy feelings were

swirling down to the town's sewer system, charging him a flow rate he didn't want to pay.

He looked out at the lake and said, "Fuck."

Karina bowed her head, maybe regretting her role in deflating the purpose of the evening. She got even closer to him, their thighs already touching for warmth, now leaning her shoulder against his, her head inclining his way. She said, "You're still in charge, Josh."

He nodded, scowling, trying to puff himself up. The night had been going so well and he didn't want the good feelings to leave. "I'm still in charge," he said.

If there was anything to salvage from this summer's debacle, it was what he brought up next, fleeing his wife's treacherous duplicity and presenting Karina with a better angle. "You remember a time we were in high school and we were out late at night, we were walking home from a dance? Like grade nine..."

Karina hummed an affirmative sound, nodding, knowing where he was going. It would be presumptuous to think this night had the same kind of impact on her. To him, that night was a milestone night, a pivotal moment in what others in the future would describe as Josh Waters. "We were just walking along Soap street, and that kid Johnny Rumble—"

"I remember. I remember him."

"Yeah, you remember," he said, glad in one way that she remembered since the moment meant so much to him, but sad in another way, that the moment also probably shaped how she thought of Josh Waters. He'd had the hugest crush on Karina Brubaker back then, and she got to see him laid out and gasping for breath, beaten and robbed and doing nothing about it. "You know I went out with Rumble and Devlin a few weeks ago? We went to a ball game."

She laughed, then looked at him. "You did not."

"Oh, yes I did," he said, chuckling. "Johnny Rumble's a fucking loser."

“Wow, big surprise.”

“Devlin runs his brain still. He’s gross. Wanted to see an *Asian* stripper, he says to me.”

When she regarded him, scrutinizing him, he waved her off, saying, “Long story. . . . Point is, I feel bad for the guy. He’s a neanderthal. He wasn’t blessed with an IQ over eighty. You know, some people just aren’t the same. Devlin used Rumble the way Kimmy used Devlin, maybe.”

Karina laughed. “I think Kimmy has a high IQ.”

“I wouldn’t argue,” he said. “But Rumble’s this sad sack who’ll never amount to anything. It’s Devlin who attacked me that night.”

“I know,” she agreed. “I see that. For sure.”

Now he rubbed his chin, looking out at the choppy water, hunching up his shoulders from the damp chill. “I, uh . . . A couple days ago, I snapped at Devlin. Like he, he just went too far.” *Did you know Kimmy’s pregnant and the baby could be Devlin’s?* “Yeah, he just said the wrong thing, and I picked up a chair, like an office chair, a fancy leather one. Heavy. Wheels on it. And I fucking wailed him with it.”

Karina lifted her head from his shoulder. “You hit Devlin with the chair.”

“Yeah, I threw it at him. We were pretty close. I got him right in the face.”

She stared, not knowing if he was joking, but sensing that maybe he was telling a true story. “You did?”

He nodded. “Yeah, hit him in the face with it. And he went down hard. But he got up and did nothing. Do you know how crazy that is?”

“That you hit him?”

“Yeah. But also that he did nothing. I thought he’d kill me for sure. I just didn’t care. In fact, he could have gone and done it and I’d have welcomed it. Like it would suit Kimmy right if she got to watch me get beat to death by the piece of shit she was fucking behind my back.”

“Oh, Josh, don’t, don’t say that,” Karina whispered and touched his face. He leaned into her, empty of anguish, devoid of sorrow, left only with a leaden despondency for all that was lost and what could have been.

Karina hugged an arm around his shoulders and squeezed him tight. She kissed the top of his head. “I shouldn’t have brought this up with you. I’m sorry, Josh. I just wanted to confess that I failed you.”

“You’re fine,” he said. “I’m not mad at you.”

She kissed the top of his head again, muttering, “I shouldn’t have brought this up.”

And she was right. Everything had been fine this night. This night had realigned the misaligned. He leaned into her more, crumpling for a moment and burying his face in her hands. It felt wonderful to have someone hold you without thinking they wanted more from you, or perhaps they didn’t even mean it at all. But now he shook his head, knowing these thoughts were wedging him deeper in an intractable Chinese finger trap. He sat up, pulling away from Karina, laughing now and breathing in cold crisp air. He tipped his beer back and finished it. He crushed the can in an impressive display of masculinity that got Karina to laugh with him. He said, “I need another drink.”

CHAPTER 10

ODYSSEY 5

Kimmy followed Hyun to the bedroom, but it was only to say good night. They stopped at the door and Hyun looked at her, frightened and timid, but still showing the tiniest smile.

Kimmy said, “I wish we could be together tonight.”

Hyun looked down the hall, then whispered, “I do, too.”

Kimmy smiled. “You’re very special to me.”

Hyun’s smile faded and her eyes bloomed with something large and wonderful.

Kimmy said, “I’d like it someday if we could, and we didn’t have to hide it.”

“I don’t want to put any pressure on you. I don’t want to put pressure on our, um, friendship. It is what it is.”

Kimmy nodded. “It is what it is.”

Beyond Hyun’s shoulder, she could see the bed where Hyun slept, and the bed where the two of them had shared intimacy. It would be wonderful to lie with Hyun tonight. Even if it were just to have their bodies touching under the covers. There was so much more she wanted, of course. So much more to be teased and tested. She wanted to show Hyun the video of Devlin. Let Hyun see Devlin’s magnificent cock in her satin panties; far too big a monster to be contained by something so feminine, her hand pulling it

out, stroking it. She could picture Hyun disgusted by its sight. And there was something funny about that; amusing. Something that made her want to show Hyun, just so she could console Hyun afterward, stroke Hyun's hair and tell her not to worry, that big, scary man-thing wasn't hiding under the bed or in the closet, it wouldn't try to claim her innocence while she slept. Other things, too. There was a distinct fantasy she had devised. One she and Hyun would explore when Sophie was next with Meyer, and she and Hyun had time alone. That was, of course, if Josh still exiled himself from the best game he had going. If she played her cards well, she could have them both, Josh and Hyun, enjoy both of their pleasures and comforts, and do them both well.

She said, "If I'm not in prison, I think we should look at getting you a bigger apartment."

"Don't say that," Hyun said, soft features scrunched with worry.

Kimmy smiled and touched Hyun's cheek, comforting her. It was good to joke about her current fortune. Dwelling on the reality would be too sobering. Too frightening.

"I don't want you to worry," Kimmy told Hyun, and then smiled like she had no care in the world. The only problem they faced was a lack of accommodation. Sophie could sleep with her mother in Hyun's bed, but Kimmy was too tall for Sophie's bed, so there was no point. "Promise me you're not going to worry."

Hyun looked down. "I can't promise that."

"Can you pretend?"

Hyun smiled a little and nodded.

"Thank you," Kimmy said, looked aside to make sure there was no sign of Sophie, then dipped into Hyun's bedroom and kissed her soft mouth. Hyun was reluctant, but wanted the kiss so much she allowed it, if only for a brief moment.

Kimmy stepped back into the hall. "I'll be on the couch."

“You can take my bed, Kimmy. I told you.”

“No, no. We already talked about it a million times. Just go to sleep and I’ll see you in the morning.”

Hyun nodded, showing a little more smile now, and closed the door. Kimmy stood for a moment waiting to see if Hyun felt adventurous and would call her in, but it didn’t happen, and that was okay. She could go home and sleep in her own bed, but right now she would prefer having company nearby, sleeping on Hyun’s couch, knowing she wouldn’t be alone in the morning.

Meyer, who didn’t even smoke, laughed so hard the cigarette nearly fell out of his mouth and fizzled in the hot tub. He plucked it from his lips, held it in the v between two fingers, and touched the neck of his beer bottle to Josh’s shoulder. “Right here, buddy. I can picture it. Somebody get me a sharpie and I’ll do a drawing for the tattoo guy to trace.”

One of the nurses said, “Or tattoo *girl*.”

Meyer showed her dubiety, narrowing his eyes at her over his shoulder and saying, “A woman? A woman tattoo artist? Yeah, right, like that’s a thing.”

The nurse doffed her cowboy hat and swatted him with it, and Meyer loved it, almost losing his cigarette again. Even Josh was laughing now, hunched over, the body of his own beer bottle submerged in the bubbling tub water. The tub was down to seven passengers in its therapeutic journey, seven of them still up at two in the morning with the stereo cranked. Karina laughed, too, though her eyes had gone sleepy in the last half hour. He nudged her knee under the water and said to her, “I told you not to smoke that joint.”

She assured him she was awake and sat straighter. Her eyes looked no more lively.

Meyer gazed at Josh's shoulder and Josh lifted it from the water so his cousin could dream up how he saw this tattoo. Meyer said, "Yeah, I can see it. A crumpled office chair. Like the legs are broken. The seat is twisted away from the back. One of the wheels you draw over here, maybe by your nipple," and then Meyer attempted the lamest titty-twister ever, taking the longest time to put his beer bottle into the hand with the cigarette so Josh could see the twister coming a mile away and turn his nipple out of reach. Meyer tried anyway, practically pleading for Josh to surrender the nipple for punishment. They wrestled lamely in the water until Quinn pulled Meyer away and stole his cigarette. "Hey," Meyer said, dismayed, following the cigarette until he fell to Quinn's bosom and she hugged him and smoked his cigarette.

Between puffs, she eyed Josh. "You're the man, Josh."

"What can I say?" Josh smiled, leaned back and put his arms over the lip of the tub, a man of leisure and accomplishment. "Don't fuck with me when there's office furniture around."

"It's true," Meyer said. "I once saw him brain a kid with one of those old-timey typewriters. Fractured the kid's skull like a farm-fresh egg."

One of the nurses, sidling up next to Steve, looked horrified. "Really?"

"No," Josh said. "He's being a goof. I've never hit anybody before."

"Not until the time was right, hey, Joshy?" Meyer winked at him from Quinn's cradling bust.

"I'm the one who used to get hit. Not the other way around."

Quinn said, "There's a time and place for everything. I'm glad you acted."

He grunted and nodded, leaning deeper into the tub, arms still outstretched, beer in hand. His head felt light and far away, like a mylar birthday balloon above colorful party favors for the birthday boy. He

smiled. His heart did a steady lub-dub-lub-dub, slow, and a little burdened by alcohol, but altogether feeling kind of very good. He had done the right thing, hadn't he? And, man, what if he hadn't stopped? What if he'd kicked Devlin in his donkey dick and goat balls when Devlin had been down on all fours in a bath robe? Wouldn't that have been something? It would have. And if he'd turned the tables with the P.I.? What about that, Joshy-boy? Imagine that one, old son. Rumble showing up on Devlin's doorstep, Devlin unprepared, bewildered, wondering what his old friend and evil henchman was doing at his apartment at this hour, Johnny half in the bag, empty bottle of Jack in one meaty fist down at his thigh, shirt partly untucked, soaking wet from a rain storm, and old Johnny steps in and puts Devlin Stone in the fucking hospital. And whereupon Devlin awakens and must learn once more how to finish the alphabet. Nah, that one was too far.

Now Josh was chuckling, eyes closed, bringing his beer to his lips and draining it. Someone nudged his arm, and he looked to see one of Quinn's beefy brothers passing him a shot glass of amber liquid and he took it and popped it back. Yes sir, the heavenly fire of oak-aged corn mash. It went down icy cold and wonderful. Quinn's brother refilled it and this time Josh passed it over to Quinn, who took the shot glass and fed her boyfriend Meyer like a drunken baby. The sight of his cousin getting so masterfully mothered had him in sudden stitches. Meyer looked at him, chagrined, his cousin's hair going this way and that. Now Quinn put the cigarette down where Meyer could suck on that like a fresh teat, and Meyer did, puffing away, playing it up to make Josh laugh.

Quinn said, "What was it that finally made you snap?"

Josh asked her what she meant and Meyer said, "What happened that made you throw a chair at this piece of shit?"

Josh said, "Trust me, you don't want to know."

Quinn said, "No. We *really* want to know."

On the phone's screen, her own hand liberated the world's biggest, sexiest penis from a pair of satin panties. It looked ridiculous in her elegant grip. And the ridiculousness was what excited her most. Devlin Stone was armed with a gargantuan weapon; a thing of incredible masculine beauty.

She could watch this video a hundred times. It was the most intense level of pleasure an innocent could conjure. A thing of bottomless betrayal. Something so dark and forbidden some would fear referencing it, doing so only in whispers.

But that was the wonderful depth of her depravity. A depth where only the most competent diver could descend.

It wasn't the deed on the screen that aroused her, it was the context. And the context arrived through her sultry enticement; plans whispered to her big-dick lover. Promising to Devlin all of his darkest fantasies, painting with words a picture almost impossible to believe. Almost impossible. But she and Devlin had done wild things together; wild things behind her husband's back. And in time, Devlin had let her know how it aroused him to lure Josh into their tryst. Devlin fantasized about Josh watching him fuck her with his big dick. Devlin fantasized about showing another man all the things he could do, his arsenal of sexual tricks and his hedonistic literacy. Devlin had thought he was the master. But it was Kimmy Chang or Kimmy Waters who orchestrated the pleasure for *both* men. It was she who owned their dicks and their brains and played their desires like a piano. Maybe Josh wanted what Devlin wanted. And wouldn't that be grand? Wouldn't that be a salvation? For she had made clumsy mistakes at first, back when Devlin's surprise appearance in her life dropped a line down the deep well of despair she'd fallen into. A dark and dingy bottom-hole where she wove baskets and hid from the world. Half way up the rope she started to climb on her own, no longer content to be lifted. Soon she wanted all that Devlin

had because Devlin didn't deserve it. Devlin wasn't smart enough to stop her. Wasn't smart enough to think a woman like her wanted more than to lift her skirt and have her big bad businessman boss give her what he knew was the good stuff. Devlin couldn't comprehend he wasn't enough as a man to satisfy a woman like her.

But now the video got to the good stuff, and under the blanket her fingers moved quicker. Soft wet sounds crackled from inside her panties as her eyes narrowed and she tuned to the words she spoke to Devlin. Devil's promises. Promises so sweet and lurid she could coax a prideful man into the same panties he'd bullied her husband for wearing. This was what aroused her. Dominance. Mastery.

Her knees bowed in and out as she listened to her sweet spoken covenant. Stroking Devlin's big cock while he trembled, and she told him his baby grew inside her belly. She controlled him with her hand, with her lies. He was a big-dick puppet who would do anything she wished now. She promised him her husband. Promised him she would birth Devlin Stone's baby from within Josh Waters' sacred marriage. She promised him they would work together; that she would do all the things he wanted her to do. She would help make him millions. He would own his own company. And Josh? Josh would raise their baby. Josh would be Devlin's baby's stay-at-home dad. Josh would live in their house and they would work together. Josh would cook and clean and when they came home, Josh would watch Devlin make Kimmy Chang come like a demon, his massive cock buried inside her, the head stretching out her deepest seams.

She came while Devlin came. She came watching his cock surge in her hand and shoot thick white ropes onto the mirror, again and again, like it would never stop coming. She had bit and kissed the back of his muscular arm, recording him the whole time.

The urge to cry out was strong, but she choked it back, her thighs clamped on her hand between her legs, her body shuddering under Hyun's

blanket.

CHAPTER 11

ODYSSEY 6

SATURDAY, OCTOBER 3

An anxious fluttering roused him. That strange kaleidoscopic shiver that sometimes swirled in the viscera. It woke him with inescapable dread. Dread and regret. And at first he did not know where he was or what was happening, but soon his reality took shape, brought to form like cold wet hands on a frenzied potter's wheel. The urge to retch hit him, and it wasn't just the drinking. Something else was there, something dark and provocative, and if he thought he could return to sleep and forget about it, figure it out in the light of day, he was wrong. It whispered the nameless dread right in his ear.

You told them. You told them everything.

He sat up with a start, fear racing in his mind, his eyes wild and rolling in the dark like a frightened horse's. Fuck. He'd pissed himself. His crotch was wet. No, it was from . . . *From what?* The hot tub.

No. It was urine. He'd pissed the bed, and holy fuck, what bed was this? *Whose* bed was this?

God, someone was in it with him.

Now he was reeling, his heart galloping with fright, his mind piecing together the night, hearing his own voice repeating truths he swore he would carry to the grave. He'd told them. He'd told them what she'd done.

Kimmy. Kimmy and Devlin. He'd told them he watched. He told them how big Devlin's cock was.

Shame and humiliation tormented him now, and he leaned away from the person in the bed with him, his stomach queasy, his brain sloshing in his skull. And his skull! Oh, the pain. It rung like a tuning fork. The booze burned his nose. Not just whisky and beer, but all kinds of *different* beer; lagers, and pumpkin ales and IPAs and some Quebecois strong beer. And bourbon. Too much bourbon. He felt the toxic flame of barrel-aged alcohol in his nose, like if he lit a cigarette, his whole face might catch fire.

He buried his face in his hands while his heart turned to cold rock, knowing he'd humiliated himself to strangers, said out loud the things that burned his soul. His wife cuckolded him. His wife shamed him to his face. There was no coming back and there was no turning away. Any pride he owned had soured. No one would ever respect him again. Another man had fucked his wife and his horse cock did things to her he could and would never do. He'd told them. He'd described it all to them.

The fucking horror of it all.

He would puke. It was coming and nothing would stop it. Fuck, he'd pissed the bed. The wet wasn't just on his shorts; it was on the sheets. Oh fuck, this was a bunkie. Yes? No? Fuck, *Quinn's* bunkie. He'd gone to his cousin's new girlfriend's family cottage and told them all the horror show of his sex life, played it out for them in a drunken charade, then he'd pissed in one of their beds.

And who was in the bed?

He could make out the shape in the growing gray light of predawn. Hips and a narrow waist. A woman. He was in bed with a woman. She faced away, curled like a shrimp in bed next to him. Had they had sex? Who was it? Blond hair.

Karina.

He was in bed with Karina.

He was in bed with Karina and he pissed himself.

Never in his life had he been so overwhelmed with bottomless remorse. The dread was insurmountable. A deep green despondency bashed its waves against the hearty ramparts of shame and guilt and dread. Kimmy's boot would forever stomp on his face. He wished to blip out of existence. Anything that would ease this mortal pain. He crawled out of the bed, and clawed himself to stand, then staggered away, heading to where he thought he might find the door. There was a window by the bed and his shadow cast out ahead of him, stretching over Karina's sleeping hump. His stomach churned and heaved. There was no bathroom in a bunkie, no plumbing at all. He needed air, that was all. Then maybe he'd stop panicking, stop his mind from ping-ponging. He could hear his own voice regaling to everyone the glory of Kimmy's orgasm delivered by her boss. In a hotel room. A luxury hotel room in Yorkville. Why would he tell them anything?

That's why I hit him with the chair.

Oh god, no. His hand covered his mouth as he found the doorknob, twisted it and stepped outside into the cold, wet morning. Tears were in his eyes and they froze in the frigid air. He stumbled along the bunkie's tiny deck, thinking he would head to the bushes, but there were bunkies everywhere. Lights were on in the cottage, but he would never go there. He would run into someone who'd heard his tale of dirty cuckolding and they would scamper away, cringing from the sheer awkwardness of Quinn's new boyfriend's weird cousin. The tears were on his cheeks now, and he headed down the hill, headed to where he'd shared the quiet moment with Karina. The only moment for months where he'd felt human. Felt like he mattered.

The gray dawn was quiet and still, the smoke from last night's fire hanging heavy. The tub was off, the patio lights shut. Beer bottles and cans littered the ground. He wove through them, getting into the grass and down where the crashing waves on the rocks would hide the sounds of one

mournful loser hurling up his drunken guts. He would call an Uber. He would be gone before anyone woke up. He would escape social death.

But there were no Ubers out here. He *would* see their faces, witness their avoidance, see his truth reflected in their painted sympathy and pursed lips. No one would say anything. Their silence would crush him.

His stomach was twisting, and the bile was splashing the back of his throat. The cold seized his wet crotch and shrunk his manhood to a raisin. His feet were bare and slippery. He wore urine-soaked shorts and a sweatshirt.

He headed to the rock where he'd sat with Karina, then changed his mind, knowing he was going to vomit and not wanting to desecrate that hallowed ground with the contents of his drunken stomach.

He found the dock and pulled himself onto it, then stumbled its length, remembering now it was the dock to end all docks, heading far out into the lake, large enough to accommodate an armada of jet skis and bass boats, stumbling into the cold wet air, the morning mist folding around his shoulders. It was perfect. The never-ending dock would take him far away from the shame. It would take him where no one could hear his vomitous cries. One look over his stooped shoulder and it was confirmed: He couldn't see the shore. The shore couldn't see him. It was him alone, stumbling deep into a purgatorial brume.

A man burdened by inescapable shame. A man betrayed by his love. Betrayed and humiliated. Bullied by the woman he trusted. Bullied by a ghost of trauma past. Bullied by his own lust and a weakness bred by fear. A tragic agreeableness formed out of cowardice; an affable, witless charm that would rather lead him to believe he wanted his wife to open her legs for Devlin Stone because that was easier than lifting a chair over your head and collapsing the schemers who wanted you under their boot. And the whole while he'd been a man capable of pride and the courage it would take to stand for it. He could have lifted that chair overhead on the first day.

Each bare footstep now brought him deeper into the heart of the cold, into the frigid wet misery that prickled his skin and opened his eyes to the harsh realities of existence. It was amazing how far this dock extended into the lake. How far would he have to travel to find release?

He lifted his woozy head and closed his eyes, the mist on his cheeks, walking into glorious oblivion.

Sophie was the first one up, and Kimmy woke on the couch to the sound of her niece flipping the large pages on a children's picture book. It was a warm and dry sound, and a pleasure far greater than a weekday alarm. She roused to find Sophie on the opposite sofa, dressed in her pajamas, content to sit with her aunt nearby and wait for her to wake.

Kimmy said, "Good morning," and Sophie smiled, looked up and said it back.

She sat up, and despite the charm of the morning, felt the guilt of how she'd gone to sleep last night, given the innocence her eyes opened on. Before Sophie scooted over and looked for attention, she slipped out from under the blanket and headed into the kitchen, asking over her shoulder if Sophie would like some juice. Sophie said no thank you, and Kimmy ran hot water in the kitchen sink, still coming awake. There was a distinct absence in her heart, like something should be there and it wasn't. She wasn't whole. The strongest urge came over her to call Josh. Ask him how he's doing. And not tease him or harangue him, not goad him into defense, but ask him if he wanted to hang out today.

She washed her hands in the sink, then wiped her face with a damp paper towel, able now to return to Sophie without worry.

"Is your mother up?"

"She's awake. She was getting dressed."

“That’s good,” Kimmy said and sat back down on the spot where she’d slept. Sophie came over to her sofa and brought her book. Kimmy held out an arm and encouraged Sophie to take up the space at her hip, Sophie opening the book and flipping pages again, intricate, colorful drawings on every one of them.

“What do you want to do today? Do you want to go to the zoo?”

Sophie liked the idea, but was hesitant. “We could do stuff here.”

Kimmy said, “Is your auntie running you ragged, keeping you too busy?” She bumped Sophie with her hip and Sophie giggled. They had a big night out last night, after all. You didn’t need to make every minute a spectacle. Was she trying to prove something? She leaned over and kissed the top of Sophie’s head.

Hyun’s light footsteps preceded her, slipper sounds on parquet flooring coming down the hall. Hyun came in soft and radiant, smiling, seeing Kimmy and her daughter cuddled up on the couch. “Can I make coffee? Or do you want tea?”

“Tea would be excellent,” Kimmy said, and moved to rise. “I’ll come and help.”

“No, sit there, stay with Sophie,” Hyun said, and their eyes met. Hyun smiled sweetly, bashfully, then looked away, saying over her shoulder, “It’s not a two-person job.”

Kimmy laughed and dropped to sit with Sophie again, putting an arm around Sophie’s narrow little shoulders and admiring the drawings, her mouth and nose hovering above Sophie’s sweet head.

Hyun returned with a teapot and cups, and brought Sophie the juice box she’d said no to earlier. Kimmy poured them two cups while Hyun worked the straw into the box for Sophie.

“Sophie wants a lazy day today,” Kimmy said, waiting for Sophie’s reaction. Sophie’s mouth dropped, and she looked at her aunt, who smiled.

She hugged her niece. “Let’s hang around here today,” she said to Hyun now.

“I’d like that,” Hyun said.

This was a morning better than the one she would have had alone in the apartment, Josh off who knew where, probably playing video games with Meyer all night long. That was no good for him. But this was good. This was healthy. Hyun sipping tea, checking her phone, Sophie sipping juice and reading her book. She rested her hand on her tummy. Soon Josh would have responsibility. They would start over. Continue where they should have been in the spring. That was if the worst things didn’t happen. If they didn’t, it opened the way for the best things to happen.

Across from her, she watched Hyun’s color fade, along with the small smile she’d showed. Her eyes were lowered to her phone. When she raised them, they were wet with fear. She looked directly at Kimmy, and something about the fear Hyun showed froze Kimmy’s heart. No words were spoken, but she knew right away that reality had shifted and something horrible had happened.

Kimmy said, “What is it?” Her voice was thin, and it cracked. Sophie looked up from her book.

Hyun whispered, “It’s Josh...”

CHAPTER 12

ODYSSEY 7

For what seemed the hundredth time, Kimmy asked Hyun, “Why wouldn’t he call *me*?”

The “he” in question being Hyun’s ex-husband and Josh’s cousin Meyer. Why wouldn’t Meyer contact *her*? Why would he contact Hyun?

Josh was in the hospital. Josh had fallen in a lake somewhere up north and somehow had almost drowned and also was suffering from hypothermia. Who the fuck had been looking out for him? Who the fuck cared about him?

Kimmy and Hyun and Sophie were in the Leaf doing about a hundred and twenty east on the 401, headed out east to bum-fuck country where some assholes lead her husband to his drinking demise. With no one telling her, she knew Josh had imbibed too much and somehow ended up in the frigid water.

Fucking three months ago, he’d chugged most of a bottle of fine bourbon and left her alone with Devlin Stone. He was his own worst enemy. Always had been.

“And he’s not awake?”

Hyun said, “Kimmy, he’s going to be okay,” then looked into the backseat with that telltale expression of worry. Sophie was in the backseat. Yes, don’t frighten Sophie. She understood. But in not frightening Sophie,

there were truths she was missing. Was Josh okay? Was he not awake or was he awake? If Meyer had texted her instead of Hyun, she wouldn't have to rely on this filter of the messaging.

Hyun said it again, face turned, to include Sophie in the message. "He fell into the lake and he was rescued. He wasn't coherent, and they warmed him, but out of an abundance of caution, they sent him to the ER in Peterborough—"

"Yeah, but who are they? Who is this they? Who was he with?"

"He was with Meyer. Some of his friends from work. Karina was there." Hyun paused, then said, "And Meyer's new girlfriend."

"And who is she?"

Behind them, Sophie said, "Quinn."

Kimmy took her eyes off the road for a moment to regard Sophie in the back, buckled into her big girl kid's chair. "You know her? You've met her?"

Hyun said, "You've met her, too."

"I did?" Kimmy recollected now a new woman with Meyer, some kind of friendship happening over the summer. "Okay," she said. The information was slow in coming, and every time she heard something new, it was like starting all over again. So, Josh and Meyer went up north to have a good time, and Josh's friends were invited, but she wasn't. That fucking hurt so bad. And no one looked out for Josh? "How did he end up in the water?"

Hyun said she didn't know. "It was this morning, Meyer said."

"They were up all night?"

"I don't know. Maybe."

There were all these questions and no answers, and she was going to go crazy before they got to Peterborough. There were so many hefty thoughts crashing against her retaining wall right now. Her lovely man, hurt and endangered, pushed into an unexpected ordeal just when he'd faced his

limit . . . and then off on the distant horizon, the threat of steeper waves thrashed her way, whipped into a frenzy under charcoal skies fattened by stormy rains. Things like how Josh could have ended up in the water, things she dared not even think about. Things like how sorrow proved too much for Josh Waters to bear. There were evil truths she didn't want to face. She'd done awful things to the man she married. Awful things to a kind and considerate human, a man stronger than he even knew. But Josh's strength could only bear so much, couldn't it? Josh's resilience was a webwork of scar tissue. The outside world had beaten him and he'd healed over and over for many years, creating a sturdy barrier to injury thicker than most. But it wasn't impenetrable. And no one could cause more harm than the ones you showed your secrets to.

Kimmy squeezed the steering wheel, gritting her teeth. "I want to know how he ended up in the water."

"Meyer says they don't know how it happened."

She shook her head and gritted her teeth harder. "I'm going to own that bitch's cottage by the time this is over."

Then she closed her eyes for a moment. There was no easier escape than an adversary. No better avoidance than turning the tables and going on the offense. But this morning the game clock had run out, and it was harder and harder to shield herself from the thrusting knives she sought to avoid.

You did this. This is you. You put Josh in the water. Josh tried to escape using the only path you'd left him after all the terror you caused.

The gritting teeth slackened their grip and began to chatter. Her jaw trembled, and she had to wipe her eyes. She sniffled, squeezing her eyes against tears. "How cold is the water right now?"

Hyun stared out the window. "I don't know, Kimmy. It's freezing."

On a cold and rainy-gray Saturday morning, Kimmy and Hyun and Sophie crossed from the hospital parking to the entrance of the Peterborough Hospital's emergency department. An assemblage of familiar and unfamiliar faces greeted them in the quiet ER. The divide struck her hard. A congregation of somber-faced white people facing three Asian women. She'd never felt like an outsider before in her life, but a cultural, historical estrangement she'd never felt before slapped her in the face this morning. The expressions on the gathered faces weren't ones of relief, seeing Josh's wife arrive to comfort Josh, they were pale faces blooming with the blush of blame and reproach, and her knees weakened, feeling discovered and exposed, and her mind racing to imagine all the truths Josh could have told them, all the wicked things his evil wife had done to such an innocent, undeserving man. For the first time in months, wickedness didn't rile some forbidden spirit in her, some impish demon that reveled in the maddening pleasure of sexual domination. This morning she froze, her interior frosting with the wet, dreadful wind sweeping across the waiting room's confine. No charm or reliable resolve saved her; no lies danced on her tongue. She couldn't even smile. Her heart galloped faster and faster, like it raced headlong to its cliff-side doom. Her shoes remained pinned to the scuffed linoleum, afraid to move closer, afraid they would seek revenge. Hyun looked back to see why Kimmy had stopped, and still Kimmy couldn't smile. All those faces turned their way. Meyer, Karina, Steve, some girl she didn't recognize, and the one named Quinn, who now that Kimmy saw her, she remembered. No one smiled or waved. Guilt washed up from Kimmy's pinned feet like a sickly sheath, crawling up her back and over her shoulders. She felt sick to her stomach, and her cheeks blazed hot as a stovetop.

Josh had told them. Josh had told them all what his wife had done. Josh had told them how his wife cheated on him, and how she'd slept with her boss, and how her boss had ruined Josh's youth, had bullied Josh, and how

she'd betrayed Josh, and lied and lied and lied, and how Josh had watched his wife have sex with his high school bully in a hotel room in Yorkville—all to fuel his wife's hungry furnace of a sex drive.

At last Steve raised a hand and nodded to her, and Meyer rose to greet them. Karina turned away. The two other girls stayed seated, heads bowed. A glimmer of hope shone in this dismal *tableau vivant*; what she'd thought was reproach could be guilt; their somber expressions could describe not blame, but shame over their failure to protect her husband from harm. They bowed their heads to avoid the menace of the righteous and faithful wife whose husband they'd neglected. But then Karina walked away, following the direction in which she'd turned, heading down the hall and through a set of double doors. The cold returned, and with it the hard and racing pulse that had her head swooning once more.

Meyer greeted Hyun, taking her hand a moment. He looked her way then, eyes troubled, camouflaging the hate he might hold for his beloved cousin's traitorous wife. Then Meyer stooped, hugged his daughter and stood up with her, Sophie clinging to her daddy. Meyer told her, "Josh, is fine, okay, baby? He's going to be okay."

Sophie nodded, a stoic little girl, patient to let matters play out so she could understand, polite enough not to buffet her father with a barrage of childish questions. Watching, waiting, learning. One corner of Kimmy's mouth turned up in the attempt at a smile, proud and envious of what Hyun and Meyer had created. And bereft. Her hand went to her stomach, thumbing below her navel.

Hyun said, "What happened, Meyer?"

"We don't really know. Karina found him. They were in bed together"—then to Kimmy, weary, saying, "Not like that, not in bed together. She went in to make sure he was okay. They were in their clothes. Then she woke up, and he wasn't there and she looked for him and she couldn't find him. She called out, and some of us got up, but Karina found

him before we were down there. He was in the lake. On the shore, but, you know, unconscious.”

“How long had he been in the water?”

Meyer shrugged, unsmiling, eyes hooded, enfeebled. “Quinn’s a nurse. So’s her friend Emily. They said like no more than half an hour. I don’t even know how he got in there. He . . . They cut him out of his wet clothes, brought him up to the fire and dried him and warmed him and everything, but he was still, like...”

“We’re so lucky they were there,” Hyun said. She looked Kimmy’s way and showed a small smile that made Kimmy believe it was encouraging or instructive; a reminder that she should show gratitude. And now she felt guilty for the ire in the car on the way here, making claims of vengeance and punishment.

Kimmy didn’t smile, but she said, “Everyone was asleep?”

“Yeah, we had all gone to bed. Karina helped Josh to his bunkie and then stayed with him because Steve was staying up later with the rest of us.”

Kimmy said, “You guys were having a party.”

Meyer nodded, his mouth turned down in a way that showed he harbored no guilt for not inviting her.

“I guess he drank too much,” she said, and Meyer nodded. She added, “That made the hypothermia worse, didn’t it?”

“You can ask the doctor when he comes out. We’re all waiting here. He was here fifteen minutes ago, said Josh was doing good. Quinn probably saved him. Quinn and Emily. They airlifted him here to—”

Kimmy put a palm on her forehead. “Airlifted him? Are you serious?”

“We were up north. Far. There are only so many hospitals. The ambulance came and took him, but they wanted to warm his blood and they couldn’t do that in the ambulance. They took him wherever, and, uh, he

came to Peterborough in a helicopter. The rest of us came down in my truck.”

There was nothing for her to say. Nothing for her to ask anymore. Nothing to add or subtract, no point in fighting and no urge to ingratiate. She felt emptied and distant and all alone. Meyer held Sophie. Hyun and Meyer were close. They’d been a family once, but now they weren’t. Sophie wasn’t hers. Hyun wasn’t really hers, either. Not so she could share their affection and consolation before others. The only person in the world that mattered was all alone in an emergency bed, having his blood warmed so he wouldn’t die. She had nothing of her own. No one. No one trusted her. No one should. Betrayal had elevated so much of her desire to mountainous heights, and while the view was nice at first, the oxygen was thin.

Josh beached on a frigid lake shore, and no one claimed to know how he ended up in the water. But she knew why. It was his wicked wife who had put him there, and everyone in this room was just afraid to say it to her face.

CHAPTER 13

ODYSSEY 8

Sophie took turns with her mother, then wandering to the other side of the waiting area where her father sat with the woman named Quinn, and Meyer would put Sophie up on his knee. Everything going on around here overwhelmed the poor girl, who had no frame of reference for a moment like this one. Two groups of adults sitting not saying anything in an emergency room in a distant city. It had been a mistake to bring Sophie; they could have avoided this hardship. The last thing a child needed was spending somber times in a hospital, the future uncertain.

Everyone here had said Josh was going to be fine, but she hadn't seen him yet. What if no one had the courage to tell her the truth? What if they'd shielded her from the truth because Sophie was present?

She leaned closer to Hyun. "You can take my car home if you need to. I'll get a train later."

"I'm staying with you," Hyun whispered.

"I'm thinking of what's best for Sophie."

Hyun didn't answer, staring straight ahead and chewing her cheek, brow furrowed with worry.

Kimmy wrung her fingers for a long moment, twisting with anxious worry and fear, before leaning to Hyun again. "I think . . . I think I'm going to go look for Karina."

Hyun nodded, leaning forward like she would stand. “Do you want me to go with you?”

“No, you stay with Sophie.” Kimmy stood and the other group’s eyes tracked her, and when she looked their way, they looked down. Her stomach sank lower, her heart going down with the ship. Sorrow creased her brow, and looming regret followed her as she walked across the waiting room, headed to the double doors where Karina had disappeared.

It took a long journey down hallways, left and right, through multiple sets of doors, and up escalators, before finding out there was a Tim Horton’s, and then thinking to check there for her friend.

Kimmy stood at the doorway of the huge cafeteria with a Tim Horton’s in it, looking out over all the tables, past mourning or worried visitors and gaggles of scrub-wearing staff. Karina had a good seat for two at the very back by a tall window looking out onto a small park. She picked up a tea from the Tim Hortons and made her way through all the tables to get to the window, standing about a dozen feet away before Karina looked up, sensing her there. Karina said nothing, her face somber, eyes tinged in pink. It hit her again that maybe there were truths no one had told her yet, that maybe everything wasn’t so fine and dandy with young and handsome Josh Waters.

She stepped nearer to the table. She said, “Do you hate me?”

Karina shook her head. “No.”

“Can I sit?”

“Yeah.”

She sat down opposite Karina in the small fixed seat and set down her tea. Karina’s face showed faint lines at the corners of her down-turned

mouth. There was a long silence, and Kimmy broke it saying, “Is Josh really okay?”

Karina pursed her lips, looking down at her hand on a ceramic Tim’s mug and her plate with the crumbs of an absent muffin. “Depends what you mean by okay.”

The answer chilled her, and the possibility of a gloomy outcome blossomed in her imagination. Josh altered, brain-injured, or worse: Josh never waking up. “He might not be okay?”

Karina looked up, her pink eyes harder now. “He’s fine, Kimmy. At least that’s what they said. You didn’t talk to the doctor yet?”

Kimmy shook her head. “I was just sitting down there, waiting.”

Karina stilled, eyes lost, staring at Kimmy’s tea mug. “I don’t know how he got down there in the water.”

“What happened?”

Karina’s lost eyes widened, brow raising again. “I found him on the shore. Soaked. It was so *freezing*. He was . . . *blue*.” She looked up, eyes wet. “But he was shivering. He was alive, and...” She stopped, lips slimming into a small thin line.

“Why was he in the water? How did he end up there?”

Karina shrugged. “I don’t know.”

“You two were in a bunkie?”

Karina looked annoyed, like maybe Kimmy had meant the question as a curve-ball accusation. She said, “Not like that.”

“I didn’t say anything.”

“We were in a hot tub. All of us. Josh was having a good time. A real good time. But then he was like nodding off, and Meyer was like, Josh has to go to bed.”

“He was drunk?”

“We all were. We were all having a good time. It was a great night. Josh . . . We cheered him up.”

Kimmy's eyes swelled, and she put an elbow on the table, touching her face, hiding it from Karina.

"Steve was bunking with Josh, but Steve was still up and having a good time and I was ready to call it a night, so I took Josh to bed. I stayed with him to make sure he was okay. And then I woke up, and he wasn't there."

"And those two girls...?"

"Quinn and Emily? Yeah, they took charge. They knew what to do. We just helped them, get them whatever they needed."

"But Josh is going to be okay?"

Karina nodded. "Yeah. He was better at the cottage, but Quinn said he was stage four or something like that and she was worried about his heart. They got an ambulance, and the paramedic said it was Josh's lucky day and they could get him on one of those *Ornge* choppers."

Kimmy warmed her hands on the hot cup, letting them off when it scorched, then putting them back on. Quieter, she said, "Why's no one talking to me?"

Karina sighed, then shrugged. "Why? I don't know, Kimmy. Because you're a lawyer and your husband fell into the lake at their cottage and they served him alcohol. And they think you must be a nasty piece of work. I keep telling them you're not. Or at least you weren't before."

Kimmy squirmed. "Why do they think that?"

"They know what you did." Karina got closer, her face angrier, that soft worry creased with meanness. "They were there to cheer up a guy whose wife cheated on him."

"They know that? Who told them that?"

"I don't know who told them. Like, Meyer," she said, bothered by the question, like it was the least important part of this whole conversation. "Who cares who told them? We all knew why we were there."

"Josh didn't tell you any details?"

Karina frowned, studying Kimmy. “Do you want to tell *me* some details? Why would *anyone* want to know something like that?”

“He didn’t tell you anything?”

“Josh didn’t tell us *anything*. The whole point of being up there at the cottage was to cheer Josh up, get his mind off it. The last thing we’re going to do is bring it up.”

It was too much of a relief to take it at face value; too fortuitous that Josh would have a chance to tell all their friends all the things his wife had done to him, and not indulge; not vomit forth all the crimes committed against him. She said, “Get his mind off of what? What did he tell you?”

“He didn’t tell me anything. It was Meyer. Meyer called me and said Josh was in the dumps, that he was in a really bad way, and do I want to go to a party for him. And I asked him why’s he in a bad way—but I think I already knew why.” She looked hard at Kimmy. “Meyer said he thought you two were done, and I hated to ask, but I just had to know, and Meyer told me, yeah, it was Devlin. Just unbelievable, Kimmy. Devlin and that new job, he said. But I knew it didn’t have anything to do with the job. Not at first. You went after Devlin *before* there was a job.”

Kimmy muttered, “I didn’t go after him.”

“I saw it with my own eyes, Kimmy. Josh never told us what you did. Why? What does it matter? Did you do worse than break his heart?”

She covered her face with both hands, wishing this day had never dawned, that Josh and she could manifest their own reality, that Josh would indulge all her lusts and sate himself from the runoff. “No,” she said. “I just broke his heart.”

Karina nodded, glum and yet satisfied, like Kimmy had been put in her place. “Josh told us he hit Devin with a chair.”

Hands still on her face, Kimmy nodded. “Yes, he did that. He hit Devlin with a chair. I saw it with my own eyes.”

“Why did he do it? Did he catch you together?”

“No, that wasn’t it.”

Karina looked away, jaw muscles flexing. “It would have to take a lot for Josh to do something like that.”

The image replayed in her mind of Josh and Devlin, and her holding their penises together and of the sexual taunting; all the work she thought might lure Josh into sexual abandon and yet the result may have pushed Josh over the edge. Or at least to the brink. She said, “Yes, but it wasn’t about me. Everybody has a breaking point. Josh is a good guy. He hit Devlin with the chair for the sake of . . . I don’t know, his family.”

Karina didn’t understand. “What *about* his family?”

Kimmy sighed, an enervating weight settling on her, a hopeless burden that pushed away all the fencing she’d struggled to set for her garden’s shape. “Not his family. Our family.”

The miscarriage. Karina looked uncomfortable. Kimmy said, “Devlin insulted Josh’s ability to create one.” Now she lay a hand on her stomach. “And that was too far.”

Karina understood what she meant now. “That is too far. He’s such a piece of shit. I fucking hate that guy and I have no fucking idea what you saw in him.”

“I don’t, either.”

“Was it Amy? Did Amy put you up to it?”

The opportunity was obvious; it stood up at the back of the class waving an eager hand for her attention. Karina had just held open the door, and Kimmy could walk right through it. Step through the threshold of forgiveness and into a room where little blame would come her way. *Why, yes, it was Amy. I’m Amy’s victim once again.* She pursed her lips, then rubbed her brow, and admitted it had nothing to do with Amy. “I did it all on my own. No one made me do it.”

Karina’s lips stayed slim, her head wagging in terse and admonishing jags. “I don’t know why you ever hung out with Amy or any of those

people. They're such jerks. So fucking arrogant."

"I was just friends with Amy."

Karina had no more to say, putting her joined hands up by her face and looking out the window, like they were done here. She should leave Amy alone, go back to Hyun and Sophie, see if the doctor was around, but she said, "Do you hate me?"

Karina put her hands down, and her eyes followed. Kimmy could read the exasperated body language, the restrained anger. She said, "I don't think you deserve Josh. You deserve Devlin."

"You said he's a piece of shit."

"Yeah, I did."

"That's what you think of me?"

"You had everything, and it wasn't enough."

"I didn't have everything. I—"

"Come on, Kimmy," Karina said, looking up to meet Kimmy's eyes. "What the hell do you want? What would be enough?"

Kimmy bowed her head and thought of the spring, before any of the paths she strode took their wicked turns. She thought of losing her baby and how fucked up that was, and maybe telling Karina how she had biological urges and maybe her body craved seed and thought Josh's seed had failed her, and those biological urges hijacked her senses and injected her with a maniacal desire that defied all common sense. But it was all mumbo jumbo, and any credit Karina might offer on such a flimsy scheme was long ago cut in half for non-payment.

Karina said, "Hey," to someone, and Kimmy looked up to see Meyer coming to the table. "What's up?"

Meyer said, "I'm going to take Quinn and Emily back up north. Emily has to work a shift tonight." Then to Kimmy, "The doctor was out. He said Josh is going to be down for a while. I'm going to come back through Peterborough. I can take Hyun and my daughter home. I'm going to come

back here to the hospital in the morning. . . . I assume you're going to stay here?" He raised his eyebrows and waited, looking like he wouldn't be surprised if she said she wasn't. Did he think she would go to Devlin tonight?

She said, "Yes. Of course I'll be here." If this was how they thought of her after she cheated, what would they think if they knew the truth?

CHAPTER 14

ODYSSEY 9

SUNDAY, OCTOBER 4

The doctor told her how lucky Josh was to have such expert care so close at hand. The doctor told her that the two nurses at the cottage did everything right; they cut off his clothing; they transported him horizontally; they took care Josh wasn't jostled or upended. The state Josh was in, his sensitive heart was on the precipice of arrhythmia or ventricular fibrillation. The doctor told her Josh was unresponsive, hypotensive with hyporeflexia, decreased renal blood flow, and a host of other symptoms that sounded terrible. It was the hypotension they treated first. Though Josh had a body temperature close to thirty-two, "where we see the worst outcomes," the doctor said, Josh had a strong heart, strong enough to fight the shock and trauma of what he'd endured. The doctor said it again: "You're lucky your husband has such a strong heart."

Josh's lips were blue. She kissed them.

Though it was only October, the lakes up north were cold enough to kill someone given enough time. Josh couldn't have been in the water for more than half an hour. If he had, he would be dead.

They admitted Josh on Saturday afternoon. Admitted him to a room shared with an older woman, separated by a curtain. Josh had the window that looked out to the helipad where the *Ornge* helicopters came in and out, their muted whoop-whoop-whoop riling her a few times overnight. *That was how Josh had arrived here.*

Meyer took Steve and Karina and the two nurses back up north, and a few hours later he'd dropped by for Hyun and Sophie. Before he'd taken them away from her, at least he'd offered her a solemn nod before parting, knowing what he'd left her with and the trial she must be enduring. And then it was her alone. It was a relief. She'd been freed from the prying, judgmental eyes of the others, yes, but now she was left with the corpse of her murdered marriage. Here lay one young man of value and the kindest of hearts; an innocent, one who sought no quarrel, no victory, only a man who wanted life to be whole and complete for those he loved. And this man whom she loved had embraced oblivion, and she would have to be the grandest of liars to make the claim she had nothing to do with it.

What if her actions had sent Josh on this quest for oblivion? What then?

Who could she tell herself she was?

The man she had married, the man she had loved, lay dead to the world in a hospital room far from home; in his slender, peaceful arms, the nurses had implanted two large-gauge peripheral IVs; one of the IV bags was filled with a crucial hot fusion of isotonic crystalloid. He'd gone through bags of it. He sported a bladder catheter and another line in his femoral artery. Without all this aid, without all this intervention, Josh would be dead.

She sat with him deep into the evening, then wandered away, going out to her car, driving into Peterborough, buying a quick dinner of eggs and fruit at a Cora's, then stopping at the Marks for a change of comfortable clothes. Then it was back to Josh's bedside, this time moving the chair around to the curtain side, the older woman moaning in her sleep behind her, and Kimmy staring out the window at the blinking lights of the helipad.

But on this side of the bed, she could caress Josh's hand. His hand that wore his wedding ring, the red dots of the helipad glinting off the gold, his fingers interlaced with hers.

Kimmy sat in a tweed chair by the side of the bed, curled on her side, eyes closed, sleeping with her hands up under her chin. He'd watched her for a quarter of an hour. No makeup, lips cracked, long silky black hair across her cheek. She wore sweatpants and a sweatshirt he didn't recognize. He was in a hospital; that was clear. But dread rolled downhill and picked up steam, realizing there was much he'd forgotten, and much he'd missed. Who brought him here? What were the circumstances? While he watched Kimmy sleep, that dread-ball had picked up speed, barreling its way through his muted psyche. *Those things he'd told everyone.* Those awful truths, those bizarre events that had led to the demise of his marriage, he'd spewed them out for everyone to see. And to escape it all, he'd headed down a long path into the mist, a path with a frigid end. He was too warm to feel so cold and dead inside.

At last, Kimmy's long eyelashes fluttered, and he watched his beautiful wife come awake, her eyes cast to the foot of the bed. How long had he been here? How long had *she* been here?

For a moment, Kimmy was oblivious to his consciousness, waking, eyes roaming the room, half-lidded in some contemplative reverie. He cherished the moment, seeing his wife in her habitat, unaware of his cognizance, lost in whatever fold of reality had occurred while he was dead to the world. A vision came to him of a path leading into a mist, a path that led nowhere, and of him following it to its end. He shivered.

Kimmy looked his way, then jumped, startled by his open eyes. She rushed to him, slinking off her chair and taking his hand in both of hers.

“You’re awake!”

He tried to answer, but his throat and mouth wouldn’t cooperate.

Kimmy kissed his cheek, and he fumbled around, trying to get his arms to move so he could touch her. She stood and poured him a cup of water from a plastic bottle. When she asked him if he’d like to sit up, he nodded, and she pressed buttons behind the bed, hydraulics raising him to sit comfortably. Kimmy held the plastic cup of water to his mouth while he drank. He licked his lips and asked her where he was, his voice a rough croak. She told him Peterborough Hospital, and he asked her, “What happened?”

Kimmy’s relieved expression dimmed. “You don’t remember?”

“I was at the cottage. I went in the water.”

Kimmy’s eyebrows bowed to a forlorn tent. She asked him softly, “Why did you go in the water, baby?”

He groaned, then closed his eyes, shaking his head. “I don’t know,” he said. “To get away.”

Kimmy sat down, put the cup aside and took his hand in both of hers. “To get away from what?”

“Aw fuck,” he groaned, and closed his eyes again. “I said too much.”

“What do you mean?”

“At the cottage. . . . I said . . . I told them . . .”

Kimmy’s thumb stroked his knuckles. “What did you tell them?”

He winced and grimaced, lamenting, “I’m so stupid.”

“Is that why you went in the water?”

“I just wanted to get away. Get away from it all.”

Kimmy lowered her head, her brow touching his hand. Her back shook, and when she spoke, he could tell she was crying. “I’m so sorry, Josh.”

His head inclined on the pillow, chin tucking down, regarding her clutching his hand like he was a saint. He said, “It’s okay,” wishing his limbs worked better so he could console her.

“I put you in the water,” she sobbed.

He said, “I put myself in the water.”

“All those things I did to you . . .”

“Don’t cry,” he said.

“You wanted to get away from it all,” she moaned.

“Because I told them what happened. Told them what you did. Told them what *I* did.”

“You told them what I did. You told them you hit Devlin with a chair.”

And now he could remember that corrosive dread he’d woken with in the bunkie; that assured belief he’d spilled all the beans in his drunken stupor. He remembered describing Devlin’s enormous penis to everyone, and how much Kimmy loved it. *That* was what he’d run from. He’d run from facing the people he’d told, facing them with shame in the cold gray of a new dawn. But he wouldn’t tell them *that*, would he? Even in the dankest craze of a bourbon-fueled monologue, surely he would never describe such depravity, such *perversity*. It seemed ludicrous now to think he would ever admit to *anyone* what his wife had done to him, all the dark paths she lured him down, and how far he’d followed her before it ended.

As much as those descriptions and confessions rang in his ears, there was no way he’d admitted his sins to his friends. He asked her, “How do you know that?”

Kimmy lifted her face so he could see her, tears racing her porcelain cheeks, her lashes fluttering. She let go of his hand to pluck a tissue from a square box on the over-bed table. She wiped her eyes and her nose. “Because they told me. They told me what happened. They hate me, Josh. They hate me. They won’t even *look* at me.”

His stomach turned, knowing how that would hurt, and now feeling guilty. “Because of me?”

“Because of *me*,” she cried, and rolled her eye upward before dabbing them again with the tissue. “And they don’t even know anything. Anything

except I cheated on you.”

There was nothing more for him to say, and now that the moment had passed, there was a certain justice in them knowing. And he didn’t like how that made him feel. “It’ll be okay in time,” he said.

She shook her head, lips pursing. She turned to him. “Do you want something to eat? You must be hungry.”

“Yeah. It can wait. How did I get here?”

Kimmy explained how Karina had found him, how Quinn and the nurse named Emily had rescued him, resuscitated him. They warmed him up. Quinn’s brothers carried him back to the house. They cut his clothes off him. All the peace he’d woken with soured. How *humiliating*. How *devastating*. After all the fun of that evening, he had to ruin it for everyone, getting too drunk and then imagining insurmountable horrors and—

He said, “I fell off the dock.”

Kimmy studied him, pretty features twisted in pain and sorrow. “That’s what happened?”

He nodded, then frowned. “What day is it?”

“Sunday,” she told him. “You came in yesterday morning.” He nodded again, and she said, “Meyer should be here soon. Your parents are coming.”

“My parents?” He scoffed. “No, come on. That’s too far for them to come. When can I get out of here?”

“I’ll get the doctor.”

“Where’s my phone? Will you text Meyer, tell him not to come?”

“Why not?” she said, trying to soothe him because he suddenly wanted very much not to be in bed or in the hospital or anywhere, really.

He settled, finding the struggle to get out of bed exhausting, letting Kimmy guide him to sit back again.

He said, “When can I get out of here?”

She said, “Probably today. Tomorrow morning at the latest. How do you feel?”

“I’m fine,” he told her. “My lower back is aching and my ass is sore, but I feel fine.”

“Meyer has your phone,” she said. “It was in the bunkie. I’ll text him to stay in Ajax if you want that.”

His eyes met hers with new reluctance. He looked away. “And my parents, too.”

She kissed his cheek, said, “Was it an accident?”

Now he looked at her again, his brow troubled. “What do you mean?”

“Did you go in the water by accident?” He could see her eyes swell up like balloons, like they would burst tears at any second. A vein rose in her temple and down her neck.

“Of course,” he told her. “I walked on the dock. This dock goes forever. And I was in the fog, and I just . . .”

“What, you just walked off the end?”

“Yeah,” he said, doleful, frowning as he recollected.

Kimmy’s eyes stayed on him, more on her mind, more she wanted to say. “You didn’t . . . You didn’t call for help?”

“I did,” he said. “I shouted for help. I guess no one heard me.”

“Did you?”

“Of course I did. . . . I must have.”

Kimmy drew in a long breath and stood, looking faint. She looked around, talking quietly, saying, “I’ll get my phone, I’ll, I’ll text Meyer. I’ll text your dad.”

“Thank you.”

She found her phone on the chair where she’d been sleeping. “I’ll find the doctor. I hope you can come home today. But I’ll stay another night if you can’t.”

“Kimmy, I . . . I don’t want you here, either,” he said. “I want to be alone for a while.”

CHAPTER 15

ODYSSEY 10

When the doctor released him, it was almost seven o'clock at night. A nurse arrived with a wheelchair and he told her his wife was waiting for him down the hall. Kimmy sat on a waiting room chair with her eyes closed, her hair a tangled mess, leaning her head against the wall. She looked nothing like the woman of this summer and fall. The one who'd taken him on the wildest ride of his life. What would this nurse think, having seen Kimmy in the room earlier, then banished from her husband's presence to wait where he couldn't see her? She wore sweats and sneakers, a pea coat, no makeup, no glossy hair. She'd never looked more beautiful. But the beauty he cherished right now was attainable; a woman who made sense on Josh Waters' arm. Maybe if the nurse saw Kimmy waiting for him with upright posture, gleaming hair pulled back from her beautiful angular face; saw the black raven's eyes rich with intellect and cunning; saw her in an expensive suit and thousand dollar shoes and gold earrings, well, maybe then the nurse would say, ah, now it makes sense. But would it? Maybe the nurse would look at Kimmy, then at him, and she would think, how did those two ever come together? Maybe she would think the only reason this man didn't want that stunning wife in his room was she scared the shit out of him.

But this Kimmy, rousing now from her waiting room chair, showing a tired smile to the nurse, uttered a quiet thanks, and that nod that said *I've got it from here*, this Kimmy didn't scare him. This Kimmy carried their baby for a brief time in the spring.

And maybe held another anew. *Or maybe the baby was Devlin's.*

The nurse bid them *au revoir*, and Kimmy wheeled him to the elevator. They rode it down. The two of them the only people in the large cab, he said, "Thanks for waiting."

She said, "You're stuck with me, Josh. And I'm taking you home. Nowhere but home."

The ride home was quiet, mostly high-speed highway, south out of Peterborough and then before they knew it they were zipping along the 407, no other traffic. Josh said nothing, and she played quiet music to ease the crushing burden of silence.

Then, south on 412, fifteen minutes from home, Josh turned down the stereo. Black farm landscapes on either side of the highway, sky the most midnight shade of blue above them, he said, "I don't want you to think I went into the water on purpose."

She nodded, eyes on the road, said, "Okay." She wanted to believe him, and chewed her cheek, waiting for him to say more.

The urge to ask Kimmy to join should be stronger. That familiar pull he'd always felt, the one that sought peace, the one that had allowed the events over the summer to worsen. But sitting here now and watching TV alone, he felt little lure to seek his wife out in their apartment, inquire what she

was doing, ask her to come sit with him. If he did, she would do it. It was what she wanted. And somehow knowing she wanted it made him reluctant to offer it. Offering his time and space to her would be forgiveness. And if this summer taught him one thing—it had taught him many—it was how Kimmy would take any amelioration as encouragement. She'd short-circuited. Malfunctioned. Went off the rails. And he'd been unaware, sitting in the passenger car as the train plunged down the slope to oblivion. Every time he reclaimed her hand after letting it go, she closed her grip on him and took one smiling step backwards, drawing him deeper into hell. But the greatest trick she could pull, that anyone could ever pull, was convincing him he wanted to follow.

So he wouldn't hold out his hand anymore.

He would watch TV alone and ponder the hardest questions. Like, how had she and Devlin conjured genuine enjoyment out of the ether? How was it that when he considered his beautiful Kimmy sneaking behind his back to fuck Devlin, the arousal was real? There was evidence. It was no illusion. They had done something to him. Some sorcery. There were parts of the journey he'd loved. There were even parts he'd like to relive. If only they didn't provoke so much terror.

Somehow those two demons had splashed his sexual lust with gasoline, then handed him a struck match. He'd ignited in a wicked flash. He'd accepted the match and self-immolated in the fieriest, most self-destructive pagan festival. A wicker man. But the construct was an effigy of his weakness, and the flames consumed it, swallowed it whole. Kimmy and Devlin had burned down the part of him he despised. Devlin would never do such a thing. To Devlin, Josh's weakness was a toy. A favorite one he would never want to part with; Devlin was a selfish but lonely rich boy whose toys replaced the love and affection absent from his life.

For his newfound strength to be true, strength in the absence of his destroyed effigy, then it couldn't also be true that he'd gone into the water

because of Kimmy.

Therefore it *wasn't* true.

He was drunk; he was clumsy.

But he was free.

The weekend had begun with the surprise announcement of her impending arrest. Its inciting incident had been the alert her husband had almost drowned in freezing water and was almost dead from hypothermia. He'd tried to step off the edge of the world because she'd created an existence too cruel to abide. Then a wonderful moment of reflection where she saw her nasty self in the eyes of others. None of what she'd done now made any sense. She'd carried an enormous load up staggering heights for what reason? To show people she could do it? And now what? Now she'd dropped it all; only a step from the top, and all she'd assumed and tended and cared for now lay broken below. And here she was, still near the top of the ladder and wondering whether her path would be up or down. Her hands were empty. Her load unburdened.

The summer had been a high like no other. The spring produced an existential rift, a tectonic-sized one, and as the unavoidable tsunami came to shore, she'd got up and surfed the crest. But now all around her was the devastation that no could have believed she would avoid. There had been glory in the hubris. Only a cold emptiness remained.

It felt good to cry. Out in the living room was the man she'd fallen in love with and swore to devote herself to. They were supposed to forge a union and start a family. Josh sat huddled in blankets watching movies, his back to her, saying not much more than simple sentences.

The act of caring for him seemed false. Even to her. She would love to go to the kitchen and make him dumplings or something he loved. Would

love to sit on the couch at his side and watch movies and laugh and be close. That was gone now. Irretrievable.

There had been a time in the summer where she'd thought the only way out of this whole complication she'd begin with Devlin was to push through. To commit to the sin and cross her fingers and hope Josh would fold, or even convince himself it was his own idea. There had been no harm in trying, she'd pondered. The damage had been done.

But she'd been wrong about that.

She slunk off the foot of the bed and went into the bathroom, took a towel to her eyes and cheeks. The mirror told her nothing. Old Kimmy was there. Meek Kimmy Chang; the one too timid to tame the world. The one content with little. The one cheated from the future her youth had promised; cheated by her mother's death and her family's nuclear dissolution.

This was spiritual death. And it came not all at once, but in agonizing gasps.

She changed into fresh cotton, dumped the things she had bought for hospital comfort into the laundry, tied her hair back and left the bedroom. Josh still watched TV, his back to her, not saying anything as she entered. She bypassed the couch and the TV, went into the kitchen, and, not knowing what to do with herself, opened cupboards, checked the fridge. Brought out ingredients for dumplings, some hopeful part of her in charge now. She wrecked it by asking Josh before she'd begun: "Do you want dumplings for dinner?" Josh said he didn't. She said, "If I make some, would you bring them to work for your lunch?"

"No, thanks."

She packed away the ingredients, poured a glass of water, but had trouble swallowing it. A tight, dreadful knot formed just above her collarbone. She tried massaging it, but it wasn't the kind of tightness that could be relieved that way. Her chest was tight, her breaths short.

She dumped the glass and put it in the dishwasher, went into the living room, stood behind the couch, behind Josh, asked him what he was watching.

"I don't know," he said. "Some reality shit. These guys have rentals in Australia, trying to see who has the best."

"Is it good?"

"It's fine."

She was too afraid to sit. Afraid he would shoo her away. She said, "Are you going to go to work tomorrow?"

"I feel fine. There's no reason not to. I don't *want* to. Samara and Gabrielle will be there." He shook his head, lowered it, sighed. "Maybe I'll stay at home."

His honesty seemed like an opening and she sat down on the chair beside the couch, facing his side. "You could take the day off."

"No," he said, not looking at her, eyes on the television. "Maybe that makes it a bigger deal. Maybe if I show up on Monday, it's like it wasn't too bad."

Words of solace stuck in her tight throat. Anything she said right now in support of his trial by cold would be thrown back at her. *It's all your fault! Why are you even sitting in here?*

"It's so fucking awful," he said with a dying man's sigh. "So humiliating."

There were things she'd like to say. Like how Gabrielle and Samara probably were worried about him. They didn't see the event the way he imagined it. They wouldn't see him as a tragic figure who'd walked off the end of a dock after his wife had destroyed him. Josh thought they saw him the way he saw himself.

She said nothing. Josh watched TV in silence, hair messy, eyes tired, luggage sagging below them; his beard was shaggy. Somehow he looked good this way, and she wished she could sit beside him. But right now, he

repelled her with an unseen force, like they were polar opposites. She said, “I’m going to go to the store. I want to send flowers and something nice to those two girls. I’ll pick up a card.” She rose. “Do you want anything while I’m out?”

Josh didn’t look up, his expression unchanged. “I suppose you’ll go to work tomorrow?”

She was drawn to the seat, felt like collapsing, but stayed standing. Just come clean. What was the point anymore? There was nothing to salvage. Tell him you took money and you don’t even know why. Tell him you took it sometimes to prove to yourself Devlin was a simpleton. Tell him you even did it sometimes because he’d been mean to you when she’d warned him already. Tell him how you used Devlin’s money to get a tailored suit for him to wear to the ball game.

Tell him you’re going to go to work tomorrow to discover your fate. Tell him tomorrow night you might be in jail or at least in a room somewhere in the city, talking to the RCMP.

She slumped, drooping her chin to her chest, imagining Josh not waiting for her when they released her. Maybe no one would wait for her.

She said, “I have to.”

Josh nodded once, unimpressed and showing a mask of indifference.

CHAPTER 16

ODYSSEY 11

MONDAY, OCTOBER 5

Gabrielle and Samara had both seen him naked. He was sure of it.

They came together to his desk almost first thing in the morning, full of concern and showing nothing that told him they'd seen any humor in what had happened. That must have been an awful morning for them. Waking up to a medical emergency, everyone running around thinking he'd died. They'd cut his clothes off him. Kimmy had bought all new clothes for him to wear home from Peterborough. But while he was unconscious these two nice women he worked with and whose company he enjoyed had seen him at his weakest and most vulnerable. He'd been in frigid water for around twenty minutes. His dick and nut sack must have retreated to the warmth of his belly. His dick and nut sack had spent all day yesterday up in his body, and that was after a whole medical team warmed him with an infusion. He was pale and thin and Gabrielle and Samara had seen someone they should respect reduced to his weakest form. If he'd seen either of them in a similar disposition, would he be able to see them the same way again later? Would seeing one of them with legs splayed after some dipshit misadventure, their labia all shriveled and out in the open, leave no impression? He'd like to think he could be the better person, be above that juvenile, underdeveloped judgment, but deep down knew he'd never escape thinking about it whenever he was with them.

He tried playing it off with humor. “At least I can say I was in a helicopter now.”

Samara palmed her forehead, eyes rolling back like she felt faint. “Oh, my god.”

“Oh, I wasn’t awake though,” he said, like that made it less of a big deal.

Gabrielle said, “I can’t believe you’re here today. That’s wild.”

“Can’t keep a good man down,” he said, first thing rolling off the top of his mind, an inline arsenal of similar bromides shunting into place.

“We were so worried. Sorry we couldn’t make it to the hospital, we—”

“Don’t worry about that,” he said. “I was out, and then I was awake, and then I was going home.”

Samara sat on his desk corner, eyes brimming with wet compassion. “What were you doing out there? Why did you go in the water?”

“You saw that dock. It goes on forever. I woke up in the middle of the night and thought it would be fun to, you know, take a, take a whizz off the end of it.”

Gabrielle smiled at last, shaking her head, looking at him with wonder, and he thought, just maybe, a little bit of admiration. “I’m just glad you’re okay,” she said.

Samara said, “You were almost *blue*. Your lips *were* blue.”

He said, “The water was surprisingly refreshing.”

Gabrielle said, “You *were* there to clear your head,” smiling, but then letting a little kitty cat out of the bag. They also knew why they were at the party that night.

He smiled too, letting her know the reminder of the party’s purpose did not offend or hurt him, leaning back in his office chair and putting his hands behind his head. Samara played with her necklace, brows knit. He said, “I think it’s pretty clear now.”

Both women smiled and then exchanged a look. Gabrielle said, “There are about a dozen women here interested in what’s going on with you.”

He sat forward again, studying them. “What do you mean by that? What is going on with me?”

Gabrielle said, “We don’t even *know*,” then laughed. “But you should know there are some women here at Swanson who have their fingers crossed.”

“Fingers crossed for what?”

Samara slid off his desk corner and she and Gabrielle sauntered away, Gabrielle saying, “Don’t be coy, Josh. You know you’re a catch.”

The elevator doors opened, but she stayed in the cab, eight-thirty Monday morning, back at work. Anything was possible. Anything could have met her past those open doors.

If someone arrested her today or at least summoned her for questioning, she dressed showing power. Tall in Louboutin heels; slim black Prada pant suit; long, black Gucci overcoat; hair back and shining; red lipstick.

There were two competing philosophies, standing in the closet this morning, wondering what to wear. One: if she dressed well, they’d think she’d done it. If she dressed down, maybe they’d think she was too meek to do what Stone Senior accused her of. But, shit, she *had* done it. She’d stolen money. Better to dress nice because when she dressed nice, she thought different, acted different, and any edge to keep herself out of jail was worth a shot.

The lobby looked as it looked every morning. Tami at her desk, her office with the light off, sounds of the photocopier from down the hall. It smelled like coffee. She stepped into the lobby and as the doors closed behind her that’s when she expected the RCMP officers to step out from

wherever they were hiding and ask her to step aside. But nothing happened. Tami greeted her the way she greeted her every day. Smiling now, getting papers together, no look on her face that said there was something going on and she was told to act normal. Tami did not have the wherewithal to act unknowing given a salacious tidbit like her boss would be arrested later today or would be fired. Tami's innocent face showed nothing; like she hadn't heard even a rumor about what her boss had done.

Kimmy greeted her and asked her for messages.

Tami said, "Lou in Kingston, following up on the Pearl River deal; and a contract from GS Freight is coming by courier this morning."

Kimmy picked up the mail that Tami hadn't put on her desk yet and leafed through it, finding nothing alarming. "That's all?"

"That's all."

No messages from The Law Society; no messages from Aaron Berg, Esquire; no messages from Stone Senior. All morning she went on like business as usual, and then at eleven, she got a call from the worst person imaginable.

He said, "Good morning, Chang. You free for lunch?"

"It's tight today, Devlin."

"I'll rephrase: You're not free for lunch because you have an important business meeting that you can't get out of."

While talking to him, she'd busied herself, as if he were in the room and she was avoiding eye contact and he would get the message and leave her alone. But he wasn't here. This was avoidance. She bowed her head and narrowed her eyes, rubbing her temple. Across the room the cranes flew from right to left, the lucky painting her father had bought her for her office when she'd landed this lucrative job; the same painting she'd thought she would witness marched out of the lobby and thrown on the concrete last Friday night. Her breaths came quick and her chest tightened. She said, "Where?"

He said, “The usual place. Twelve-thirty. We’ve got important things to discuss.”

Devlin’s tone was hopeful and upbeat. Did he know by now what was happening? Did his father tell him? Devlin’s voice didn’t sound like he knew what she’d done. But Devlin was sinister. Devlin would take great delight in hurting her if given the chance.

The RCMP were waiting in “the usual place.” Or Berg and Devlin’s father. Or maybe Devlin and his buddy Rumble, and they would pull off her jacket and punch her in the stomach like they’d done to Josh all those years ago. *It wasn’t even that long ago.*

She told him she’d be there and hung up. Then tried to get back to work but her hands were shaking. She couldn’t hold a piece of paper without it flapping like a dying bird’s wing. She squeezed her hands into tight fists then opened them, doing it over and over, holding out her hands then and staring at them, looking for signs of weakness. Cursing herself.

Steel your nerves. For fuck’s sake, your future depends on it.

Devlin answered the door. “Not like you to be late, Chang,” he said, smiling, eyes casual, hooded. Confident.

Her heart galloped in her chest, everything sensible in her brain telling her she never should have come here. The effort to manifest a confident aura pushed her to the limit; no one even knew she was here in this apartment with Devlin.

This was the last place she should be. This was dangerous.

And what about Josh?

It was too late to save Josh from harm. Or from worrying. He wouldn’t care she was here. He would expect her to be here. She should have told him last night. She should have told him everything. And why hadn’t she?

Afraid he would disown her. Afraid the timing was so wrong, it would seal the deal in what seemed like Josh's final verdict on her and their marriage. No good. Wicked. Foul. Maybe one more day to right the wrongs, then she would tell him. If she'd told him, she wouldn't have to be here. Maybe he would have understood. Maybe he would have held her, tried to comprehend all the inexplicable badness that had flowed from her. Josh could have said there's no way you're going back. We're going to figure this out together. We'll get you a lawyer. We'll make things right.

She said, "I got here when I could," and stepped past him and into the foyer like she didn't have a care in the world. Devlin closed the door behind her and she closed her eyes, expecting him to hook a powerful forearm around her neck and lift her off her feet, take her to the couch and beat the shit out of her. His hand touched her back, strong but reassuring, not looking to grip her by the back of the neck. Had he ever taken Josh like that, taken him by the back of the neck and pushed her husband's face into the toilet? Had Rumble flushed?

"Better late than never," he said. "I'm glad you're here."

He took her coat, hung it up on a hook, and then did the strangest thing: he held up a finger to his mouth, as if warning her to be quiet.

Bugs in the house? The RCMP? Why would he shush her?

Devlin saw her scowling, then smiled, nothing to worry about, taking her arm and walking her into the apartment. Not to the couch where they would usually go, and not down the hall to the bedroom, which sometimes they would go to first, bypassing the casual pre-fucking drinks. She was reluctant to go with him, but didn't resist.

He said, "Let's get you a drink," heading to the minibar by the window.

"I can't," she said, reminding him. "I'm pr—"

He put a finger to his mouth again, silencing her. She frowned, eyes narrowing on his, showing him he had to explain. Devlin said, "Perrier?"

"Fine," she said. "What's going on?"

Devlin went to the bar and plied two ice cubes from a bucket, tossed them in a glass and topped it up with fizzy water. He said, “We’re not alone,” and held out the glass for her to come and take it.

CHAPTER 17

ODYSSEY 12

Kimmy sipped her water, psyche roiling and eddying, but only showing calm on the surface. She said, “Who’s with us?”

“I told you we had business here today. That wasn’t a joke.”

“Okay. So what’s the business?”

Devlin made like he would answer, but paused as they both heard a door opening down the hall. He held up a finger like she would know in a second anyway, and they listened as the clop of shoes came down the hall to the main room.

A man emerged from the hall and stood under the square archway between the foyer and the living room. He was young and well-dressed; a man not dissimilar to Devlin. Despite the suit’s quality tailoring, his muscular bulk was noticeable.

Devlin said, “Kimmy, this is my buddy, Glenn. We went to university together. I told you about him before.”

“Glenn, nice to meet you,” she said, leveling her eyes on Glenn’s crystal blues.

Glenn stepped down into the living room and shook her hand, his hand huge but soft and warm. “Hi, Kimmy. I believe I spent some time with your husband.” His voice was deep but creaky, like he held it tight in his chest and only let out a little air at a time.

“With Josh?” Just uttering her husband’s name sunk her heart. Not only had she wounded Josh with her own weapon, she had thrust him into Devlin’s dark and dangerous waters, thinking he could swim with sharks if he only tried.

“We met him for a Jay’s game,” Glenn said, then winked at Devlin. “I think we kept him out of trouble.”

Devlin said, “We had a good time that night.”

Glenn still held her hand, looking at her again. “I liked Josh. Josh is a good guy.”

“He really is,” she agreed.

Glenn stayed smiling, putting his hands in his pockets. Devlin said nothing. She said, “What’s the business we’re doing?”

“You know the business, Kimmy,” Devlin said.

And she figured she was in trouble. The business. The business she’d exposed to Devlin’s dad. The reason she was here. Devlin and Glenn were going to pummel her, throw her on the bed and fuck every hole, cackling and laughing and punishing her the way she deserved. And she deserved it. She’d done awful things.

Then Devlin stepped away, heading for the passage into his kitchen, stepping down, waving like they should both follow. “You see, Glenn’s my deals guy. My money man, my main business hombre.”

Kimmy followed, stepping into the kitchen where sometimes she would reheat her lunch after having lunchtime sex with Devlin Stone while Josh was busy at work being a good husband. Glenn followed behind her.

Devlin turned when he reached the kitchen table and put out a hand, gesturing at a spread of books and papers and ledgers and file folders.

Her lips slimmed and her breath held choked in her chest, her neck tight, heart racing. All this paperwork. Evidence. It would outline and trace her transactions out of Devlin’s shell corporations into other shell

corporations, back into Stone accounts, and then into her pocket to buy extravagances. Just for the thrill.

Devlin said, "This is the game plan."

She looked at Devlin, and he smiled. She said, "What game plan?"

"Jesus, Kimmy, what game plan? What game plan do you think?" He looked at Glenn and said drolly, "I'm sorry, buddy. She's usually on the ball."

She said, "I wasn't aware that Glenn knew what you are talking about. What *are* you talking about?"

Devlin braced his weight on the kitchen table, big hands spread out on the wood, his tie hanging down. "The vision. The game plan."

Glenn stood beside her. "Devlin says you're on board. He wants to take a sideways turn with the transport business."

She nodded once, her mind racing ahead through possible chess moves, seeing no way this conversation would trap her into admitting she'd stolen money. "I'm on board," she said, in a calm and rational tone, looking at Devlin. She wanted to say to him how he didn't know what he was doing. Wanted to tell him he only wanted to start his own company so he could tell people he'd done it. He didn't want to *run* a company. He didn't have the brain or the drive. He was twenty-nine with the brain of a twenty-one-year-old. Young, dumb, and full of come.

She turned her head toward Glenn. "And you're the main business hombre? Is that a C-suite position? I've never heard of it."

Glenn smiled and assessed her with humor. He five-finger pointed toward the kitchen table and its array of business paraphernalia. "That's the plan all laid out. The plan as Devlin sees it. We've worked it out. We used some of your ideas and then added a few twists and turns. Devlin wants me to run you through it, get your perspective."

She said, "And then?"

Glenn shrugged, looked at Devlin, and then back at her. “Then we sign some papers.”

Devlin nodded, saying, “Contracts.”

It took Glenn about an hour to run through all the paperwork spread on the table. He held her hand through a guided tour of spreadsheets, projections, and analyses. Sometimes, he would double back and ask her pointed questions, making sure she was following along. Did Devlin not tell Glenn how they’d shared some of this information before? Was her involvement in this scheme as big a surprise to Glenn as Glenn’s was to her? Devlin had crafted his plan with two separate parties, and now he’d brought them together to see how they might interact. None of what Glenn showed her was surprising. It was all stuff she’d pre-considered or had already discussed with Devlin. Some things Glenn showed her were her own ideas. Devlin had taken them, given them to Glenn, who’d polished them, and now showed them back to her like they were his own. But she said nothing, only nodded and looked keen. In the end, with no more papers to turn over, no more spreadsheets to withdraw from a manila folder, Glenn showed his hands; he’d presented the case. What was left?

She gestured to the paperwork and asked Devlin, “Where does this leave us?”

Devlin said, “Where do you think it leaves us?”

“That’s why I asked, Devlin. Everything here is in place. It all makes sense. But why here and why now?”

“Because we’re moving forward,” Devlin said. “Much sooner than I expected.”

Again came that sharp feeling that this was a put-on. This was Devlin and Devlin’s father working together, creating some scenario where they

would lull her into indicting herself.

She said, “And what do you want from me?” and then corrected herself. “What do you *need* from me?”

Devlin and Glenn shared a look, and Devlin crossed his arms and regarded her. He said, “A commitment.”

“What kind of commitment?”

Devlin said, “The written kind.”

And she said, “Like what? Sign in blood?”

He said, “That would be wonderful, but more dramatic than I need it.” He lifted a pen and passed it over to her, a Mont Blanc, the kind of pen one reserved for special events like this. She took the pen but didn’t remove the cap.

She said, “There’s one thing that’s missing.”

Devlin said, “What’s that?”

She said, “Glenn. Where does he fit in? Because before today, you only vaguely referred to other parties. Who *is* Glenn, and what does he want?”

Glenn laughed and shook his head. “I’m not part of it. I’m not looking for any piece of this. I just want the peripheral business. I’m not on the board. I’m not involved. I’m putting some money in and I have some others who want to pitch in as well. But I’m only, I guess, what you would call a consultant in the matter.”

Devlin said, “So what do you think?”

She said, “I wish I’d known what I was coming here for today. There’s a lot to go over, and Glenn did a great job explaining it, but I’m not signing it until I have more time to go through all this paperwork.”

Devlin nodded. “I understand that. That’s good. I kind of expected it, but you understand . . . the game plan can’t leave here. I can’t let you leave the apartment with this paperwork. If you want to read it, you have to stay here to do it.”

She thought for a long moment with both men staring at her, then placed the pen down on the kitchen table. “I’m going to need a little time.”

Glenn said, “No rush. Doesn’t even have to be today.”

Devlin interrupted him. “It would be better if it was today.”

Glenn looked at Devlin and said nothing. Then he nodded. “Well, I guess I’ll get going. You’ve got everything you need. You two need to work out what you’re going to do.” He extended his hand toward Kimmy again, and they shook over the kitchen table.

Once Glenn was gone and they were alone, standing together in the foyer, she said, “That wasn’t fair, springing this on me. Why now? Why today?” She studied his eyes, looking for a tell, looking for a giveaway that this was part of a game—no, an entrapment; a snare. But even if it was a trap, the response wasn’t so simple as walking away from the trap, turning her back on it and leaving it still triggered. It was imperative she understood the trap’s mechanism.

“I told you. I’m moving my timeline up.”

“But who is Glenn? Tell me who he is.”

“I trust Glenn. You don’t trust him? His family’s mega-rich. He went to St. Andrews, U.C.C. . . . I met him at U of T. What are you worried about? He’s not on the board. Glenn’s not part of the business at all. He’s an investor.”

“I’m not on the board, either.”

“I know. I didn’t ask you to be. I just want you by my side. I want you working for *me*. That’s the only commitment I’m asking for.”

“That’s what you want me to sign?”

“That’s it. Sign a statement of intent.”

“That I’m legal counsel, is that it?”

“You’re not telling me you want to stay with Stone?”

“I’m not telling you that.”

Devlin studied her with calm resolve, then cocked his head, showing soft sympathy. “Am I putting too much pressure on you?”

“You know how much my life has changed this summer.”

“I know you still want what I want,” he said, and stepped into her space. His arms went around her middle and he held her close to him in an unusual embrace.

“I do,” she said, the bitter lie staining her tongue. “I really do.” There had been a terrible point where she had convinced herself she wanted this, and that seemed incomprehensible now. She only held a desire for Josh.

Devlin said, “Trust me when I tell you I know what I’m doing. You trust me, don’t you?”

“Of course. Of course I do.”

Devlin lifted her face, holding her jawline in his huge hands. “And you wouldn’t lie to me?”

The question caught her off guard, and she scrunched up her nose. She had no answer. She was used to Josh’s request for the truth, for an assurance she wasn’t lying or betraying him. But never from Devlin. Devlin’s nature wasn’t like Josh’s.

“Why would you even ask me that?”

Devlin sighed, his hands returning to his sides. He stepped back. “I’ve never let a woman get so close to me before.”

“Oh, *bullshit*,” she said.

“What don’t you believe? That I haven’t let a woman get close, or that *you* are the woman I let get close?” He smirked to one side.

She said, “I don’t like you when you’re wistful. I like you when your confidence is colossal.”

“You think it’s weak when I ask if you’d lie to me?”

She raised her chin, narrowing her eyes on his. “You sound like Josh when you do.”

Devlin laughed and turned away, heading down the hall toward the bedroom. Any day of the week she would have followed without question, but today she stood frozen to the foyer floor, afraid of what might happen next.

Devlin stopped and turned. “Aren’t you coming?”

“I already spent an hour here. I should get back to the office.”

He frowned, puzzled. “You’re not coming to the bedroom?”

“I should go.”

Devlin raised his eyebrows, put his hands in his pockets. “I think you want to come to the bedroom, Kimmy.”

“I want to. I just don’t think I have the time.”

He smiled wider. “When you see what’s in the bedroom, you’ll make the time.”

“What does that mean?”

He smiled and turned to walk down the hall again. “Come and see.”

He kept walking. She called after him, “What do you want to show me?”

Devlin paused at the bedroom door. “You wouldn’t believe it if I told you. You’re going to have to come and see for yourself.”

CHAPTER 18

ODYSSEY 13

A naked woman lay on Devlin's bed. Long lengths of cotton fabric circled the woman's wrists and held her arms above her head, the lengths of fabric tied to the bed frame in clumsy, looping knots. A sleeping mask covered the woman's eyes. The woman was alert, aware that someone had entered the room, and she began writhing against the restraints, angling her body to face the doorway. From the short, cropped bob of blonde hair the sunlight now reflected from, Kimmy realized the woman's identity. It was Amy. And up Amy's stomach and between her bare breasts shone a frosted spatter. Someone had ejaculated on Amy while she lay tied to the bed.

There was a sudden revulsion at seeing her friend's naked body. Especially when it had come so unexpectedly. She'd known Amy a long time, but had never seen her so *bare*.

This is what was so important. This was the secret she just had to witness with her own eyes.

Amy had lain here tied to the bed the whole time she'd been in the apartment. The whole time Glenn had toured her through the complications of Devlin's shady yet legal business venture, Devlin knew Amy lay tied to his bed. Had delighted in it.

Oh, fuck. And Glenn. Glenn had known as well, hadn't he?

Devlin crossed his arms, smiling like he was proud of his work. He said, “What do you think?”

“Is this supposed to be funny? What the fuck do you think you’re doing?”

Amy gasped and writhed more. She whispered, “Is that Kimmy? Is Kimmy here?”

Devlin ran a finger down Kimmy’s back and she pulled away from him. She said, “What the fuck do you think you’re doing?”

The sound of Amy’s light, taunting chuckle flittered from the bed. A shiny lipstick smile spread below the edges of the mask. “I told you she’d run away again.”

Kimmy’s hands went cold and her stomach turned over. This was a trap. The meeting a lure. Amy tied to the bed was the whole point. It might even have been Amy’s idea.

She ran her tongue over her teeth and pushed away the tight, zinging wire of fear and repulsion that hummed up her spine. She stood tall. “You brought me here for games? For some dumb games?”

“Games, Kimmy? Come on,” Devlin said as he strolled deeper into the room where she and he had spent a lot of time over the summer, and had done terrible and wonderful things to each other’s body. Devlin stood at the foot of the bed. “I brought Amy here for you. Not for games, but for revenge. Don’t listen to Amy’s taunts.”

Amy said, “He’s lying, Kimmy. Don’t believe him.” But Amy’s smile hadn’t faded. Amy was enjoying this. Devlin was enjoying it, too. Both of them taunted her. They worked together.

Devlin said to Amy, “She’s not going to run.”

“I’m not going to run,” Kimmy said. “But tell me why I would stay.”

“You see?” Devlin said to no one in particular. “That’s *my* Kimmy.” He smiled, impressed, eyeing her over.

Kimmy smiled. “None of what happened this summer was real, was it?”

Devlin frowned. “What do you mean not real?”

“It was contrived. Fashioned at your hands and done for sick enjoyment. Taunting me, taunting Josh. Treating us like we mean so little.”

Amy closed her legs tight, like she felt vulnerable hearing those words. The smile stayed.

“That’s not true,” Devlin said. “It was real. Very real.”

“And you brought me here today, made me sit through that sales pitch for your business plan, and the only reason I’m here is for some sadistic game. You’re wasting my time.” The right thing to do was to leave, but she stayed where she stood, tall and secure. All because she’d fled the first time Devlin and Amy had done this to her, and for some inexplicable reason had carried the regret like a heavy burden ever since. It was the shame, the humiliation, the regret, the fear of missing out . . . And so much more. Her friend Amy had betrayed her, hadn’t she? The worst time in Kimmy’s life, a time when everything was going wrong around her and the family she knew crumbled to dust, and her friend, her one cool friend, *used* her. For what purpose? It never made sense. And because it had never made sense, she’d found it easy to push away betrayal’s sting, bury it like it hadn’t happened. So much easier than facing the truth. For all of Josh’s faults, and her condemnation of him as his own worst enemy, here she was facing the real truth; something she should have done so long ago, but had wanted Amy to be her friend so bad—because of the things being friends with a girl like Amy could do for a bookish nerd—that she’d explained away the unkindness, ameliorated Amy’s abuse and bullying. Amy had taken advantage of her in her weakest time back in high school, and now here Amy was a decade later doing it all over again, ruining her life for kicks.

Amy laughed again and Devlin said, “A waste of time?”

Their malevolence astounded her. After all these years, to still be the same primitive people they were in high school. Too rich, too spoiled,

privileged children from wealthy families, and this was how they chose to spend their time.

She was only a toy in their wicked game of decadence. She walked closer to the edge of the bed, heading toward the top side so she could see Devlin clearly.

“This *is* a waste of my time,” she said.

Devlin smiled and showed his hands, saying, “It’s only wasted if you don’t take advantage of it.”

She clucked her tongue and shook her head admonishingly. “You two went to all this trouble just to mess with me, just to ruin my life?”

“Ruin your life?” Devlin said. “I offered you opportunities, and you took them. You snatched them and then showed them to me in ways I hadn’t seen before.”

“Then why this?” she said, gesturing to Amy’s writhing, naked body. “Why this, then? A ridiculous spectacle. Why would you bring me here? Why would you pretend you had this business idea, this *plan* for the future?”

“I *do* have a business,” Devlin insisted.

“Bring me here to involve me in your stupid theater? Taunt me, make fun of me, just like you did last time,” she said. “Put me through this humiliation ritual.”

“No one’s taunting you,” Devlin said with mock concern on his face, almost convincing her.

She addressed Amy, who wasn’t smiling anymore under the face mask. “You, Amy. Taunting Josh, sending him texts, putting terrible ideas in his head.”

Amy said, “I was only joking around.”

Kimmy said to Devlin, “I’m not your pawn. I’m not some cheap chess piece you throw around the board.”

“No one said you were,” Devlin said, coming around the foot of the bed toward her, his look of concern becoming even more convincing.

“I’m not as naïve as I used to be,” Kimmy continued. “I’m not the same person you used to be able to push around.”

“No one’s pushing you around,” Amy interjected, pulling against her cloth bindings. “Someone untie me,” she muttered.

Devlin said, “It’s not a fake business, Kimmy. That’s what you think? I know you’re not naïve; I know you’re savvy. That’s why I’m doing this. That’s why I’ve done everything this summer. The idea of doing my own thing has always been something I’ve had, but I wasn’t going to do it so soon. It’s not *fake*. I don’t know why you think that.”

Kimmy gestured at Amy again. “You bring her here, tie her to the bed, and then make me listen to that dumb sales pitch with Glenn, and Amy’s tied to your bed,” she said, jabbing a finger at him.

Devlin held up his hands again, the concern still present but now with a more assuaging look in his eyes. “This was supposed to be fun. I brought her here for you.”

“That’s why you fucked her?” Kimmy said, prompting Amy to laugh.

Kimmy turned on her heel and headed to the bedroom door. “You two are still children. A couple of spoiled teenagers. I don’t have time for your bullshit.”

Amy hollered out behind her. “Devlin didn’t fuck me.”

Devlin caught up with her at the door. “I brought her here so you could punish her. Yes, I know she’s naked, but I *didn’t* have sex with her.”

Kimmy held her hand on the door handle, knowing again the smartest thing to do would be to leave. There was nothing holding her to Devlin Stone anymore. Devlin Stone had nothing she wanted. Devlin stone was everything she hated.

“Hey,” Devlin said, a little softer now and putting his hand on her wrist. Not pulling her hand away from the doorknob or seeking to stop her, but

just holding her. “I didn’t have sex with her.”

“Someone did,” she said, staring at the door.

Devlin said, “Glenn did.”

“You tied Amy up and let your friend fuck her?”

From behind her, Amy laughed again and said, “Glenn is my ex, Kimmy.”

Devlin said, “They’ve been on again and off again since U of T. They’re fuck buddies.”

“Amy knows about the business. Glenn knows about the business. No one ever tells me anything.”

“But I’m telling you now. I don’t know why you’re acting this way. You’re usually five steps ahead of me.”

She let go of the door handle and faced him. “Are you starting your own business?”

“Are you crazy? You think I made all that up? All those spreadsheets, all that paperwork. I did that for a joke? You think I did that because it would be funny to trick you? You’re not even making sense anymore.”

“You have Amy tied naked to your bed, and you want me to act sane? When it comes to the brokerage, I might be a few steps ahead, but I don’t lie around anticipating what’s possible for Devlin to surprise me with in bed. Who would anticipate what I walked into here?”

“I thought you’d handle this differently,” Devlin said. “You’re usually so calm, so *ready*.”

“I am calm. I’m calm right now. I’m calmly saying that what’s going on in your bedroom right now is juvenile. And I’m offended you’d think I wanted to be part of it.”

Behind them, Amy said, “I told you she would leave.”

Kimmy turned, saw Amy smiling again, pulling her wrists against the restraints, her breasts jostling on her chest, the nipples aroused into dimpled bulbs.

“Are you trying to be funny?”

“Don’t you think I *am*?”

“You’re taunting me.”

Devlin said, “She’s being a bitch. She bet me you would leave, so she’s *trying* to make you leave—don’t listen to her.” He turned his face toward the bed and said, “Knock it off, Amy.”

Amy chuckled, then pouted.

“Stay,” Devlin said, still looking Kimmy in the eye.

She said, “I don’t trust you.”

“You trusted me before.”

“And look where it got me.”

“Where did it get you, Kimmy? Think of what we talked about just a few days ago, all those promises . . . I don’t know what’s changed since then, but you had a different mindset—”

“That was before you tied Amy naked to the bed.”

Devlin said, “Glenn did that. I didn’t do that.”

Amy sang, “You told him to do it.”

Devlin sighed, looked down. He admitted to her, “I asked him to. But for you, Kimmy. Not for me. For you. Can’t you believe that?”

CHAPTER 19

ODYSSEY 14

“So Glenn tied Amy to the bed,” Kimmy said, “and then came out and did that sales pitch, going through all that bullshit with me?”

“It’s not bullshit.”

“It’s psychopathic. . . . And, yeah, if it’s real, you treat it like bullshit.” Kimmy jabbed her hand at Devlin while she talked, astounded he wouldn’t see things the way they were. “You gave me a sales pitch to sign paperwork. A letter of intent that I would serve as your counsel. But you give the moment no reverence, nothing of value. You treat everything like a game. Like everything revolves around your dick.”

Devlin’s lips pursed and then a slow smile began to spread. He said, “I’ve never seen you disrupted like this. Never seen you so emotional. I don’t know what to make of it.”

“Don’t try to turn the tables on me, Devlin. I’m not stupid.”

“Kimmy,” Devlin said, strolling back to the bed, turning, then sitting down beside Amy’s naked body. “I hired you for fun. I hired you because I knew you could do the job I wanted you to do, but I also hired you—yes—to fuck around with Josh’s head.”

“It’s juvenile, Devlin,” she said, announcing each syllable to emphasize the importance of what she was saying, to slow it down so he could understand it.

“You did it, too. I wasn’t alone. I wasn’t by myself. Sometimes, when I’d lost interest, it was you who renewed it.”

Amy said, “Can someone untie me? You guys are so boring.”

“Shut up, Amy,” Devlin said over his shoulder, and Amy chuckled.

Devlin continued, the daylight falling on his broad shoulders and lighting up his glossy black hair, Amy a moving flesh landscape behind him. “Don’t act like I’m fucking up. Don’t act like what I’ve done here is something crazy.” He looked over his shoulder at blindfolded Amy, then back at Kimmy. “You were the one who fucked me in Cayman while Josh sat at the house waiting for you to come back. Was that juvenile? You don’t get to pick and choose. You don’t get to align everything in your favor when you’ve been complicit from day one.”

Kimmy chewed her cheek, raising her chin in defiance. She cocked a hip and put her hands on her waist.

“You wanted me because you wanted a job. I know it. I said it to you a hundred times. You’re a lawyer, you work at an immigration place. You’re worth so much more. And after that party you were gonna go home, and you were gonna make cat baskets for a bunch of lisping cat daddies with disposable income. What does that do for anybody? It doesn’t do anything for you. You fought with me at Tiffany’s—you were fighting to get out. You were fighting to get away, to get out from under the burden of a pointless existence. And I gave you everything. As much as I could. Not to toy with you, but because you deserve it. You can do anything. Anything you want. You’ve got the drive, you’ve got the intelligence, and look at you”—he turned to speak over his shoulder—“you can’t see her, but holy shit, Amy. As tall as me in heels, thousand-dollar shoes, jet-black suit.” He faced Kimmy again. “Prada, right?”

She clenched her jaw, nostrils flaring, crossing her arms and staring back at him. “Yes.”

Devlin spoke over his shoulder again, but kept his eyes on Kimmy, sly smirk tugging up the corner of his mouth. “When she walks into a boardroom, you should see everybody’s face. She scares them shitless.”

Amy scoffed and said, “Whoop-dee-doo.”

Devlin said, “Seriously, Kimmy. Don’t go off the rails on me. I didn’t fuck Amy. I’m not going to fuck Amy. That’s Glenn’s job.”

Amy said “Where *is* Glenn?”

“So don’t listen to Amy,” Devlin said. “She’s here, and she’s tied to the bed for only one reason.”

“And what’s that?”

Now Devlin smiled again. He patted his hands on his knees, then stood. He removed his suit jacket and tossed it to a nearby chair. Then, with his eyes on Kimmy’s, he unbuckled his belt and withdrew it in one quick snap from the belt loops. “I told you. I brought Amy here so you could punish her.”

Amy said, “Here’s where she runs out of the room.”

Kimmy ran the tip of her tongue across her upper lip, back and forth, back and forth, eyeing Devlin and then Amy’s naked body. She looked at Devlin’s eyes, looked at his hand holding the circled loop of his belt.

And Amy was right. The urge to flee was massive.

In her mind, her feet had already skittered out of the room, but only by sheer force did she keep them planted on Devlin’s bedroom carpet. The moment dragged on. Her staring, Amy wondering what was going on, and Devlin smiling, holding out his belt.

Kimmy said, “What am I punishing her for?”

“You know what she did.”

“Do I? Do I *really* know?”

“Come and ask her,” Devlin said, presenting the belt once more with an eager gesture.

Kimmy uncrossed her arms, stepped toward the bed, looking at her high-school friend laid out with hands above her head, naked from head to toe, except for a sleeping mask across her eyes. She said to Amy, “What am I punishing you for?”

“There’s nothing to punish me for. I didn’t do anything.”

Devlin flicked his belt, and it snapped against the sole of Amy’s foot. Amy’s leg jumped, and she tucked it underneath her, laughing and rolling on the bed.

Devlin looked at Kimmy and held the gaze, and Kimmy felt an uncomfortable connection to him in that moment. Devlin’s words echoed: *Amy’s a psychopath*. And Amy was. Kimmy had always denied it because it was cool to be Amy’s friend. Now she licked her lower lip, then reluctantly held out her hand. Devlin put his belt into her grip, smiling wide, light gleaming in his dark eyes that shone blue in the daylight spilling into his bedroom.

They’d spent a lot of time in here doing terrible things.

This was nothing new.

She walked around the bed to the far side, getting near to Amy’s face.

“You texted my husband behind my back.”

Amy said, “I would never do that.”

“I *know* that you did,” Kimmy told her.

“That’s such bullshit.”

Kimmy looked at Devlin. Devlin shrugged, putting up his hands in a gesture of *What are you gonna do?*

Kimmy said, “And what about a picture of me?”

“What about it? What did I do with a picture of you?”

Kimmy stood looking at Amy’s vulnerable body and, for the first time, felt a vengeful urge to strike the belt across her. She gripped the leather in her fist. A slap right across Amy’s bare stomach. A slap across her tits. She deserved it. She deserved the sting.

“You taunted Josh. You taunted my husband to my face.”

“I *did* do that,” Amy said. “But I was only joking.”

“And what did you think was so funny? Pointing at my husband’s penis and saying it was *so* small? And what was that for? Why would someone say such a thing? I mean, you know I married the man I love. And if I love him...”

“If you love him, it wouldn’t matter.”

“But you thought it might. You thought if you created the smallest measure of doubt, that my marriage would crumble. Not because you care about my marriage, but because you *love* the crumble.”

Amy chuckled. “That’s ludicrous.”

“Is it?”

“What kind of woman would leave the man she married because his penis was smaller than a potential lover’s? That would be insane.”

“I didn’t leave him because of that.”

Amy cocked her head, lips pursing. “You *left* him?”

“No. No, I didn’t,” Kimmy said through gritted teeth, wringing the leather in her fists.

Devlin said, “She didn’t leave him. He didn’t leave her. You won’t *believe* what’s happening.”

Kimmy said, “You didn’t tell her?”

Devlin shook his head no. “It’s our secret.”

An indignant shift adjusted her stomach, thinking how she shared such intimacy with the man her husband hated. The secret they held together was a lie. That was something she could hold on to for strength, remind herself she wasn’t as bad as Devlin and Amy believed.

Amy said, “I made fun of Josh’s penis to remind you what you missed out on—because you were a *chicken*.”

Kimmy’s eyes moved from Devlin to Amy’s masked face. That expectant smile. Amy knowing she was wicked; reveling in it. Kimmy had

envied Amy's teenage aloofness at one time; the ease with which Amy handled life's common misfortunes. Amy always knew what to say. And it was because Amy didn't care about consequences. Or outcomes. She was protected, privileged. Privileged with beauty and some other thing she wielded like a two-pronged weapon along with her confidence: a sultry something, an indescribable quality that made anyone think of sex every time Amy walked or talked. She'd learned to use it to get what she wanted.

Kimmy told Amy to roll over. Amy smiled, showing teeth. "Why, what are you going to do, Kimmy?"

Kimmy brought the belt down across Amy's bare stomach with a quick snap. Amy yelped and jumped, bringing up her knees and twisting to move her stomach away from another sting. "Ow," she exclaimed, laughing. "Not even a warning, Kimmy? You're cruel."

"You're the cruel one," Kimmy said. "Now roll over."

Amy deserved punishment. But this punishment was contrived, theatrical; Amy deserved ruin. When Amy rolled to her stomach, her bare ass sticking up in the air, she bent her knees and brought her feet up like her feet would protect her ass from punishment. Kimmy told Devlin to hold Amy's feet down.

Devlin took Amy's ankles and guided her feet to the bed so her ass was exposed.

Amy said, "Now the party's getting started."

"This isn't a party, Amy," Kimmy said, looking at Amy's narrow waist swaying out to her generous, womanly hips. Teenage boys would swoon when they saw Amy walk the halls of Dalton High. She brought the belt down on Amy's bare ass and Amy gasped, a whicking sound that slowed to a breathy chuckle in the wake of the snap's echo. A pink swath bloomed on Amy's perfect ass. Amy writhed in sexual frustration.

Lust spread throughout the room. Bringing the belt down on Amy's ass had ignited something. Devlin's bedroom was a salon of sexual endeavor. A

place where things such as this were meant to occur. Events such as this were the reason this bedroom existed. All three of them breathed deeper and slower. All of them had switches flipped in their head that went from on-off; lusty intent now burned in all of them. Kimmy could feel it strongest because it shouldn't exist within her at all. Nothing but chaste regret should shine in her heart after the weekend past.

The burn of shame flared on her cheeks. The two people in this room ruined her life. It took them ten years to do it, but this event began the night they invited her to Devlin's place so they could scare timid Kimmy Chang into running home to hide from the wicked world. The promised job had been a farce. The promised parlay of her position at Stone Senior to Stone Junior for more pay and power was likely a farce as well. Soon she would have no job, no marriage. She'd been tricked into humiliating and betraying her husband. She'd corrupted a good friend, disappointed her niece, embarrassed her father, lost to her sister, and there was a good chance she would go to prison for at least eighteen months. Who would look after her baby while she was away? Would Josh even talk to her ever again?

She bent at the waist so she could speak near Amy's ear. "You're going to wish I ran away today, Amy. You're going to wish you could only bully me like you used to."

Amy harrumphed, still smiling. "I never bullied you, Kimmy."

Kimmy looked at Devlin, stooped at the foot of the bed, his large hands gathering Amy's thin ankles together. "Spread her legs for me."

CHAPTER 20

ODYSSEY 15

Once Devlin parted Amy's legs, Kimmy swatted Amy's bottom again. Amy flinched and squealed with delight. Kimmy said, "The way you enjoy this tells me everything I need to know."

Amy said, "You don't need to interrogate me?"

Devlin watched the show, his hands on Amy's ankles, pinning them to the bed, an aroused and desperate look in his eyes. Sexual hunger emanated from him like a dynamo's hum.

Kimmy put a knee on the bed and looked between Amy's parted thighs. The sight was strange and lurid; Amy, a girl she only knew as a friend, now privy to her privatest place, the place where she was pink and sensitive. And wet. Shining wet. She doubled the circle of Devlin's belt into a shorter switch and batted the leather against the wetness. Each little smack produced a sticky wet crackle, and Amy's hips humped the bed in rhythm with Kimmy's leather-pecking. "Why would I give you what you want if I sought to punish you?" She stopped swatting and now slid the oiled leather up and down Amy's pussy. Amy's hips gyrated.

"Because I done you wrong," Amy sighed, using the vernacular of the American South, twinged with the fake English accent she used since moving to London.

Kimmy began to beat Amy's pussy again with the leather, and each time she did, Amy uttered a soft gasp. "And how did you do me wrong?"

Amy showed a sultry look over her shoulder despite the sleeping mask's coverage, her hips grinding into the mattress, eager for the leather smacks on her sopping wet pussy. "Kimmy, I'm just a merry prankster. I didn't mean any harm."

Now Kimmy regarded Devlin, whose eyes burned holes into where she smacked Amy with his belt. "I bet you're hard right now."

Devlin chuckled, his eyes flicking up to hers. "Kimmy, I'm hard as steel right now."

Kimmy brought the belt down in a wicked smack on the inside of Amy's thigh. The snap of leather on flesh was as bright as a bulb, and Amy cried out in surprise and pain. Even Devlin flinched.

Kimmy said, "Why am I the Grand Inquisitor when you both think I'm as guilty as you are?"

Devlin chuckled. "You see it, don't you? This isn't punishment. This is reward."

"We're all three wicked," Kimmy said. "Aren't we?"

"As wicked as they come," Amy said.

Kimmy tapped the leather belt on the back of Amy's thigh, the trembling one she'd already smacked with the belt. "But some of us are wickeder than others, wouldn't you agree?"

Amy's body tightened, expecting another extreme whip of Devlin's belt.

Kimmy said, "Is this what it's like on the other side?"

Devlin said, "The other side of what?"

"This is the side of sin and heresy. Of sodomy and moral offense."

"Sounds delightful," Amy crooned. "Are you selling time shares there?"

Kimmy chuckled and smacked the inside of Amy's thigh where a pink mark had already risen. Amy cried out in laughing anguish. Kimmy said, "You can free your hands, Amy."

Amy looked over her shoulder again, rakish eyebrow at a sly angle above the sleeping mask. Kimmy lightly smacked Amy's bare bottom, smiling. Amy laughed, then worked her hand around in circles, loosening the bind of the tied cloth on her wrist. Her hand came free, and she used it to pry off the other binding.

Kimmy swatted Amy's bare ass much harder this time. "Punishment isn't theater," she said. "Don't make a farce of it."

Devlin chuckled but didn't let go of Amy's ankles, still pinning them to the bed, shoulder width apart.

Kimmy regarded him. "You brought me here for this."

"This is what you want," he said.

"Retribution," she said and laughed. "You think this belt and I"—she snapped the leather in his direction—"can make right all the wrongs against me?"

Devlin said, "Who did you wrong, Kimmy?"

Kimmy brought the belt down on Amy's bare ass with a massive crack. Amy jumped and scooted away, rubbing her ass cheeks. "Ow, what the hell, Kimmy?"

Kimmy pointed the leather at Devlin. "Don't you think he's the one who should be punished?"

Amy crawled up to the pillows, still consoling her pink buttocks, smiling, head angling toward Devlin. "You might be right," she said.

Devlin stood upright, sticking his muscular chest out, face so fucking handsome and masculine; chiseled features, five o'clock shadow at two in the afternoon. His cock showed through his pants, swollen and massive, hanging down one leg but pushing up against the fine material of his tailored suit. She smiled. He smiled.

Kimmy said, "How did you know he put a business card in my front hall drawer, Amy?"

Amy chuckled. The answer was obvious.

“Doesn’t mean I told her to do it,” Devlin said.

“And that awful picture of me?”

Amy snorted and bowed her head. She slipped off the sleeping mask and looked up, seeing Kimmy for the first time today. Her eyebrows rose. Kimmy stood tall.

Amy exhaled an excited, disbelieving sound. “What do we have here?”

Devlin gestured Kimmy’s way. “I told you.”

Amy met Kimmy’s gaze. “Holy fuck, Kimmy. Look at you.”

Kimmy said, “And that awful picture of me?”

Amy said, “I wouldn’t call it awful.”

“If you’ve seen it, you know about it, and if you know about it, it was sent to you.”

Amy’s brow crinkled. “By whom?”

“Excuse my passive language,” Kimmy said, chuckling. She looked at Devlin. “Devlin sent it to you.”

Devlin smiled, shrugged, showed his hands in a mocking gesture of sheepishness. “It was a really good picture.”

Kimmy turned to Amy, Amy still checking her out, and it provoked an unwanted pride. As distasteful as it was, she pretended to enjoy Amy’s flattering gaze, saying to Amy, “And he thinks you’re the one who I should punish.”

Amy regarded Devlin and sneered. “Uh-oh. She’s onto you.”

“The thing with Kimmy,” Devlin said, taking off his cufflinks, “is her wrath comes with so much pleasure.”

Kimmy said nothing for a moment, tapping the looped belt against her opposite palm. Then: “Amy, undress him for me.”

Amy shared a look with Devlin, and Kimmy studied their eyes, looking to see what they communicated. Amy showed mild surprise, and Devlin showed a serious confidence. Amy was now the outsider looking in. Kimmy Chang owned Devlin Stone’s attention, and Amy would have to work hard

to keep a position close to what she'd claimed before. Amy would do what Kimmy asked because it pleased Devlin. Amy was the follower. Devlin could call Amy a psychopath, but Amy followed Devlin like he was the master, not the other way around.

Amy rose to her knees and knee-walked from the head of the bed to the foot, holding an arm across her chest to stop her breasts from swaying—something an envious teenage teacup Kimmy would have dwelled on. Devlin faced her while Amy approached him from behind, putting one bare foot down on the floor near Devlin's foot, clad in a hand-stitched black-leather brogue. Amy eyed Devlin's profile, then flicked her poisonous gaze Kimmy's way. "Let's get him naked."

Devlin smiled, eyes darkening and narrowing, angling his head to the side to get a look at beautiful Amy and her angular face framed by the platinum-blond bob. Amy's arms circled Devlin's wide shoulders and snatched a handful of his tie, caressing the fabric, admiring its silky feel, before her fingers climbed their way to the knot and loosened it.

Kimmy turned and headed to the dresser on the far side of the room, opened the top drawer and searched through some of their toys, pulling out lube first and then some other useful items. When she turned, Amy was unbuttoning Devlin's shirt, still behind him, her hands working in delicate motions, her eyes gazing at Devlin, seducing him. Once Amy had unbuttoned his shirt to the bottom, she pulled on the plackets, opening the shirt, showing off Devlin's gorgeous body; his muscle, his spread of masculine hair across his chest. The shirt pulled out of the waistband and Amy finished the last button and slid Devlin's shirt off his thick arms. Devlin loved the show. Devlin loved the devotion, loved all eyes on him right now.

Amy muttered sexual noises in her throat, approving noises, admiring Devlin's bare torso and how beautiful a male specimen he was. Was it their first time together in a long time? Did Devlin fuck Amy behind her back

over the summer? How much of their relationship had been a charade? Amy's hands slid over Devlin's shoulders, massaging his muscle, copping a feel, running down his arms. But Devlin posed for Kimmy, standing facing her, showing off the breadth of his shoulders, the way his narrow hips formed a sharp V under his muscular frame. Amy's hands still explored, riding over his front, over his flexing abs, his narrow waist, caressing their way to his belt line. But before Amy undid the waist, her hands swept over the fly of Devlin's fine tailored pants, her right arm extending far across so she could smooth her dominant hand over Devlin's prized feature. She purred when she found the hump of his massive arousal.

"You're so fucking big," Amy whispered, handling Devlin's weapon through his pants. "So fucking sexual." She kissed the bare skin at his waist.

"Take off his pants," Kimmy said, strolling her way to the bed again, tossing the big pump-bottle of lube onto the bedding. It had been full in the middle of the summer, but now it was down by two-thirds.

Amy worked loose Devlin's waist fastener and drew down his zipper, and Devlin held Kimmy's gaze the whole time like it was just the two of them that mattered in the room. Amy slowed, and groaned with excitement when the only thing holding Devlin's pants up was the size of his cock and the strength it had pushing the fabric tighter on his pant leg. She drew in a whistling intake of air through her teeth, overwhelmed with sexual excitement.

Kimmy smacked the belt into her palm, getting Amy's attention. Amy stopped massaging Devlin's bulge and regarded her. "Get on your knees and untie his shoes."

Amy looked up at Devlin, and Devlin showed her a calm expression. Amy slid off the bed with a small smile, turned her back to Kimmy, and crouched at Devlin's feet to untie his laces. Devlin and Kimmy shared looks while Amy worked.

Kimmy chuckled, slapping the belt into her palm in slow rhythm. “Good, Amy. Now his pants, please.”

Like an eager thrall, Amy, still kneeling before her master, looking up, smiling, aroused, smoothed her hands up Devlin’s leg to engage in the worship of his mighty manhood. Both of Amy’s hands stroked up and down the dark fabric, stroking and squeezing on Devlin’s impressive meat. Then she gathered her hands at Devlin’s fly and guided the pants to the floor. Inch by incredible inch, Devlin’s dark fleshy polearm was revealed. Down its thick length until one flap of the tailored fly caught on the swollen lip of his engorged coronal ridge. Then the fabric peeled further and Devlin’s huge cock was freed.

It bounced and wagged side to side, but not for long before Amy’s hands were on it, showing it all the love Kimmy had shown it this summer. Amy was mesmerized; eyes lost and ecstatic, stroking Devlin’s cock in two hands, watching the skin roll over his engorged cock head, pulling it back and watching it angle upright. She held it up against his belly, rubbing her palm north and south, eyes studying every vein and wrinkle and bulge.

Devlin put his hands on his hips, feet shoulder width apart, doing his Superman pose; looking more like an airbrushed barbarian, the way Amy clung to his leg and knelt before him in sexual worship.

There had been many times this summer her very own behavior could be observed this way. Many times this summer, she’d worshipped Devlin’s cock and sang hymns to his deep thrusting, writhing on the bed in sultry passion as Devlin did dark and nasty things to her body with his incredible cock, made her cast aside all that mattered for one of those singular moments of intense pleasure unlike anything she’d experienced before.

While Amy showed Devlin his due adoration, Devlin’s eyes weren’t on Amy. They were on Kimmy.

Kimmy stepped closer, looked between them at Amy as Amy used her hands to anoint Devlin’s loins. She smiled, and Devlin smiled too. There

was much camaraderie there, but still a measure of mutual distrust or wariness. But just as she'd worshipped at his altar, he had begun to worship at hers, requiring some of the rare sacraments only she could perform.

She said, "You're not wearing my panties."

Devlin chuckled, eyes flicking down at Amy, showing some uneasiness. He said, "Not when we have company, dear."

Amy stopped her ministrations, looking up to decipher what they were talking about, jealousy roiling in her gaze.

Kimmy reached in her pocket and produced a well-worn green satin ball that, when held by a hip-string, unraveled to sway between them. "I insist," she said.

CHAPTER 21

ODYSSEY 16

Devlin snatched the panties from her, aggravated but still smiling, still having fun. “You like my dick in these, huh?”

“I know *you* do,” she said.

Amy smiled, studying the panties in Devlin’s grip, not wanting to be on the outside of a secret—but asking what the panties were would show she didn’t know what was going on, and Amy wouldn’t do that. And Devlin wouldn’t put the panties on. That was for sure. Not when Amy was here. The panties put both Amy and Devlin at awkward angles. Kimmy was sure Devlin regretted wearing them the first time.

The story of the panties Devlin held occurred to Amy, who said now, “Are those the panties Josh wore?”

Devlin chuckled, looking over his shoulder at Amy, holding the panties up by the waist strings so Amy could see them. He said, “His little dick was hard as a rock. You should have seen it.”

Kimmy smiled while hatred and anger burned in her heart. These two laughed together at Josh’s expense. Laughed at a man who stepped off a dock into a frozen lake this weekend and almost departed this sweet earth. A man no one should ever laugh at. “We want to see your dick in them, Devlin,” she said.

“Yeah, I don’t think so,” Devlin said, full of bravado and macho pride, putting his hand with the panties down at his thigh. He’d worn them. She’d coaxed him into stretching them over his wider hips, telling him she wanted to see his big cock in her satin. Devlin had done it, but she knew he wouldn’t do it now. But the thought she might tell Amy—or worse, show Amy the picture—tightened his chest for sure.

Amy took the panties from Devlin’s hand, held them up before them all, then pushed her index finger out of the front panel, imitating a small erect penis. Amy and Devlin laughed. Josh didn’t even have a small penis. This was cruel taunting with little merit. Pure wickedness.

Devlin stroked Amy’s wrist. “You put them on.”

Amy said, “Put on Josh’s panties?”

“Put them on,” Kimmy said, producing her phone from a pocket.

“My hips are wider than Kimmy’s,” Amy said to Devlin, and it shot past Kimmy like a gunfighter aiming wide. A sting meant for Kimmy, owner of slim hips and small breasts.

Devlin saw Kimmy’s camera. “Record her. Record her putting on Josh’s panties.”

“It’s her punishment,” Kimmy said. “I’ll show Josh.”

Amy looked offended. “Hey, I’m not getting naked for *Josh*.”

Devlin stroked Amy’s forearm. “Do it for me.”

Amy turned up her nose. “So Josh can watch?”

Devlin told Amy how there was more going on and not to ruin things for him. Amy looked more confused. Devlin said, “Maybe Kimmy and I will tell you our secret. If you’re good.”

That worked. Now Amy wanted to play along—not to satisfy Devlin or Kimmy’s request, but to situate herself on the inside of the circle rather than the outside. Amy would worry if she didn’t comply, she could end up on the outside, standing somewhere with Josh. Devlin stepped aside, big naked dick wagging back and forth in stiff arcs, and Amy tried not to look

disgruntled, sitting down on the edge of the bed, holding the green satin panties, arching her back, her facial expression steadying to stony blankness for the sake of the camera. Kimmy held up her phone, getting Amy in the frame; naked Amy, evildoer, tauntress, mean girl from high school. Bad Amy, who'd helped trick Kimmy and Josh into risking it all this summer. Risking her job and her marriage and her future, all for some big dick, some dirty fun, and for money. Don't forget the money.

With the camera recording, now Kimmy said, "This is your punishment. That's why you'll do it, Amy. Tell Josh you're sorry." Saying Josh's name hurt her chest, and his name warbled on her tongue when she spoke. Maybe she would show him this. Maybe one day Josh would be brave enough to see what his wife would do for him. This was a perverse display of devotion, but everyone in this room was guilty in setting the stage where a theatrical show such as this might find an audience.

Amy cocked her head, eyes slimmed, expression screwed into a cynical mask. But she obeyed, even dissolving her stiffness into sultry action. "Looks like I'm in trouble," Amy said as if addressing Josh. With her knees together, she bent at the waist and lifted a foot and slipped pointed toes into a leg hole of the panties. She repeated it with the other, doing her best to make sure nothing between her legs would show to Josh. As she slipped the panties up her shapely calves to her knees, she looked at the camera. "No one around here can take a joke." Then she stood, pulling up the panties and swaying her hips so she could pull them up into place. They fit. Yes, Amy's hips and breasts were larger, but Devlin had managed to get them on.

"There," Amy said. "Satisfied?" She showed the camera she wore the panties, turning around to show her ass, feet and knees together, making it look good. Making it look good for Josh. Taunting him with something she knew he would never touch. "I look good in them, don't I?" She shot a sly look over her bare shoulder.

Devlin asked for Kimmy's phone, and she took her eyes from Amy to regard him. He stood there, enjoying himself, unaware of all the hurt that had occurred over the weekend. All that she'd endured meant nothing to him. The vision of ignorance. The vision of arrogance. So handsome. So spoiled. So rich. Muscular. His hard cock hung with heavy, lazy weight between his legs, engorged, swollen, enormous. Unreal. All of Devlin's gifts granted his dreams of depravity. He had a life where nothing other than physical pleasure interested him. Even his pursuit of an independent company from his father only served his hedonistic interests. Travel across the globe. Deep pockets. Control. Devlin wanted to experience everything in life with his big dick out of his pants where everyone could see it. It was the most impressive thing about the man.

She passed him the camera. Devlin aimed it at Amy. "Punish her. Punish Amy's sin for Josh."

Kimmy still studied the man who'd ruined her life, Devlin unaware she studied him. Enjoying his time, getting his rocks off at the expense of others. Partying it up in the middle of the day when everyone else in the world was working to feed their families. He looked her way, wondering what was taking her so long. She smiled, even using her eyes, showing him the wicked Kimmy Devlin wanted to see.

"What was her crime again?"

Devlin turned the camera on her and she didn't shy away. He recorded her while he spoke, documenting her while he answered. The only person who might ever see this was Josh.

Devlin said, "Those panties he loves. Amy told Josh to wear them. Told him to *show* me he wore them. Are you going to let her get away with that?"

Kimmy still held his leather belt, looped in one hand. She regarded it now. Her hand. The belt. Her manicured fingers, long and graceful, holding onto this implement that would deliver sharp punishment. In the spring of

this year, this moment was inconceivable, yet here it was. Sunlight on her skin, leather on her palm, the smell of sex in the room. Two ominous figures from her past brought again to life. For what? Was it all for this? Was it all for this moment? For their punishment?

It was a farewell.

A farewell, closing the book on that moment she'd fled from.

She would make Amy and Devlin think they would get everything they wanted from her and much more than they'd even imagined. When she betrayed them, and she would, it would hurt that much more.

She took her time closing the gap between her and Amy. And liked being dressed; liked wearing heels. She towered over Amy. And Amy had been rendered weak and vulnerable. Naked but for her own panties her husband had obsessed over.

"Josh loves those," Kimmy said, standing right beside Amy now, Amy still facing the bed. Devlin recorded the scene on her phone. "He loves them because they're mine."

Amy watched her over her shoulder, not knowing what to say.

"You think you can wear them?"

Amy smiled, undeterred and unintimidated.

"Peel them down," Kimmy said.

Amy bit her lower lip and complied, her hands coming together behind her back, fingers tracing under the fabric, rolling the waistband, pushing the panties down her bare ass cheeks.

Devlin, holding the camera, whispered, "Do it, Kimmy. Punish her."

Kimmy brought the belt back behind her, waist high, then snapped it across Amy's bottom. Amy yelped and jumped. Her ass cheeks bounced. It looked good. Good enough maybe Josh could forgive her.

She brought the belt back again and whipped it across Amy's ass. Harder this time. Amy yelped and jumped, and this time moved away, like she couldn't bear another smack.

Kimmy said, “Bend over, Amy. Put your hands on the bed.”

Amy hesitated and Devlin said, “Do what she says, Amy.”

Amy stilled. She bent at the waist, her ass sticking out, and put her hands on the bedding. Kimmy brought the belt behind her farther, twisting at her waist, generating torque. This time when she snapped the belt across Amy’s bottom, the sound was wet and sharp and Amy cried out. She rolled away from Kimmy, scooting to the far side of the bed, face contorted with pain.

“Ow, okay. Holy shit,” she said, annoyed. “You really hit me.”

“Stand up,” Kimmy said, strolling to the far side of the bed, heels on carpet.

Amy’s eyes flicked toward Devlin, then came back to Kimmy. She stood up, lips pursed, brow lowered. Kimmy took her face in her left hand and pinched her cheeks, pooching out Amy’s lips.

Devlin grumbled behind them. “This is so fucking hot. Keep going.”

Kimmy turned to Devlin. To the camera, to Josh watching this at some future moment, and smiled. Devlin filmed them, holding up her phone, his other hand stroking his massive cock.

Kimmy flicked the belt between Amy’s legs, smacking her pussy, and Amy buckled. She pushed Amy back by her face and Amy slumped to sit on the bed, her hands clamped between her thighs. Her eyes were alive and electric; anger slithered there, but something else as well. It was hard to pinpoint, and the best word Kimmy could summon was ‘engaged.’ Amy was into this. Amy wanted this. Amy delighted in sin, just like Devlin. And just like Kimmy, too.

Devlin said, “Make her stand up again.”

Kimmy slapped the belt across her palm. “You want me to punish her more? You want to see me work between her legs?”

Amy bit her lower lip and tilted up her chin.

Kimmy held the point of Amy's chin and looked down on her. "Apologize. Apologize and I'll go easy on you."

Amy chuckled, licked her lips, then pulled her face away from Kimmy's touch. She shrugged her shoulders, hands still clamped between her thighs to protect her pussy. "Sorry," she said.

"Not to me," Kimmy said, stepping away and pointing toward Devlin, jerking his horse cock and recording them on their phone. "Apologize to Josh."

Amy scoffed, lowering her lids and showing a sleepy, disinterested look. Kimmy pulled back the belt like this time she would strike Amy across the face.

Amy laughed and recoiled, putting up her hands to protect herself. "Fine, fine," she said, chuckling. She faced the camera and shook out her bob, fixing her face to an expression of mock empathy. "I'm sorry. I'm sorry, Josh," Amy said, her tone convincing. Then she smiled and cocked her head. "I'm a real bitch."

Devlin laughed, loving every minute of this. Kimmy turned to see him turning her phone to record his own cock, hard end huge, wagging between his legs. The first fist length shone with his pre-come, and a long sticky strand swung from the tip. "Can you fucking believe this, Josh? Can you fucking believe it? Look at these two. They're so fucking hot I can't stand it." He turned the camera to record his face. "You want to watch me fuck them?" He turned to the dresser and placed the phone on it, the camera angled toward the bed.

Now he faced Kimmy and Amy, sexual intent flaring in his eyes. "Poor Josh can't even imagine what happens when he's not around. We're going to show him." He turned to the camera, his manhood swinging, saying, "You can't even satisfy one of them, Josh. You can't satisfy your own wife. You're going to watch me fuck them both."

CHAPTER 22

ODYSSEY 17

Devlin joined them on the bed. Amy lay between them, Devlin on one side and Kimmy on the other. Devlin touched Kimmy's jacket lapel. "You're too well-dressed for this event."

She removed Devlin's hand from her jacket. "Clothes are the source of my authority."

Devlin chuckled, then turned his face down to regard Amy. "Don't you think she should get more comfortable?"

Amy said she thought so, head back on the mattress, admiring eyes moving over Kimmy. "I want to see your body."

"You know I never do what I'm told," Kimmy answered.

"The Kimmy I knew was complacent," Amy said, trying to keep pace with the struggle for control, trying to look as unbothered as she could, lying vulnerable on the bed. "She would do what someone wanted. Always eager to please."

"Now I'm the one who does the asking. Now I'm the one seeking compliance."

Devlin rumbled an appreciative chuckle in his chest, watching Kimmy. "You can punish, but can you pleasure? Do you have what it takes to *pleasure* a woman?" Amy snickered, eyes seeking out Kimmy's.

Yes, she had what it took to pleasure a woman—at least one woman.

She turned away from the recording camera on the dresser as though she were bashful. It was better to play dumb when challenged like this. Devlin's plan all along had been a threesome. It was his plan today, no matter how he framed it. And, maybe, this whole scheme had been planned against her at Tiffany's high school reunion party. It sure looked like Devlin and Amy had sought for this moment to present itself once again. And why not? There was no downside for them. No chance of loss. If Kimmy ran away again, they would laugh together at her cowardly constitution. If she agreed to the threesome, they would get what they wanted: the threesome. The best bullies lay nothing on the line. The best bullies played fixed games. The best bullies never exposed themselves to consequence.

Kimmy regarded Devlin, cocking her head. "You don't think I can?"

Devlin didn't answer and Amy said, "If you can't, he can show you. You're not afraid, are you?"

Kimmy didn't acknowledge Amy, eyes staying on Devlin's. "Why would I provide pleasure when all I'm here for is the punishment? . . . Unless pleasure was *your* plan all along."

"Both things can be true, Kimmy," Devlin said.

"Pain and pleasure. You're the ultimate hedonist."

Devlin drew in a slow breath and let it out. "You are, too."

Devlin's words chilled her. They arrived bearing more truth in the cargo hold than she had been prepared for. She looked down. Below her, Amy lay writhing in sexual anticipation. Amy's creamy tummy undulated, and that movement sent a daytime sunshine shimmer on the satin of the panties she wore. Josh's favorite panties.

Kimmy rested her palm on Amy's thigh, and Amy sighed with satisfaction. Devlin smiled. Kimmy said, "Is this what you wanted?"

"You're not timid Kimmy anymore," Devlin said.

Amy said, "She's not?" Her tone was chiding, instigating. A bully's tone.

Amy and Devlin had brought her here, thinking they were better than her, thinking they were in charge, that they were dominant.

Kimmy smiled and snuffled a small laugh. Her hand smoothed up Amy's thigh to touch Josh's favorite panties. Amy shivered and laughed, surprised by Kimmy's boldness. She even tightened her thighs together, protecting her sleazy pussy. Josh had worn these panties. Josh had sexualized them, turned them into some sort of magical talisman powered by his wife's sexual betrayal. He'd distilled the worst thing she'd done in her life into this dangerous but potent chemical. That chemical inebriated him; got him high as a kite. But like every potent poison, it came with a harsh payment. A side effect. Josh's sexualization of her betrayal was a coping mechanism. A survival skill. He'd converted her sin into kink because he loved and cherished her. He'd done it so they would stay together. It was so clear now.

The pads of her first three fingertips glided over the panty fabric, cresting the raised mound of Amy's pussy. A sudden fluttering of Amy's tummy delighted her. The pleasure her fingers delivered had hijacked Amy's bitter tongue; silenced her. No more bullying now. With her fingers on Amy's pussy, Amy was Kimmy's subject. And with Devlin's eyes on where her fingers traveled, Devlin was too. Devlin's huge cock throbbed. It hoisted out from between his legs, engorged to its fullest shape and size, the cock head a plump and excited helmet leaking a steady stream of lubricant onto the bedding.

Kimmy moved her fingers over Amy's panty-clad pussy in tentative, timid movements. Like Amy's pussy was the first pussy she'd ever touched. But she'd touched Hyun's pussy. And Hyun was ten times the woman Amy was. Hyun had a beautiful little thing between her legs. For her own sake, what she and Hyun had shared would forever be private. And while the camera filmed all of this, it would be recorded evidence showing Josh that his wife had never been with a woman before; that Amy's pussy was the

first and only pussy his wife had ever encountered that wasn't her own. If Amy was the first, then she had never been with Hyun. Hyun's privacy was sanctified. Hyun wasn't like Josh. Hyun was wholly different. Hyun couldn't bear sexual exposure.

If it weren't for Hyun, Kimmy would humiliate and dominate Amy right now. She would work between Amy's legs and overwhelm her two corruptors with surprising expertise. For now, she played the part of the curious ingenue.

Amy purred and moaned, and soon her hips were humping her pussy against Kimmy's touch. Her long fingers—two of them, stiff and held together—stroked up and down on the satin, sliding in the hot valley between Amy's fatty vulva. The panties grew damp under her touch. The more Amy's excitement soaked the panties, the more the panties power over Josh subsided. Amy poisoned them. Josh had been a pawn in a game, and as much as she hated to admit it, she was as well. This act would free Josh from his sexual burden, and maybe even restore them; Amy's poison would neutralize Kimmy's sin and show Josh his poor wife had been manipulated in order to manipulate him. Neutralization and revenge gleamed in the distance, and she headed to their bright spots on the horizon.

Kimmy teased Amy over the satin and Amy moaned and writhed. "Where had this Kimmy been hiding?"

"She was there the whole time," Devlin said.

"Laying in wait," Kimmy said, then batted the flat of four fingers against Amy's pussy. She squeaked a small grunt, then chuckled. Kimmy batted Amy's pussy again, harder this time, exchanging a knowing look with Devlin. She said to him, "Take her panties off."

Devlin sat up, curled fingers under the waistband of the panties she'd once worn, and then ran them down Amy's legs. Amy's hands slid between her thighs and covered her sex. Devlin tossed the panties away onto the floor by the dresser.

Kimmy curled her hand over the back of Amy's double-handed protective clutch. "Now that you have me where you wanted me, is it everything you imagined?"

Amy's eyes fluttered open, and she regarded Kimmy. "Me? You have me where you want me. Is it everything *you* imagined?"

Kimmy batted Amy's hands, chasing them away from her pussy. Amy removed them, her hands going down to the bedding at her sides. Amy kept her pussy shaved bald. It was puffy, the skin pale, her sexual membranes a deep cherry-pink. The labia shone wet. Devlin dared her to touch it. Kimmy balked as part of the act.

She said, "This isn't where I want you, Amy. You lured me here."

"You're here to punish me."

"I want to know why you lured me ten *years* ago. A kid. A messed up kid whose mother..."

"It was everything you needed," Amy said. "I was doing you a favor. I wasn't trying to hurt you, Kimmy."

"You hurt me."

Amy was insistent. "I wasn't trying to hurt you. I was *offering* you something. Something *good*."

"You laughed at me."

Amy shook her head, disbelieving. "Never."

Control slipped from her hand, and Kimmy felt the tearing at her edges, real emotion trying to get a grip on her corner and peel her up, tear away her coverage. She drew in a deep breath and looked at Devlin. "You didn't want me there."

Devlin's brow furrowed, his eyes studying her and assessing the situation. He said, "Amy always promised me you would have the tightest little pussy. She said I'd *break* it." A smile spread on his face, light gleaming in his cold eyes.

Kimmy turned her face to Amy. "You wanted me broken?"

Amy raised her eyebrows high above her sleepy, sultry eyes. "I knew you'd *love* to be broken. I knew you wanted it."

"But you were wrong."

Amy shrugged a naked shoulder, breasts jostling. "Because you ran? Maybe. In the end, I was right. Wouldn't you agree?"

Kimmy looked at Devlin. "Do you think you broke me?"

"Quite the opposite," Devlin said, looking at Kimmy but speaking to Amy. "Kimmy likes it. Kimmy likes it hard and deep. *Balls* deep. Your friend here can take *every* inch."

Amy assumed the mask of the unperturbed again, but Kimmy could read the displeasure in Amy's eyes. It sounded as though Devlin Stone liked Kimmy Chang more than he liked her. Amy would try now to belittle or diminish her in any way she could.

Kimmy smiled for Amy, provoking her; while she showed the smile, her eyes showed something else, something meant to intimidate. She stood up from the bed and adjusted her suit. Tall, standing in heels, clothed while her adversaries were bare and unwary. She was taller, stronger, smarter; more beautiful. And she pleased Devlin more. Amy shrank.

Kimmy said, "Amy's not the only guilty party in this room."

Devlin lay his hand on his muscular hairy chest, in the pose of the offended. "Me? My crime was giving you everything you ever dreamed of."

"You think you did nothing wrong?"

Devlin said, "I haven't been as bad as you."

Kimmy nodded, her mouth turning down in a grim curve. "I know my punishment will come, but for now, I *want* to play. And my game is punishment."

Devlin raised his eyebrows. "And who's going to punish you?"

"There's a long line of those who want to. And *will*. One thing at a time, though, Devlin."

Devlin cocked his head. "You think you're going to punish me?"

Kimmy ignored Devlin, addressing Amy, telling her to sit up. Amy sat up, her expression blank. Two naked people sitting on the bed, unsure. They were both capable and striking and powerful in their own way, but somehow they sat now like corrupted Adam and Eve in the Garden of Eden, contemplating wrath. Kimmy slipped a hand into her jacket pocket and produced something hidden in her fist. She held it before Amy and opened her fingers. "I want you to put this on him."

Amy studied the thing, a ball of black leather straps with stainless studs and snaps. Amy took it and opened it out, assessing what it was in its unfurled state. Kimmy said, "It goes on that massive cock of his."

Devlin smiled and Amy smiled too. With wrath averted, pleasure abounded.

Amy got onto the floor on her knees and Devlin lay back on his elbows, legs parted. With the cock harness in one hand, Amy lifted Devlin's huge organ upright, affixed the open mouth of the harness onto his shaft and smoothed it downward into place.

Kimmy said, "Make sure you gather his balls. One strap goes around his scrotum."

Amy looked over her shoulder at Kimmy, silent, then went back to work, gathering Devlin's oversized testicles into a palm, her other hand swinging a leather strap under his thick shaft, cinching his scrotum, pushing those extra-large eggs against the thin skin of his dark scrotum. She snapped the clasp and sat back on her heels waiting for further instruction. Devlin smiled, his huge horse cock lying back onto his belly now, his big balls squeezed by the harness into a plump brain shape.

"Now we have him where we want him," Kimmy said, smacking Devlin's leather belt across her palm.

CHAPTER 23

ODYSSEY 18

Amy circled her thumb and index finger around the wide base of Devlin's manhood at Kimmy's instruction. Devlin leaned back on the bed on his elbows, happy for his powerful sexuality to be the center of attention. Kimmy studied Amy and Devlin's movements, wondering how unfamiliar they were with each other. The chance that Devlin had slept with Amy while she and Devlin were together wasn't impossible. And while she had no reason to be jealous of Amy with Devlin, she couldn't help it. But the jealousy stemmed from Devlin's possible betrayal, not his infidelity. Devlin and she didn't use condoms. The unspoken agreement being they were both exclusive—bar, of course, Josh.

Amy toyed with Devlin's manhood familiarly, but they'd been together many times. It proved nothing. Amy lifted her grip on Devlin's scrotum, hoisting his big testicles up, then wagging them. Amy regarded Kimmy with sly intention. "What are we going to do to him?"

"You're both devils," Kimmy said.

Devlin laughed, adjusting his elbows on the bed and getting more comfortable. "We're all devils here," he said, eyes on his impressive organ and its black leather accoutrement.

Kimmy slapped the leather belt against the inside of Devlin's thigh.

Devlin clapped his legs together, eyes wide with fearful alarm.

Amy squawked and let go of Devlin's scrotum, half upright on her knees. She laughed at Devlin's plight.

Devlin wasn't amused. "Fucking watch it."

Kimmy said, "Pain and pleasure, Devlin. We're all devils here, remember?"

"That fucking hurt."

Kimmy said to Amy, "Hold his balls up again. Hold them steady for me." To show her intention, she slapped the belt across her palm once more.

Devlin said, "I'm warning you, you better not hit me."

"You don't trust me?"

"Go ahead and find out what happens."

"Are you threatening me?"

"The consequences of your actions aren't a threat. The future is in your hands."

Kimmy slapped the belt across her palm again. "Devlin the Philosopher."

"That's right," he said, looking up at her through his lowered brows. Amy's hand circled his scrotum again, his massive organ reclining on his muscular midsection, eager for action.

"Hold them up higher," Kimmy told Amy.

Amy complied, the look on Amy's face telling Kimmy that she enjoyed it, enjoyed the situation. Devlin on the defense, Devlin on his back with two women on top. Anything Kimmy did wouldn't be Amy's fault—Devlin couldn't blame her.

Kimmy said, "Pain and pleasure. Amy's into pleasure."

"And pain," Amy said.

"That's right. Aren't you a tormentor?"

"Only if it's fun."

Devlin said nothing, never taking his eyes off Kimmy and her vicious belt. A red, hazy welt grew redder on his muscular thigh.

“You don’t think I’ll hit them?”

“You want to,” Devlin said. “But you know what a bad idea that would be.”

Kimmy brought the belt down harder against Devlin’s thigh, striking almost the same spot. This time, Amy didn’t let go of Devlin’s scrotum. And while Devlin flinched and jumped, he didn’t complain or move away, gritting his teeth and snarling through it.

Kimmy smiled and held out the belt so the leather strap hung from her grip, dangling above Devlin’s scrotum. She danced the leather against his vulnerable testicles. “You don’t think I’d do it?”

Devlin’s expression didn’t brighten, didn’t soften with humor. “You’d do it if you could get away with it. You’d do it if you thought you could get out to the elevator before I caught you.”

She tilted up her chin. “How would you be able to run?”

Amy snickered. “How would you be able to run, Devlin?” She waggled his scrotum again.

Before he answered, Kimmy dropped the belt onto his testicles. Not hard enough to hurt, but enough to shock him. He grunted and his stomach muscles flexed, his big cock bouncing on them. He smiled at last, relief and the warm glow from his accurate prophecy of her resolve.

Kimmy said to Amy, “And now, show him some pleasure.”

Amy snickered again, lowered her mouth to her grip, then pressed her pooched lips against the plump plum of Devlin’s scrotum. She ran her tongue out and spread it over, working it around in wet circles, making Devlin’s eyes flutter.

Kimmy said, “Pain is nothing without pleasure. Wouldn’t you agree?”

“It’s a fine line,” Devlin said.

Kimmy flicked her wrist and snapped the belt, not striking Devlin, but making him jump to attention again.

Devlin said, “Your turn will come.”

“Promises, promises,” Kimmy said, then dangled the belt so the strap patted his testicles again. Still not hard enough to hurt, but enough to drive Devlin to the edge.

Kimmy laughed seeing his discomfort, and Amy laughed too.

Devlin said to Amy, “What’s so funny?”

Kimmy said, “You can dish it out, but you can’t take it.” She tossed the belt to the floor and put her hands on her hips in a pose like the one Devlin used when he felt at his most macho.

She said, “How long have you two been apart?”

Amy thumbed Devlin’s testicles, then kissed them. She said, “What do you mean?”

“Did you fuck over the summer?”

Amy looked puzzled, but she and Devlin shook their heads no.

“How long has it been?”

“A while,” they both said, out of sync.

Kimmy regarded Devlin. “Are you going to fuck her today?”

Devlin smiled, and Amy smiled too.

Kimmy said, “You planned on it, right?”

Devlin asked Amy, “What do you think?”

Amy smiled at Devlin, then said, “That’s up to Kimmy.”

Kimmy asked, “How bad do you want it, Amy?”

Amy said, “I want *you* in bed with us, Kimmy. That’s what I want.”

“What are you going to do to me?”

Amy said, “I want to see your body.”

Devlin said, “She’s not a kid anymore. She’s not that gawky teenager.”

“No, I’m not,” Kimmy said. “I’m nothing like I was.”

“I’ll say,” Amy said, eyes moving over Kimmy in devious admiration.

Kimmy shooed them with her hands, saying, “Get higher on the bed.”

Devlin scooted backwards on his elbows and Amy crawled on all fours until their heads were level with the pillows. Amy said, “What do you want

to see us do?”

“I want to see you kiss,” Kimmy said.

“Just the two of us?”

Kimmy slipped off her jacket and tossed it on a side table. She said, “Show me how you kiss.”

Devlin and Amy regarded each other, unsure but confident, wondering how this woman whom they’d led to the bedroom for this moment had the upper hand over them—but not caring. They didn’t care because they never faced consequences. They didn’t care because everything was a game to them; their father’s business; an imaginary business you wanted to develop on your own; the sanctity of other people’s marriages. Nothing mattered to them but their id—unbound by the framework of ego and superego. Just fledglings mewling for more and more perverse pleasure, their mother’s teats removed from their suckling mouths.

Amy and Devlin moved their faces closer, their eyes turning down, their lips parting. The sight of their soft mouths coming together and mushing together disgusted her. The sight was erotic, but sour and unsettling. Soft Amy, buxomer than Kimmy would ever be; Devlin, her summer lover, her betrayer and mutual conniver, hot and muscular, his oversized cock stiff and upright. Though there was much lubricious beauty, her stomach tightened and turned over. She’d almost *trusted* Devlin. Almost liked him a few times. There were even times she considered what a future with him would look like. Standing at the foot of the bed now, she’d never felt stupider. More deceived, more unseeing.

At least her eyes were open now.

While they kissed, she unbuttoned her shirt all the way and let it hang open. Amy and Devlin paused, looking into each other’s eyes. Something ignited between them. Seeing that shared connection burned in her heart, knowing she’d always just been a rube to them; a pawn, a geeky ingenue they could break. Amy had promised Devlin Kimmy as a sexual third

partner, guaranteed him her bookish friend would have the tightest pussy. They planned on delighting in Devlin hurting her.

Amy whispered, “Now what? What do you want to see next?” Devlin grinned next to her, his eyes flitting in the open section of her shirt. Amy saw it now too and reached out a hand, urging Kimmy to come closer.

Kimmy put one knee on the bed, just behind Amy, and Amy sat up, opening Kimmy’s shirt and admiring her skin. “You’re so sexy,” she whispered.

Amy’s hands went to Kimmy’s naked waist, and her fingers traced over her ribs and down the flat of her stomach, slipping a soft crescent underneath Kimmy’s navel.

Devlin reached around Amy to touch her stomach, too. But Devlin’s hand wanted to touch her lower. Only wanted to touch under her navel, the woolen front of her pants covering over where her baby grew. His eyes showed the liquid sheen of the mesmerized.

When Amy’s hands roamed higher, surrendering her reproductive terrain to Devlin, going up to touch her breasts through her bra, Kimmy took her chin and pushed her back so they could look into each other’s eyes. “I want to watch you suck his cock.”

Amy’s eyes widened. She liked to be told what to do in the bedroom. She was sick and twisted, but she didn’t dominate in the bedroom. She submitted.

Devlin liked the request, saying nothing, retreating to lie on his back again, in an expectant pose, legs open, flexing his stomach and whatever muscles operated his shaft, making it lift up and down as much as it could with its beefy weight. Amy rolled to her other side, facing Devlin, showing Kimmy her naked back and ass. Kimmy got both knees on the mattress.

Amy caressed the underside of Devlin’s huge shaft with her palm, up and down, then playing around the flared edges of his cock head with his

fingertips. Devlin watched. They all did. All three of them in the bed and centering their attention on Devlin's equine endowment.

Amy hefted it, and swirled her grip, squeezing out some of Devlin's pre-come. Then she pressed her lips to the tip of his cock and spewed saliva, putting her hand over it and polishing the end of Devlin's cock. Devlin's head lolled back with the pleasure of Amy's touch. Amy slow-stroked it, admiring his size in her hand, reacquainting herself with the size of her former lover. She sunk the head into her mouth and sucked and stroked, rolling her head around. Devlin groaned and his eyes went half-lidded.

Amy worked Devlin's cock well. She sucked and stroked, bobbed her head, taking a few thick inches into her mouth before backing off—before gagging. She was careful with Devlin's manhood. Almost reverential. She pleased Devlin for a long while before holding his massive cock upright, her base clamped around where the leather strap wrapped around his very base. His cock extended upright from her grip like a thick fleshy tower, shining with her spit. She said, "I want to watch her take this. I want to see it go inside her." She looked up at Devlin for approval. Amy didn't run the show. Devlin smiled, his eyes flicking to Kimmy's before returning to Amy.

"Kimmy doesn't want to fuck me anymore," he told Amy.

Amy looked confused, looking for clarification. Devlin chuckled and looked at Kimmy again. He sat up, his cock touching his sternum, Amy still gripping it. He reached over Amy to touch Kimmy's belly again.

Amy said, "She doesn't."

"No," Devlin said, smiling and looking up at Kimmy. She palmed Devlin's stubbly cheek.

Devlin said to Amy, "She thinks I'll hurt our baby."

CHAPTER 24

ODYSSEY 19

Amy's eyes widened with shock. Kimmy pushed Devlin's hand away, saying, "Lay back. Let me watch her suck it."

Devlin lay back, smiling the whole time, engrossed. Devlin was the entitled prince. Devlin had it all, and the two women in his room worshipped him. In Amy Devlin had an envoy, a manipulator, a strategic diplomat; in Kimmy he had a partner, a capable schemer, a mate—and the host of his seed. Two women who worked to make his dreams come true. In this moment, Devlin believed he had it all. And that he deserved it.

But Amy's expression showed disbelief still overwhelmed her, Amy wanting to know more but too flabbergasted to speak. Kimmy crossed to the other side of the bed on her knees, getting Devlin in between them. Amy watched, her eyes moving from Kimmy to Devlin, again and again. Kimmy told her once more to suck Devlin's cock.

Amy chuckled breathily, cheeks pink and cheerful. "What baby?" Amy's mask of superior slyness slipped, and behind swirled human weaknesses.

Kimmy disregarded the baby tangent, acting as though the bedroom's sexual act was the only thing concerning her. Devlin maintained silence, sneering. A shared secret between them was currency in Devlin and Amy's free-market anomie.

Amy was an indebted pauper now, eager to service the elite for a tossed coin. She purred and slunk against Devlin, eyes on Kimmy. She ran her nails down Devlin's hard chest, riding the pectoral swell, and rumbling over the ridges of his abs, reaching to caress his magnificent cock. "Is she teaching you fertility games?"

Kimmy raised her eyebrows but didn't smile, eyes still connected to Amy's.

Devlin said, "I think you're supposed to be sucking my cock."

Kimmy laughed, knowing Devlin would laugh along with her. Amy's eyes shone hot. Kimmy stopped laughing. "Show me how you suck it."

The cold insensitivity amused Devlin and had him laughing harder. "Come on, Amy," he said. "You heard her."

Devlin helped guide Amy down his body, but Kimmy reminded them she wanted to see them kiss. Devlin chuckled and took Amy by the back of her neck, pulling her close. They looked into each other's eyes, mutual antagonization simmering between them, something that might be common. They thrived on conflict and did their best fucking when they fought. Hating Devlin and fucking Devlin were synchronous elements. Something she'd learned herself this summer.

Amy and Devlin's mouths drew closer together. When they connected, it was with soft familiarity and hard, unresolved grievances. They rolled heads, sucked mouths, and bit lips. The connection changed something between them, and Amy melted to Devlin again, the stiffness in her attitude limbering. With his hands on her shoulders, Devlin guided Amy's kisses down his body, down to the heavy masculine pole heaped on his stomach like a basking seal. Amy caressed it, swirling her palm over its bloated shape.

"That's it," Kimmy said, as though satisfied, settling on her haunch next to Devlin, clothed, but her shirt unbuttoned and bloused open. "Show me."

Amy hefted Devlin's organ, the secretive baby talk still bothering her, but still putting on the sultry theater. She held Devlin's cock upright, eyeing it through heavy lids, stroking and squeezing in gentle pulses, watching the shiny tip swell with more and more lubricant that streamed down the shaft and into her grip until her strokes went smooth. Then she angled the monstrous tenderloin lower, pushing pouted lips against the tip and looking at Devlin. She sank his cock into her wet mouth. But Devlin was too large to suck. Amy did what she could with what fit. Devlin's head rocked back with pleasure.

Kimmy leaned her head on her shoulder and watched his face as Amy sucked his cock. That look of pleasure was one she'd provoked herself, and had raised her own esteem when provoking it. It seemed so small and distant now. Such a dumb thing to have found joy in.

Devlin's eyes fluttered, and he caught her watching him in his periphery, left-facing to regard her. He groaned and grumbled while Amy sucked. Sucked for long, dragging minutes slicked with the wet sounds of her mouth.

Devlin said low and rumbling, "You going to tell her?"

Amy kept sucking.

Kimmy smiled and didn't answer. Amy stopped to look at them both, using her hand to give her mouth a break for a minute.

"Tell her what?" Kimmy said. "Tell her how I will make your dirtiest dreams come true? How I'm going to deliver you gifts only gods receive?"

Devlin regarded her with scrutiny; at once seeking any detectable nuance in her hyperbole and also wallowing in her statement's perceived truth. Wanting to believe, but wary. And as Amy sucked the shining fat head of his massive cock again, Kimmy watched resolve wash from Devlin's eyes, replaced by an ecstatic flux that overwhelmed him. Amy cradled his huge cock in her palm and ran her pink tongue up and down the belly of his

manhood in wide, wet lines, her eyes up and watching the effect her tongue-pleasure had on her worshipped man.

Devlin growled and humped his hips, pushing his mighty pole up through Amy's grip, swelling and flexing his weapon. Amy kissed it and stroked it, letting him hump it up and down, Devlin admiring his own size, admiring how big his cock looked in Amy's small feminine grip, how big and dark it looked against her pale face. He breathed heavily for a moment, an almost pre-orgasmic panting. Then he said, "Let me tell her."

"I don't think I'll be able to stop you."

Devlin gasped as Amy did something wonderful with her tongue. "You, mm, don't want me to?"

"You can't keep a secret?"

"Of course I can," he said, biting his lower lip as Amy stroked two hands on his shaft, the head of his cock getting sucked hard.

Kimmy produced from her jacket pocket the last remaining toy liberated from Devlin's drawer and spun the toy's base to get it vibrating.

At the obvious sound, Devlin turned to witness the thing they'd discovered he enjoyed. He snickered, eyes narrowing. Kimmy dug the point of the plain-white vibrator into the hard edges of muscle on the inside of Devlin's hipbone, easing the thing along in the direction of his cock. He humped against the provocative vibration. Amy took her mouth from Devlin's cock and only stroked him, watching Kimmy draw lines near Devlin's pubic pad with the dull vibrator nose. She smiled at Devlin, communicating to him she would use the vibrator the way he liked.

Devlin said, "Only if I can tell her."

"You're going to tell her, so do it. Tell her."

Devlin smiled a mean, lopsided smile. He'd never looked more devious. How chin touched his collarbone as he looked at Amy laying on his thighs, breasts squashed, his dick in her hand. Devlin, upbeat and happy for the theatrical effect, said, "Kimmy's carrying my baby."

The statement was what Amy believed he'd meant—now that it was confirmed, she didn't know which way she would react. Her expression passed through a series of tremulous changes; some showed anger, some meanness, but what looked most honest was the look of fear Kimmy saw.

Amy smiled and raised her brows. "What?"

Kimmy buzzed the nose of the vibrator lower, nudging the side of Devlin's hanging scrotum. Devlin reacted with warm moaning. She lifted one testicle, looking up to see Amy watching her face. Kimmy turned off the vibrator and dropped it by Devlin's thigh, sitting back on her haunch. Amy asked if it was true.

Kimmy looked at Devlin with ardor, a glowing look of the mother-to-be. Devlin chuckled. "It is," he said, and reached his hand inside Kimmy's shirt to stroke his knuckles across the tight surface of her barely bubbled tummy. "It's true."

Kimmy put her hand over Devlin's. "It's true. Josh is going to raise our baby."

Amy scowled, trying to stay in character, but this revelation so huge and powerful her foundation shook. "What do you mean? Are you serious?"

"Devlin and I have more than a few things on the go," Kimmy said, sharing a look with Devlin.

"Yeah, we do," Devlin agreed.

Kimmy told Amy to straddle Devlin. "I want to watch you fuck."

Devlin chuckled—a sound of masculine satisfaction; but more than that, it was the sound of a man who couldn't believe the capabilities of the exotic creature at his side, like he'd transformed her into this incredible thing capable of unending treachery and sexual play. The sound of a man who believed what happened here today in his bedroom was only the beginning of a long, licentious journey.

Amy hadn't looked away from Kimmy. "You're pregnant?"

“Josh is going to raise my baby,” Devlin said, handling Amy’s wrists, trying to get her to climb onto his lap. Amy was sluggish, but got to her knees and over Devlin’s thighs. The news had dumbfounded her, threatened her with obsolescence.

Amy said, “On purpose? Did you get pregnant on purpose?”

Kimmy didn’t answer, only smiled and raised her chin, waiting for Amy to straddle Devlin properly so she could show off how she and Devlin fucked.

Amy said to Devlin, “Did you know? Know she could get pregnant?” Amy sought to sow the seeds of doubt, plant in Devlin the idea that Kimmy had tricked him into paternity. Kimmy smiled wider.

Devlin wasn’t in the mood for questions. He had a huge sexual appetite that needed satiation. With his hands on her upper forearms, he guided Amy to climb onto his hips, her breasts swaying, her expression bewildered. Devlin slipped his hand underneath Amy, knuckles creasing her pussy, taking a hold of his beefy member and batting it on her ass, guiding her to ease forward to give him room to sink his cock inside her. The ease with which he transitioned from a monogamous yet illicit lover to prurient hedonist was striking. All Kimmy had to do was present an unhindered path to libertine indulgence and Devlin surged ahead, unquestioning.

Amy reached behind to do the honor, raising her butt up, leaning forward on her knees, face over Devlin’s. Devlin brought his hand away, letting Amy do the work, situating the end of his cock where she liked it before easing back. Amy’s expression pinched tighter at the stretching of Devlin’s size.

Devlin said, “Glenn hates it when I fuck you, doesn’t he?”

“He gets so mad,” Amy gasped. She snickered and winced, taking her time to acclimate to Devlin’s intrusion. “It’s been awhile.”

“You miss it.”

“Of course I do,” Amy sighed, easing to sit back further, accommodating more of Devlin’s huge cock.

Kimmy slipped off the side of the bed, stalked to the foot, disgusted at the sight. Amy’s sexual membranes clinging for dear life to Devlin’s threatening girth. Devlin’s sagging balls, Amy’s rosy-brown anus. It was the erotic distilled to the benign biological foundation. Ugly and necessary. She found the white vibrator in the sheets on the outside of Devlin’s thigh and thumbed the screw-bottom to get it humming. She nosed Devlin’s balls again, watched them recoil and roll, watched him shove his cock higher, Amy yipping at the intrusion, then muttering profanities. Kimmy lifted Devlin’s sack and teased the end of the vibrator lower. Devlin brought his knees up, feet coming onto the mattress. Devlin liked the toy. Devlin liked it when she made him wear her underwear and jerked him off and played the vibrator in and out of his ass. He’d blasted a liter of semen all over the mirror the last time.

The tip of the vibrator found some give at last between his cheeks, and she eased it into Devlin’s anus. Devlin’s thighs trembled and his sack tightened up into a tight pouch. One of his balls went inside his body. He groaned. Amy gasped.

Kimmy left it inside Devlin, rose and stepped aside. “Get on top of her.”

Devlin was fully engaged, all his cylinders firing, the turbo kicking in, rolling with Amy on him, getting on top of her missionary style with the white base of the vibrator showing out of his ass cheeks. Kimmy buttoned her shirt.

Devlin eased his huge cock in and out of Amy and Amy squealed with discomfort slowly becoming ecstasy.

Kimmy moved to the dresser where Devlin set her phone, recording every second of this lurid cinema. She reclaimed her phone, turned it to get a good shot of the action, then slipped it into her pocket.

Devlin stopped her as she opened the bedroom door. “Where are you going?”

She looked back, Devlin on top of Amy, hands at her shoulders, up on his outstretched arms, Amy with her legs wrapping Devlin’s thighs. “I have to get home,” she said. Devlin’s expression was blank, yet uncertain.

Kimmy paused at the door, holding it, one foot out. She dipped her chin, like she was in thought. “I think . . . I think Josh tried to kill himself this weekend.” Then she smiled a humorless smile, a smile of hopeless resignation.

Devlin shook his head like nothing she said made sense. Amy chuckled—as humorless as Kimmy’s smile, faltering and unsure. Kimmy said, “Yeah, I’m pretty sure.”

Devlin said, “What are you talking about?”

“You two are pathetic. Pathetic children. You should see yourselves. See how dumb you look. Two sick piggies wallowing in your own muck.”

Devlin couldn’t make sense of her change, frowning. “What are you doing?”

“I told you. I’m going home.” She stepped forward, then stepped back, hand below her navel. She said, “And if you think this baby is yours, you’re even dumber than I thought.”

CHAPTER 25

ODYSSEY 20

The world around her seemed nothing like the world she'd escaped. Out here in the daylight, the general population walked and talked and laughed, up and down the sidewalks, in and out of shops, across walkways; cars on a million errands, trucks delivering, and school out at three-thirty, kids up and down, young ones, older ones up to petty no-good. The school bus stopped in front of her again, red stop sign flapping out, lights flashing. Then a gaggle of little people in coats disembarked, laden with books and bags and school projects, rushing to their waiting guardians, ready to be shuttled to warm homes.

It was all behind her now. The bridge burned. She'd thought she could eke out more time, play along until she was better situated. But no more. Not when she saw herself reflected in the amoral theater playing out in Devlin's apartment this afternoon. Any play actor with a soul should be ashamed to take a bow. No accolades were warranted, only chagrin. The time for stratagems and expedients evaporated. But to call what she'd done a moral turn would be laughable.

And yet . . . Maybe it was. Or at least a turning point. She could play it as moral.

As the bus's stop sign flapped closed and the lights shut off, the bus burping out a plume of black smoke and lurching up to speed once again,

Kimmy swiped through the contacts in her phone, found the number for Aaron Berg, Esquire.

The day had shown him unexpected kindness. He'd thought he'd face scorn or avoidance at work today; that he would see a lot of people at Swanson avert their eyes when they saw him coming, pretend they didn't even see him. Then they'd whisper behind his back after he'd passed. But that wasn't what happened. Gabrielle and Samara and Steve were the only sources of the weekend's event which his workplace would get access to. And it would seem like his three friends—intentionally or naturally—had a much better perspective on the weekend than he did. No one knew the blackness growing in his chest; no one knew the extreme and bottomless evil of his wife's infernal torments. No one knew he'd watched his high school bully fuck her. No one knew his wife had held up her boss's massive dick against his mere mortal dick. And that his wife got off on it. What people had heard through the grace of Steve and Samara and Gabrielle: Josh got wasted and fell off the dock. They'd had to call an ambulance, and he'd even had to fly by helicopter to Peterborough. Hypothermia. It had been bad. And yet, Josh came to work on Monday like nothing happened. Some at work, he considered, might even think Josh Waters was kind of a crazy badass.

But now here he was back at home, alone in the apartment, the surprise and relief of the day's good treatment already beginning to fade. Kimmy should be home, but she wasn't. That could mean Kimmy was held up at work, or it could mean she had her legs in the air and Devlin fucked her deep with that massive dick Kimmy loved. Kimmy didn't hang with the mortals anymore. Mere mortals didn't do it for her.

Yet the power Kimmy had over him had eased its grip somehow. He'd heaped so much value on their relationship that the idea of loss or failure

would always break his heart and fill him with dread, furrow his brow. In the weekend's aftermath, numbness occluded all those sharp feelings of loss. And yet, here he was, in his apartment, the home he shared with his wife, and the simple observation she wasn't home came to him with an immovable payload. The depth of her betrayal no longer hurt, but it still burdened him.

Tonight, they would talk. Talk for real.

Kimmy wasn't getting away with her crimes anymore. There were no equivocations or excuses he would consider. Their relationship would rattle back onto their shaky track. If it didn't, he had the newfound fortitude to leave for good. What she'd done for herself—and told him she did for him—held no value in their relationship. No promises of a house were worth what she'd done. And filling that house with babies he could doubt were his own? Untenable. How could he have ever permitted this slide into madness?

He slipped his tie out of his collar and walked to the family room, turned on the TV, and then went to the window. His heart sank, and the dread flashed on his dashboard like sudden engine trouble. His stomach ached and his balls ached. Kimmy was home, long leg stretching out of her open car door, setting a heel down on the asphalt.

"Come on, Josh," he said to himself. "You have to do this."

She found Josh waiting for her in their kitchen. Just home, obviously, wearing a suit, tie off, collar open, shoes still on. They didn't speak while she slipped off her shoes in the foyer, then stepped into the kitchen. They were face to face, neither of them smiling. A tension enriched the air between them; a heavy, unbroken silence waiting for the crack of a gunshot that would make them both jump.

She said, "How are you feeling?"

"Pretty good."

"How was work?"

"Better than I expected."

She nodded. She asked him about Gabrielle and Samara and Steve and what they said and Josh told her they were all laughing about it, like what had happened on the weekend to him was no big deal. The relief Josh found in their laughter hurt her heart. He'd almost died, and the bright side was no one knew the depths of his despair. Maybe not even Josh himself. Josh's bright side was that his wife's torture and betrayal went still undiscovered. Josh held shame's mighty weight on his shoulders like an impossible burden. She was the one who shamed him.

Kimmy looked as beautiful as ever. But tired. Worn out. Her eyes were heavy and shone only dully; her shoulders drooped. He felt no sympathy. Actually, maybe even enjoyed a certain victory. Hoping it was all the bad she'd done coming home to accumulate in her psyche. This beautiful woman's husband had almost died on the weekend and it was all her fault. Wasn't it? Maybe Kimmy deserved the weight of that blame, even if the facts weren't supportive. He asked her how her day at work was, the question heavy with the summer's torture and his wife's refusal to quit the job that put her side by side with Devlin Stone.

"Not good," she said with a strange uplifting tone.

All he could do was nod. He didn't even care how her day went. Good, bad—neither mattered. All that mattered was she went to work when she knew she shouldn't. She couldn't stop her Devlin addiction and if her husband's ordeal with death's whisper this weekend couldn't stop her, then nothing would. "That's a shame," he said, silently cursing his own petty,

juvenile response. There were more masculine responses, but they escaped him at the moment. The urge to lash out was strong.

Kimmy had no retort, no snide comeback. She just turned aside and put her hands on the counter, hanging her head. “Can I make us some dinner?”

“That always makes things better, doesn’t it?”

Kimmy knew what he meant. If she had no snide comebacks, she shouldn’t worry. He had dozens.

“I’m not trying to buy your affection, Josh. I just think we need to sit down and talk.”

A cold dread formed on the heels of her statement. It had the chill of finality. But it was he who’d been pushed to the brink, not her. “Now you want to talk? All summer that’s what I wanted, but everything you said was just an excuse you could use to put me in a holding pattern. Make me sit on my hands and take it. Take all the shit you heaped on my lap and told me I liked. And now you want to talk?”

Kimmy shook her head. Not with anger, but with some sad resignation. “We talked, Josh. We talked. You can’t say we didn’t.”

“I heard you talk. You never heard me talk.”

“I listened to every word you said.”

“And then disregarded them.”

Kimmy faced him. The same height, eye to eye. No eyes down on him like when she wore heels. Her eyes were lifeless. “If you want to unload on me finally, if you’re ready to get your satisfaction, today is your lucky day. I’m your punching bag, Josh.” She opened her arms to the side, showing him she was defenseless. “Beat the shit out of me. Tell me every thing I did wrong. Blame me. Curse me. Call me all the names you’ve bitten your tongue on.”

Anger sizzled in his ears. His wife was an oiled viper. She never gave him a foothold, never left an opening for him to catch her. Just when he was sane enough to settle the score, she yanked the plug and now his tub was

draining. “How do you do it? How do you pull the rug out from under me every single time?”

“Go ahead, Josh. I’m telling you, today is the day.”

“I’m not doing that. I’m not going to give you what you want.”

“You know I deserve it.”

“Yeah, you do,” he said, hands stilling at his sides. For a moment, he’d thought he would get to enjoy an angry explosion.

They stared at each other, not saying anything. He’d never felt more separate from her in his life. He felt closer to her when they were on their first date. There was a chasm between them, deep as her sins.

Kimmy said, “Can I touch you?”

He said, “Why?”

“Because I want to.”

He squinted and frowned, trying to decipher her plan. “Yeah. Fine. You can touch me.”

Kimmy’s cheeks dimpled and her eyes grew troubled. She paused, then lifted her hands to his face, cupping his jawline, thumbing the corners of his mouth. It felt awkward, but he let her, and after a while, he warmed to her touch.

She said, “Did you go in the water on purpose?”

He brushed her hands away, grunting and pulling back. “No, I didn’t.”

“Tell me the truth.”

“You want to know the truth? You want to hear it? I woke up in the bunkie and I thought I’d told them the truth. Told all the people at the party what *you* did. What you made *me* do.” His jaw clenched hard, his brow lowering, feeling the red heat of emotion coursing through his veins. When he spoke, he jabbed his chin toward her, saying, “I told you this, Kimmy. I thought I got so drunk I told them the *real* truth. The *real* reason they had to throw me a party. That’s why, Kimmy. I thought I told them the *truth*. And the truth is so bad I wanted to run away.”

Kimmy's eyes welled with tears and the sight of genuine emotion from her surprised him. Her chin dimpled and her lips wriggled. And she didn't look away. Forced herself to keep her eyes on his. A sudden softness formed around his heart. Like he'd gotten through to her. Like she'd joined a cult and abandoned her family, but this was the first sign the deprogramming could work. Like the woman he loved was still in there somewhere.

"I didn't go in the water on purpose," he said. "It would be great if you believed that I did. That would make things *so* much easier for me. Because you don't seem to realize your actions have consequences. But they do, Kimmy. I didn't go in the water on purpose, but I ran from your *lies*. I ran from your *crimes*. I ran because the shame I would feel if my friends *knew*?—now *that* would kill me. That would *really* kill me. I ran and ran until there was no more dock. Okay?"

Kimmy looked down, sighing, shaking her head. She looked up again, up past him, somewhere near the ceiling. "I thought I could do it. I thought I could do anything. But I can't. I'm not that person."

"Do what?"

"*Win*. Win everything. Clear the table and bring us victory."

"Us?" *Yeah, right.*

"I was tired, Josh. Tired of the struggle. Tired facing the time it would take us to achieve our dreams. I wanted a shortcut. I wanted everything now. And it was there. Right there in front of me."

"That's such bullshit. You wanted Devlin."

Kimmy stepped back, lips pursed, eyes wounded. "That's not true."

"You know it is, Kimmy. You went after Devlin at Tiffany's and you know it. You fought with him because it turned you on. *He* turned you on. He's everything I'm not, and I'm not enough for you."

"You want that to be true."

"What?" He laughed at how ridiculous her statement was. "Who would want that to be true?"

“You do. You want to think it because it turned you on.”

“Don’t,” he warned her. “Don’t do that.”

She realized the seriousness of his expression and looked away.

He said, “Tell me one reason I shouldn’t leave again.”

Kimmy looked up, eyes wet. “Because I’m the one who’s leaving.”

CHAPTER 26

ODYSSEY 21

In a long moment of silence after Kimmy's proclamation, he struggled to frame meaning in her words. And in that long, dreadful moment, the look in Kimmy's eyes showed there was no other interpretation than that she was going to leave him. Her lips trembled, her eyes shone with wet emotion. She looked weak. Frail. A cavalcade of retorts raced through his mind like the arrow clicking on a game spinner. Outrage was obvious. *How dare you.* But weakness of his own was there, too. Crumpling. Finally, at very long last, he could surrender to the burden of her sin and torture, and collapse on their kitchen floor in a sobbing heap, occasionally opening his eyes to verify her pretty, stocking feet were still there, and she still bore witness to the alchemical result of her nefarious and mythical experimentations. But in the middle of the spinner's selections, the choices between the polar extremes, were a gamut of dull responses hard to decipher from one another. When he'd found her underwear in Devlin's couch and fled to Rome, what struck him most was the vague, shapeless form of his realized suffering. That cottony buffer that had maybe protected him from the extremes; ones where he would either swan dive from the spire atop St. Peter's Basilica or cave his beloved's cheating head in with the back side of a claw hammer. When the first in a series of marital detonations went off, his mind protected him from harm, shutting down his reactions, putting him

into a hibernation for his own safety. So while he could collapse, it wasn't impossible he would explode in red rage and trash their apartment and throw all of her belongings out the windows.

He said, "You're leaving? You? *You're* leaving?" The clarifier. That's what the arrow had settled on; the response of the tepid administrator who wanted the wretch to repeat their own words so that they were heard better, the hope being in a well-concentrated reconsideration, nothing more would need to be said. Kimmy leaving was a ludicrous option, and once she said it aloud once more, she would recognize the error in her ways and amend them. Maybe when she repeated that she was leaving, they would both look at each other and smirk and acknowledge how dumb that was.

But his voice was weak and crackly and not at all the sort of masculine foreboding he wished he conjured naturally. *Why was he always the voice of reason?*

All she said was, "I have to," her voice soft, almost breathless, that sadness still in her eyes.

He laughed and threw up his hands. A man surprised such a cruel world had more impossible punishment ready to heap upon him. He jabbed a finger at her. "I could have done that. It would have been so easy. Leaving. But *you* do it? You're going to leave *me*? You rob me of my pride and my chance at justice?"

Kimmy shook her head, eyes pleading. "I can't hurt you anymore and I don't deserve your compassion. I don't deserve your support."

He frowned, he grunted, he suffered more. "You can't hurt me anymore? You don't deserve my support? You're my wife. We had a wedding. You were there. I was there. Kimmy, we're married. That means something, that—" He stopped talking and his heart sunk. His mouth closed, and he put a hand on his chest. "Oh no," he sighed.

She asked him what, like she was genuinely curious.

“The baby,” he said, his voice sounding a mile away. “You know it’s not . . . You don’t deserve my support? You know it’s not mine.”

She closed her eyes and fell toward him, trying to put her arms around his waist. He held her at bay, pushing her back and stepping toward the counter.

Kimmy retreated, features twisted in emotional hurt, and he hated how he liked it. Her hands came together over her stomach. “Don’t say *the* baby. It’s *our* baby. It’s *your* baby.”

Now he turned away from her and braced his weight with hands laid out on the counter. “I’ll never know.”

She said, “You’ll know.”

He admired the patterns on the counter surface, the splotches in the marble. He said, “Then why would you leave me after all you put me through?”

“I’m not leaving you, Josh. I’m leaving the apartment. You’ve fled, and you never should have—because I’m the one who’s wrong.”

He stood up again, lightheaded, leaning his butt on the counter and folding his arms. “Where are you going to go?”

“I’ll find a place.”

“Hyun’s?”

Kimmy looked down and shook her head. “I don’t think so.”

“You gotta be kidding me,” he said.

Kimmy looked up. “What?”

“Where are you staying? *Oh, I don’t know.* You *know* where you’re staying.” *Devlin’s.*

“I really don’t, Josh,” she said. “Don’t accuse me of that.”

“Don’t accuse you of that?” He scoffed, finding sudden and gratifying amusement in her ridiculous statement. “After everything you did, I shouldn’t accuse you of the fucking obvious? Is it so crazy? Where are you going to stay?”

“It’s not what you’re thinking, Josh. Not that at all. I don’t know where I’ll stay. I’ll figure it out.”

It puzzled him. None of this was expected. All of it was so strange. He said, “Just quit. Just quit, Kimmy. You don’t have to go anywhere. Quit and we can start over.”

“I did quit, Josh. I told you to let me handle this the way I needed to, but don’t worry, today I quit the brokerage.

There was something in the way she said *Don’t worry* that he didn’t like. An insinuation. “I wrecked it. I wrecked your plan, is that it?”

“No, Josh. You did everything right, I did everything wrong.”

“Are you patronizing me?”

“No, I’m not.”

“You told me to let you handle it your own way, you had a plan, but then . . . Then what? What’s the insinuation? You had a plan you never told me and I wrecked it by what? Falling into the lake? Is that it?”

A tear rolled her cheek, and it surprised him. One long finger wiped it away like light rain on a windshield. She sniffled and raised her chin. Another tear was imminent. “I don’t deserve you, Josh. I don’t want to hurt you anymore. I never wanted to hurt you. Not for real. But everything I did ended up destroying who you are.”

Another bloated moment of silence, batted with emotion and dread over what they would say next. All day he’d been chuffed, pampered by the unexpected care of his co-workers. More than once he’d heard the insinuation that Josh Waters might be on the market. And, boy, he’d surfed that wave in his mind, daydreaming at his desk, seeing himself with some of the girls he knew. Going on dates, showing a new woman all the good things about himself and imagining their cooing and positive reception. He’d thought about sex, too. Thought about bedding one or two, imagined getting his cock sucked. Every time he thought that way, it would soon turn to Kimmy. Wanting Kimmy to see it. Wanting Kimmy to witness how he

could move on, how he wasn't the little thing she treated poorly. He could be a Devlin to another woman. And he wanted Kimmy to see it. To hurt seeing it. Now all that strangely sprung confidence seemed watery and useless. Lies. Fantasies. Facing the cold reality of a separation from his wife, he felt no more reinforcement from those fantasies. Nope. He felt scared.

"Fuck," he whispered as a tear fell on his own cheek. Tears came easier to him than to Kimmy. He wiped it away. "Don't go," he said. She said she had to and wiped the second tear from her cheek.

Now he was offended. He'd offered her reprieve, offered her a chance to breathe and reconsider and she was adamant she must leave. He asked her again where she was going to stay.

She didn't answer. He watched her elegant hands hanging at her sides form fists and wiggle fingers, nervous tension acting like she had leaned on her elbows too long and her hands fell asleep. She said, "Not with him, Josh. Never again."

Devlin had hurt her. He'd fired her today. He'd humiliated her. He'd punished her the way her husband should have. *Good.*

"It's over. All of it is over."

"Then stay. We'll make dinner. You can tell me."

She shook her head no and the rejection angered him. "Why not? Why do you do this to me? Why do you have to hurt me? Every day it's something new. Now you're gone from the brokerage, the thing I wanted, the thing I asked you to do a hundred times, and you're like, you're not going to come back to me. You're addicted to punishing me. What the hell did I ever do to you?"

She rolled her head aside and looked up, another tear rolling her cheek—and now he was convinced they were fake tears and she was making sure he saw them. He said, "Did he fire you?"

Kimmy huffed an amused sound and rolled her eyes. "No."

“You quit?”

She widened her eyes, gazing aside and down, like in an act of remembering. “I burned the bridge down behind me.”

More silence. More staring and saying nothing. “Stay. Stay and tell me what happened.”

She shook her head no again and made like she would leave.

“Don’t fucking go, Kimmy. Don’t walk away from me. You wanted to cook me dinner and now you get me to agree, get me to soften, and you’re going to turn your back on me?”

She turned to regard him again. Fear shimmered in her dark eyes. She opened her mouth to speak but couldn’t form words.

He said, “Don’t you dare leave.”

Her mouth closed. She shook her head for the tenth time. “I have to go. I have to.” She turned again and went to the foyer. He followed. When she tried to put a foot in her high heel shoe, he grabbed her upper arm and pushed her to the door. No words. Face to face. Kimmy wouldn’t meet his eye. The tears were flowing now. He let her arm go.

“You’re the cruelest person I know. I’ve never met anyone worse than you.”

Kimmy cupped shaking hands around her mouth and nose and breathed into them. She put that foot into that shoe and this time he didn’t stop her. She put the other foot in the other shoe and now she was taller than him. Beautiful, stunning. But broken. Twisted, broken, ashamed. Afraid.

She lifted the hands from her face, fingers trembling like he’d never seen someone tremble before. Her hand cupped his cheeks, warm, tender. She looked into his eyes. A tremendous effort was under way for her to not break down. The trauma was obvious.

He said, “What happened?”

She cocked her head, showed him the weakest smile, and whimpered in her throat. “I started something I can’t stop, Josh. And now it’s out of

control. I don't want you to get run over. You're the kind of man who'd step in the way to save me, and I don't want that. I want to burn all by myself."

Before he could respond, she kissed him. The kiss was magnificent and filled his heart with surprise and passion. But he could never ever experience it the same way after all she'd done to him. Her love came barbed with hurt.

He pushed her back. "Don't you dare leave," he said.

She turned. She showed him her back. Opened the door, didn't look over her shoulder. Walked down the hall to the elevator.

Fuck her.

He wouldn't give her the pleasure of calling after her. Wouldn't submit to her anymore. Not ever again.

"Leave," he muttered and slammed the door. "Bitch."

But with the door closed, it was over. The urge came on strong to fling it open again and chase down the hall, grab Kimmy at the elevator and kiss her, bring her back to the apartment and tell her they would make it all work. But why? For more pain? More rejection? How many times would she have to kick him in the balls before he'd leave her alone?

Instead he turned and laid his back on the door, like bracing it in case she returned, crashing barbarians at the gate, armored in beauty and wielding the deadliest blades of torment, eager to force their way in and sate their steel with his pain. He slid down to sit on the floor, staring up at the photo Kimmy's father took when he was a married man with a wife and two daughters, traveling back to his homeland. Happy. Together. But all good things come to an end.

He covered his face and cried as quiet as he could.

AFTERWORD

The 15th book is already under way on my [Patreon](#) and on my [Ream](#) and will be available in the stores right after the last chapter has been posted.

ktmorrison.com

On my [Patreon](#) and on my [Ream](#) you can have access to chapters as they are written, and see artwork from the KT universe of stories—even NSFW ones!

ABOUT THE AUTHOR

KT Morrison writes stories about women who fall in love with sexy men who aren't their husband, and loving relationships that go too far—couples who open a mysterious door, then struggle to get it closed as trouble pushes through the threshold.

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